

Existentialism

A brief introduction

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Chapter 1

Existentialism

“Existential” redirects here. For the logical sense of the term, see [Existential quantification](#). For other uses, see [Existence \(disambiguation\)](#).

Not to be confused with [Essentialism](#).

Existentialism (/ˈɛɡzɪˈstɛnʃəlɪzəm/)^[1] is a term ap-



Clockwise from top left: Kierkegaard, Dostoyevsky, Sartre, Nietzsche

plied to the work of certain late-19th- and 20th-century European philosophers who, despite profound doctrinal differences,^[2]^[3]^[4] shared the belief that philosophical thinking begins with the human subject—not merely the thinking subject, but the acting, feeling, living human individual.^[5] While the predominant value of existentialist thought is commonly acknowledged to be freedom, its primary virtue is authenticity.^[6] In the view of the exis-

tentialist, the individual's starting point is characterized by what has been called “the existential attitude”, or a sense of disorientation, confusion, or dread in the face of an apparently meaningless or [absurd](#) world.^[7] Many existentialists have also regarded traditional systematic or academic philosophies, in both style and content, as too abstract and remote from concrete human experience.^[8]^[9]

[Søren Kierkegaard](#) is generally considered to have been the first existentialist philosopher,^[2]^[10]^[11] though he did not use the term existentialism.^[12] He proposed that each individual—not society or religion—is solely responsible for giving [meaning](#) to life and living it passionately and sincerely, or “authentically”.^[13]^[14] Existentialism became popular in the years following [World War II](#), and strongly influenced many disciplines besides [philosophy](#), including theology, drama, art, literature, and psychology.^[15]

1.1 Definitional issues and background

The term is often seen as a historical convenience as it was first applied to many philosophers in hindsight, long after they had died. In fact, while existentialism is generally considered to have originated with Kierkegaard, the first prominent existentialist philosopher to adopt the term as a self-description was [Jean-Paul Sartre](#). Sartre posits the idea that “what all existentialists have in common is the fundamental doctrine that [existence precedes essence](#)”, as scholar [Frederick Copleston](#) explains.^[16] According to philosopher [Steven Crowell](#), defining existentialism has been relatively difficult, and he argues that it is better [understood](#) as a general approach used to reject certain systematic philosophies rather than as a systematic philosophy itself.^[2] Sartre himself, in a lecture delivered in 1945, described existentialism as “the attempt to draw all the consequences from a position of consistent atheism”.^[17]

Although many outside Scandinavia consider the term exis-

tentialism to have originated from Kierkegaard himself, it is more likely that Kierkegaard adopted this term (or at least the term “existential” as a description of his philosophy) from the Norwegian poet and literary critic *Johan Sebastian Cammermeyer Welhaven*.^{*[18]} This assertion comes from two sources. The Norwegian philosopher Erik Lundestad refers to the Danish philosopher Fredrik Christian Sibbern. Sibbern is supposed to have had two conversations in 1841, the first with Welhaven and the second with Kierkegaard. It is in the first conversation that it is believed that Welhaven came up with “a word that he said covered a certain thinking, which had a close and positive attitude to life, a relationship he described as existential” .^{*[19]} This was then brought to Kierkegaard by Sibbern.

The second claim comes from the Norwegian historian *Rune Slagstad*, who claims to prove that Kierkegaard himself said the term “existential” was borrowed from the poet. He strongly believes that it was Kierkegaard himself who said that “*Hegelians* do not study philosophy 'existentially'; to use a phrase by Welhaven from one time when I spoke with him about philosophy” .^{*[20]} On the other hand, the Norwegian historian *Anne-Lise Seip* is critical of Slagstad, and believes the statement in fact stems from the Norwegian literary historian *Cathrinus Bang*.^{*[21]}

stract form that also must inevitably run into trouble whenever it is to be applied to the concrete. To the same degree as the subjective thinker is concrete, to the same degree his form must also be concretely dialectical. But just as he himself is not a poet, not an ethicist, not a dialectician, so also his form is none of these directly. His form must first and last be related to existence, and in this regard he must have at his disposal the poetic, the ethical, the dialectical, the religious. Subordinate character, setting, etc., which belong to the well balanced character of the esthetic production, are in themselves breadth; the subjective thinker has only one setting—existence—and has nothing to do with localities and such things. The setting is not the fairyland of the imagination, where poetry produces consummation, nor is the setting laid in England, and historical accuracy is not a concern. The setting is inwardness in existing as a human being; the concretion is the relation of the existence-categories to one another. Historical accuracy and historical actuality are breadth.” Søren Kierkegaard (Concluding Postscript, Hong pp. 357–58)

1.2 Concepts

1.2.1 Existence precedes essence

Main article: *Existence precedes essence*

Sartre claimed that a central proposition of Existentialism is that *existence precedes essence*, which means that the most important consideration for individuals is that they are individuals—individually acting and responsible, conscious beings (“existence”)—rather than what labels, roles, stereotypes, definitions, or other preconceived categories the individuals fit (“essence”). The actual life of the individuals is what constitutes what could be called their “true essence” instead of there being an arbitrarily attributed essence others use to define them. Thus, human beings, through their own consciousness, create their own values and determine a meaning to their life.^{*[22]} Although it was Sartre who explicitly coined the phrase, similar notions can be found in the thought of existentialist philosophers such as *Heidegger*, and *Kierkegaard*:

“The subjective *thinker*’s form, the form of his communication, is his *style*. His form must be just as manifold as are the opposites that he holds together. The systematic *eins, zwei, drei* is an ab-

Some interpret the imperative to define oneself as meaning that anyone can wish to be anything. However, an existentialist philosopher would say such a wish constitutes an inauthentic existence - what Sartre would call ‘*bad faith*’. Instead, the phrase should be taken to say that people are (1) defined only insofar as they act and (2) that they are responsible for their actions. For example, someone who acts cruelly towards other people is, by that act, defined as a cruel person. Furthermore, by this action of cruelty, such persons are themselves responsible for their new identity (cruel persons). This is as opposed to their genes, or *human nature*, bearing the blame.

As Sartre writes in his work *Existentialism is a Humanism*: “... man first of all exists, encounters himself, surges up in the world—and defines himself afterwards”. Of course, the more positive, therapeutic aspect of this is also implied: A person can choose to act in a different way, and to be a good person instead of a cruel person. Here it is also clear that since humans can choose to be either cruel or good, they are, in fact, neither of these things essentially.^{*[23]}

Sartre's definition of existentialism was based on Heidegger's magnum opus “Being and Time”. In a set of letters, Heidegger implies that Sartre misunderstood him for his own purposes of subjectivism, and that he did not mean that actions take precedence over being so long as those actions were not reflected upon. This way of living, Heidegger called “average everydayness” .

1.2.2 The Absurd

Main article: [Absurdism](#)

The notion of the [Absurd](#) contains the idea that there is no meaning in the world beyond what meaning we give it. This meaninglessness also encompasses the amorality or “unfairness” of the world. This contrasts with the notion that “bad things don’t happen to good people”; to the world, metaphorically speaking, there is no such thing as a good person or a bad person; what happens happens, and it may just as well happen to a “good” person as to a “bad” person.*[24]

Because of the world’s absurdity, at any point in time, anything can happen to anyone, and a tragic event could plummet someone into direct confrontation with the Absurd. The notion of the Absurd has been prominent in literature throughout history. Many of the literary works of Søren Kierkegaard, Samuel Beckett, Franz Kafka, Fyodor Dostoyevsky, Eugène Ionesco, Miguel de Unamuno, Luigi Pirandello,*[25]*[26]*[27]*[28] Jean-Paul Sartre, Joseph Heller and Albert Camus contain descriptions of people who encounter the absurdity of the world.

It is in relation to the concept of the devastating awareness of meaninglessness that Albert Camus claimed that “there is only one truly serious philosophical problem, and that is suicide” in his *The Myth of Sisyphus*. Although “prescriptions” against the possibly deleterious consequences of these kinds of encounters vary, from Kierkegaard’s religious “stage” to Camus’ insistence on persevering in spite of absurdity, the concern with helping people avoid living their lives in ways that put them in the perpetual danger of having everything meaningful break down is common to most existentialist philosophers. The possibility of having everything meaningful break down poses a threat of [quietism](#), which is inherently against the existentialist philosophy.*[29] It has been said that the possibility of [suicide](#) makes all humans existentialists.*[30]

1.2.3 Facticity

Main article: [Facticity](#)

Facticity is a concept defined by Sartre in *Being and Nothingness* as the *in-itself*, which delineates for humans the modalities of being and not being. This can be more easily understood when considering facticity in relation to the temporal dimension of our past: one’s past is what one is, in the sense that it co-constitutes oneself. However, to say that one is only one’s past would be to ignore a significant part of reality (the present and the future), while saying that one’s past is only what one was, would entirely detach it from one-

self now. A denial of one’s own concrete past constitutes an inauthentic lifestyle, and the same goes for all other kinds of facticity (having a human body—e.g. one that doesn’t allow a person to run faster than the speed of sound—identity, values, etc.).*[31]

Facticity is both a limitation and a condition of freedom. It is a limitation in that a large part of one’s facticity consists of things one couldn’t have chosen (birthplace, etc.), but a condition of freedom in the sense that one’s values most likely depend on it. However, even though one’s facticity is “set in stone” (as being past, for instance), it cannot determine a person: The value ascribed to one’s facticity is still ascribed to it freely by that person. As an example, consider two men, one of whom has no memory of his past and the other who remembers everything. They both have committed many crimes, but the first man, knowing nothing about this, leads a rather normal life while the second man, feeling trapped by his own past, continues a life of crime, blaming his own past for “trapping” him in this life. There is nothing essential about his committing crimes, but he ascribes this meaning to his past.

However, to disregard one’s facticity when, in the continual process of self-making, one projects oneself into the future, that would be to put oneself in denial of oneself, and thus would be inauthentic. In other words, the origin of one’s projection must still be one’s facticity, though in the mode of not being it (essentially). Another aspect of facticity is that it entails [angst](#), both in the sense that freedom “produces” angst when limited by facticity, and in the sense that the lack of the possibility of having facticity to “step in” for one to take responsibility for something one has done, also produces angst.

Another aspect of existential freedom is that one can change one’s values. Thus, one is responsible for one’s values, regardless of society’s values. The focus on [freedom](#) in existentialism is related to the limits of the responsibility one bears, as a result of one’s freedom: the relationship between freedom and responsibility is one of interdependency, and a clarification of freedom also clarifies that for which one is responsible.*[32]*[33]

1.2.4 Authenticity

Main article: [Authenticity](#)

Many noted existentialist writers consider the theme of authentic existence important. Authentic existence involves the idea that one has to “create oneself” and then live in accordance with this self. What is meant by [authenticity](#) is that in acting, one should act as oneself, not as “one’s acts” or as “one’s genes” or any other essence requires. The au-

thentic act is one that is in accordance with one's freedom. Of course, as a condition of freedom is facticity, this includes one's facticity, but not to the degree that this facticity can in any way determine one's choices (in the sense that one could then blame one's background for making the choice one made). The role of facticity in relation to authenticity involves letting one's actual values come into play when one makes a choice (instead of, like Kierkegaard's Aesthete, "choosing" randomly), so that one also takes responsibility for the act instead of choosing either-or without allowing the options to have different values.*[34]

In contrast to this, the inauthentic is the denial to live in accordance with one's freedom. This can take many forms, from pretending choices are meaningless or random, through convincing oneself that some form of **determinism** is true, to a sort of "mimicry" where one acts as "one should." How "one should" act is often determined by an image one has of how one such as oneself (say, a bank manager, lion tamer, prostitute, etc.) acts. This image usually corresponds to some sort of social norm, but this does not mean that all acting in accordance with social norms is inauthentic: The main point is the attitude one takes to one's own freedom and responsibility, and the extent to which one acts in accordance with this freedom.

1.2.5 The Other and the Look

Main article: **Other**

The Other (when written with a capital "O") is a concept more properly belonging to **phenomenology** and its account of **intersubjectivity**. However, the concept has seen widespread use in existentialist writings, and the conclusions drawn from it differ slightly from the phenomenological accounts. The experience of the Other is the experience of another free subject who inhabits the same world as a person does. In its most basic form, it is this experience of the Other that constitutes intersubjectivity and objectivity. To clarify, when one experiences someone else, and this Other person experiences the world (the same world that a person experiences)—only from "over there"—the world itself is constituted as objective in that it is something that is "there" as identical for both of the subjects; a person experiences the other person as experiencing the same things. This experience of the Other's look is what is termed the Look (sometimes the **Gaze**).*[35]

While this experience, in its basic phenomenological sense, constitutes the world as objective, and oneself as objectively existing subjectivity (one experiences oneself as seen in the Other's Look in precisely the same way that one experiences the Other as seen by him, as subjectivity), in existentialism, it also acts as a kind of limitation of freedom.

This is because the Look tends to objectify what it sees. As such, when one experiences oneself in the Look, one doesn't experience oneself as nothing (no thing), but as something. Sartre's own example of a man peeping at someone through a keyhole can help clarify this: at first, this man is entirely caught up in the situation he is in; he is in a pre-reflexive state where his entire consciousness is directed at what goes on in the room. Suddenly, he hears a creaking floorboard behind him, and he becomes aware of himself as seen by the Other. He is thus filled with shame for he perceives himself as he would perceive someone else doing what he was doing, as a **Peeping Tom**. The Look is then co-constitutive of one's facticity.

Another characteristic feature of the Look is that no Other really needs to have been there: It is quite possible that the creaking floorboard was nothing but the movement of an old house; the Look isn't some kind of mystical telepathic experience of the actual way the other sees one (there may also have been someone there, but he could have not noticed that the person was there). It is only one's perception of the way another might perceive him.

1.2.6 Angst and dread

Main article: **Angst**

See also: **Living educational theory**

"Existential **angst**", sometimes called existential dread, anxiety, or **anguish**, is a term that is common to many existentialist thinkers. It is generally held to be a negative feeling arising from the experience of human freedom and responsibility. The archetypical example is the experience one has when standing on a cliff where one not only fears falling off it, but also dreads the possibility of throwing oneself off. In this experience that "nothing is holding me back", one senses the lack of anything that predetermines one to either throw oneself off or to stand still, and one experiences one's own freedom.*[24]

It can also be seen in relation to the previous point how angst is before nothing, and this is what sets it apart from fear that has an object. While in the case of fear, one can take definitive measures to remove the object of fear, in the case of angst, no such "constructive" measures are possible. The use of the word "nothing" in this context relates both to the inherent insecurity about the consequences of one's actions, and to the fact that, in experiencing freedom as angst, one also realizes that one is fully responsible for these consequences. There is nothing in people (genetically, for instance) that acts in their stead—that they can blame if something goes wrong. Therefore, not every choice is perceived as having dreadful possible consequences (and, it can be claimed, human lives would be unbearable if every

choice facilitated dread). However, this doesn't change the fact that freedom remains a condition of every action.

1.2.7 Despair

Main article: [Despair](#)

See also: [Existential crisis](#)

Despair, in existentialism, is generally defined as a loss of hope.*[36] More specifically, it is a loss of hope in reaction to a breakdown in one or more of the defining qualities of one's self or identity. If a person is invested in being a particular thing, such as a bus driver or an upstanding citizen, and then finds his being-thing compromised, he would normally be found in state of despair—a hopeless state. For example, a singer who loses the ability to sing may despair if she has nothing else to fall back on—nothing to rely on for her identity. She finds herself unable to be what defined her being.

What sets the existentialist notion of despair apart from the conventional definition is that existentialist despair is a state one is in even when he isn't overtly in despair. So long as a person's identity depends on qualities that can crumble, he is in perpetual despair—and as there is, in Sartrean terms, no human essence found in conventional reality on which to constitute the individual's sense of identity, despair is a universal human condition. As Kierkegaard defines it in *Either/Or*: “Let each one learn what he can; both of us can learn that a person’s unhappiness never lies in his lack of control over external conditions, since this would only make him completely unhappy.”*[37] In *Works of Love*, he said:

When the God-forsaken worldliness of earthly life shuts itself in complacency, the confined air develops poison, the moment gets stuck and stands still, the prospect is lost, a need is felt for a refreshing, enlivening breeze to cleanse the air and dispel the poisonous vapors lest we suffocate in worldliness. ... Lovingly to hope all things is the opposite of despairingly to hope **nothing** at all. Love hopes all things—yet is never put to shame. To relate oneself expectantly to the possibility of the good is to hope. To relate oneself expectantly to the possibility of evil is to fear. By the decision to choose hope one decides infinitely more than it seems, because it is an eternal decision. pp. 246–50

1.3 Opposition to positivism and rationalism

See also: [Positivism and Rationalism](#)

Existentialists oppose definitions of human beings as primarily rational, and, therefore, oppose [positivism](#) and [rationalism](#). Existentialism asserts that people actually make decisions based on subjective meaning rather than pure rationality. The rejection of reason as the source of meaning is a common theme of existentialist thought, as is the focus on the feelings of [anxiety](#) and [dread](#) that we feel in the face of our own radical [freedom](#) and our awareness of death. Kierkegaard advocated rationality as means to interact with the objective world (e.g. in the natural sciences), but when it comes to existential problems, reason is insufficient: “Human reason has boundaries” .*[38]

Like Kierkegaard, Sartre saw problems with rationality, calling it a form of “bad faith”, an attempt by the self to impose structure on a world of phenomena—“the Other”—that is fundamentally irrational and random. According to Sartre, rationality and other forms of bad faith hinder people from finding meaning in freedom. To try to suppress their feelings of anxiety and dread, people confine themselves within everyday experience, Sartre asserts, thereby relinquishing their freedom and acquiescing to being possessed in one form or another by “the Look” of “the Other” (i.e., possessed by another person—or at least one's idea of that other person).

1.4 Religion

See also: [Atheistic existentialism](#), [Christian existentialism](#), and [Jewish existentialism](#)

An existentialist reading of the [Bible](#) would demand that the reader recognize that he is an existing subject studying the words more as a recollection of events. This is in contrast to looking at a collection of “truths” that are outside and unrelated to the reader, but may develop a sense of reality/God. Such a reader is not obligated to follow the commandments as if an external agent is forcing them upon him, but as though they are inside him and guiding him from inside. This is the task Kierkegaard takes up when he asks: “Who has the more difficult task: the teacher who lectures on earnest things a meteor's distance from everyday life - or the learner who should put it to use?”*[39]

1.5 Nihilism

See also: [Existential nihilism](#)

Although [nihilism](#) and existentialism are distinct philosophies, they are often confused with one another. A primary cause of confusion is that [Friedrich Nietzsche](#) is an important philosopher in both fields, but also the existentialist insistence on the inherent meaninglessness of the world. Existentialist philosophers often stress the importance of [Angst](#) as signifying the absolute lack of any objective ground for action, a move that is often reduced to a [moral](#) or an [existential nihilism](#). A pervasive theme in the works of existentialist philosophy, however, is to persist through encounters with the absurd, as seen in [Camus' *The Myth of Sisyphus*](#) (“One must imagine Sisyphus happy”),^[40] and it is only very rarely that existentialist philosophers dismiss morality or one's self-created meaning: Kierkegaard regained a sort of morality in the religious (although he wouldn't himself agree that it was ethical; the religious suspends the ethical), and Sartre's final words in *Being and Nothingness* are “All these questions, which refer us to a pure and not an accessory (or impure) reflection, can find their reply only on the ethical plane. We shall devote to them a future work.”^[41]

1.6 Etymology

The term “existentialism” was coined by the [French Catholic philosopher Gabriel Marcel](#) in the mid-1940s.^[42]^[43]^[44] At first, when Marcel applied the term to him at a colloquium in 1945, [Jean-Paul Sartre](#) rejected it.^[45] Sartre subsequently changed his mind and, on October 29, 1945, publicly adopted the existentialist label in a lecture to the *Club Maintenant* in [Paris](#). The lecture was published as *L'existentialisme est un humanisme* (*Existentialism is a Humanism*), a short book that did much to popularize existentialist thought.^[46] Marcel later came to reject the label himself in favour of the term Neo-Socratic, in honor of Kierkegaard's essay “On The Concept of Irony” .

Some scholars argue that the term should be used only to refer to the cultural movement in Europe in the 1940s and 1950s associated with the works of the philosophers Jean-Paul Sartre, Simone de Beauvoir, Maurice Merleau-Ponty, and Albert Camus.^[2] Other scholars extend the term to Kierkegaard, and yet others extend it as far back as [Socrates](#).^[47] However, the term is often identified with the philosophical views of Jean-Paul Sartre.^[2]

1.7 History

1.7.1 19th century

Kierkegaard and Nietzsche

Main article: [Søren Kierkegaard and Friedrich Nietzsche](#)

[Søren Kierkegaard](#) and [Friedrich Nietzsche](#) were two of the first philosophers considered fundamental to the existentialist movement, though neither used the term “existentialism” and it is unclear whether they would have supported the existentialism of the 20th century. They focused on subjective human experience rather than the objective truths of mathematics and science, which they believed were too detached or observational to truly get at the human experience. Like [Pascal](#), they were interested in people's quiet struggle with the apparent meaninglessness of life and the use of diversion to escape from [boredom](#). Unlike Pascal, Kierkegaard and Nietzsche also considered the role of making free choices, particularly regarding fundamental values and beliefs, and how such choices change the nature and identity of the chooser.^[48] Kierkegaard's [knight of faith](#) and Nietzsche's [Übermensch](#) are representative of people who exhibit [Freedom](#), in that they define the nature of their own existence. Nietzsche's idealized individual invents his own values and creates the very terms they excel under. By contrast, Kierkegaard, opposed to the level of abstraction in Hegel, and not nearly as hostile (actually welcoming) to [Christianity](#) as Nietzsche, argues through a pseudonym that the objective certainty of religious truths (specifically Christian) is not only impossible, but even founded on logical paradoxes. Yet he continues to imply that a [leap of faith](#) is a possible means for an individual to reach a higher stage of existence that transcends and contains both an aesthetic and ethical value of life. Kierkegaard and Nietzsche were also precursors to other intellectual movements, including [postmodernism](#), and various strands of [psychology](#). However, Kierkegaard believed that individuals should live in accordance with their thinking.

Dostoyevsky

The first important literary author also important to existentialism was the Russian [Fyodor Dostoyevsky](#).^[49] Dostoyevsky's *Notes from Underground* portrays a man unable to fit into society and unhappy with the identities he creates for himself. Jean-Paul Sartre, in his book on existentialism *Existentialism is a Humanism*, quoted Dostoyevsky's *The Brothers Karamazov* as an example of [existential crisis](#). Sartre attributes Ivan Karamazov's claim, “If God did not exist, everything would be permitted”^[50] to Dostoyevsky himself, though this quote does not appear in the

novel.*[51] However, a similar sentiment is explicitly stated when Alyosha visits Dimitri in prison. Dimitri mentions his conversations with Rakitin in which the idea that “Then, if He doesn't exist, man is king of the earth, of the universe” allowing the inference contained in Sartre's attribution to remain a valid idea contested within the novel.*[52] Other Dostoyevsky novels covered issues raised in existentialist philosophy while presenting story lines divergent from secular existentialism: for example, in *Crime and Punishment*, the protagonist Raskolnikov experiences an existential crisis and then moves toward a Christian Orthodox worldview similar to that advocated by Dostoyevsky himself.

1.7.2 Early 20th century

See also: [Martin Heidegger](#)

In the first decades of the 20th century, a number of philosophers and writers explored existentialist ideas. The Spanish philosopher [Miguel de Unamuno y Jugo](#), in his 1913 book *The Tragic Sense of Life in Men and Nations*, emphasized the life of “flesh and bone” as opposed to that of abstract rationalism. Unamuno rejected systematic philosophy in favor of the individual's quest for faith. He retained a sense of the tragic, even absurd nature of the quest, symbolized by his enduring interest in [Cervantes'](#) fictional character [Don Quixote](#). A novelist, poet and dramatist as well as philosophy professor at the University of Salamanca, Unamuno wrote a short story about a priest's crisis of faith, *Saint Manuel the Good, Martyr*, which has been collected in anthologies of existentialist fiction. Another Spanish thinker, [Ortega y Gasset](#), writing in 1914, held that human existence must always be defined as the individual person combined with the concrete circumstances of his life: “*Yo soy yo y mi circunstancia*” (“I am myself and my circumstances”). Sartre likewise believed that human existence is not an abstract matter, but is always situated (“*en situation*”).

Although [Martin Buber](#) wrote his major philosophical works in German, and studied and taught at the Universities of Berlin and [Frankfurt](#), he stands apart from the mainstream of German philosophy. Born into a Jewish family in Vienna in 1878, he was also a scholar of Jewish culture and involved at various times in [Zionism](#) and [Hasidism](#). In 1938, he moved permanently to [Jerusalem](#). His best-known philosophical work was the short book *I and Thou*, published in 1922. For Buber, the fundamental fact of human existence, too readily overlooked by scientific rationalism and abstract philosophical thought, is “man with man”, a dialogue that takes place in the so-called “sphere of between” (“*das Zwischenmenschliche*”).*[53]

Two Russian thinkers, [Lev Shestov](#) and [Nikolai Berdyaev](#), became well known as existentialist thinkers during their

post-Revolutionary exiles in Paris. Shestov, born into a Ukrainian-Jewish family in Kiev, had launched an attack on rationalism and systematization in philosophy as early as 1905 in his book of aphorisms *All Things Are Possible*.

Berdyaev, also from Kiev but with a background in the Eastern Orthodox Church, drew a radical distinction between the world of spirit and the everyday world of objects. Human freedom, for Berdyaev, is rooted in the realm of spirit, a realm independent of scientific notions of causation. To the extent the individual human being lives in the objective world, he is estranged from authentic spiritual freedom. “Man” is not to be interpreted naturalistically, but as a being created in God's image, an originator of free, creative acts.*[54] He published a major work on these themes, *The Destiny of Man*, in 1931.

[Gabriel Marcel](#), long before coining the term “existentialism”, introduced important existentialist themes to a French audience in his early essay “Existence and Objectivity” (1925) and in his *Metaphysical Journal* (1927).*[55] A dramatist as well as a philosopher, Marcel found his philosophical starting point in a condition of metaphysical alienation: the human individual searching for harmony in a transient life. Harmony, for Marcel, was to be sought through “secondary reflection”, a “dialogical” rather than “dialectical” approach to the world, characterized by “wonder and astonishment” and open to the “presence” of other people and of God rather than merely to “information” about them. For Marcel, such presence implied more than simply being there (as one thing might be in the presence of another thing); it connoted “extravagant” availability, and the willingness to put oneself at the disposal of the other.*[56]

Marcel contrasted *secondary reflection* with abstract, scientific-technical *primary reflection*, which he associated with the activity of the abstract [Cartesian](#) ego. For Marcel, philosophy was a concrete activity undertaken by a sensing, feeling human being incarnate—embodied—in a concrete world.*[55]*[57] Although [Jean-Paul Sartre](#) adopted the term “existentialism” for his own philosophy in the 1940s, Marcel's thought has been described as “almost diametrically opposed” to that of Sartre.*[55] Unlike Sartre, Marcel was a Christian, and became a Catholic convert in 1929.

In Germany, the psychologist and philosopher [Karl Jaspers](#)—who later described existentialism as a “phantom” created by the public*[58]—called his own thought, heavily influenced by [Kierkegaard](#) and [Nietzsche](#), *Existenzphilosophie*. For Jaspers, “*Existenz-philosophy* is the way of thought by means of which man seeks to become himself...This way of thought does not cognize objects, but elucidates and makes actual the being of the thinker” .*[59]

Jaspers, a professor at the University of [Heidelberg](#), was

acquainted with **Martin Heidegger**, who held a professorship at **Marburg** before acceding to Husserl's chair at **Freiburg** in 1928. They held many philosophical discussions, but later became estranged over Heidegger's support of **National Socialism** (Nazism). They shared an admiration for Kierkegaard,*[60] and in the 1930s, Heidegger lectured extensively on Nietzsche. Nevertheless, the extent to which Heidegger should be considered an existentialist is debatable. In *Being and Time* he presented a method of rooting philosophical explanations in human existence (*Dasein*) to be analysed in terms of existential categories (*existentiale*); and this has led many commentators to treat him as an important figure in the existentialist movement.

1.7.3 After the Second World War

Following the **Second World War**, existentialism became a well-known and significant philosophical and cultural movement, mainly through the public prominence of two French writers, **Jean-Paul Sartre** and **Albert Camus**, who wrote best-selling novels, plays and widely read journalism as well as theoretical texts.*[61] These years also saw the growing reputation of Heidegger's book *Being and Time* outside Germany.

Sartre dealt with existentialist themes in his 1938 novel *Nausea* and the short stories in his 1939 collection *The Wall*, and had published his treatise on existentialism, *Being and Nothingness*, in 1943, but it was in the two years following the liberation of Paris from the German occupying forces that he and his close associates—Camus, Simone de Beauvoir, Maurice Merleau-Ponty, and others—became internationally famous as the leading figures of a movement known as existentialism.*[62] In a very short period of time, Camus and Sartre in particular became the leading public intellectuals of post-war France, achieving by the end of 1945 “a fame that reached across all audiences.”*[63] Camus was an editor of the most popular leftist (former **French Resistance**) newspaper *Combat*; Sartre launched his journal of leftist thought, *Les Temps Modernes*, and two weeks later gave the widely reported lecture on existentialism and secular humanism to a packed meeting of the Club Maintenant. Beauvoir wrote that “not a week passed without the newspapers discussing us”;*[64] existentialism became “the first media craze of the postwar era.”*[65]

By the end of 1947, Camus' earlier fiction and plays had been reprinted, his new play *Caligula* had been performed and his novel *The Plague* published; the first two novels of Sartre's *The Roads to Freedom* trilogy had appeared, as had Beauvoir's novel *The Blood of Others*. Works by Camus and Sartre were already appearing in foreign editions. The Paris-based existentialists had become famous.*[62]

Sartre had traveled to Germany in 1930 to study the



French philosophers Jean-Paul Sartre and Simone de Beauvoir

phenomenology of Edmund Husserl and Martin Heidegger,*[66] and he included critical comments on their work in his major treatise *Being and Nothingness*. Heidegger's thought had also become known in French philosophical circles through its use by **Alexandre Kojève** in explicating Hegel in a series of lectures given in Paris in the 1930s.*[67] The lectures were highly influential; members of the audience included not only Sartre and Merleau-Ponty, but **Raymond Queneau**, **Georges Bataille**, **Louis Althusser**, **André Breton**, and **Jacques Lacan**.*[68] A selection from Heidegger's *Being and Time* was published in French in 1938, and his essays began to appear in French philosophy journals.

Heidegger read Sartre's work and was initially impressed, commenting: “Here for the first time I encountered an independent thinker who, from the foundations up, has experienced the area out of which I think. Your work shows such an immediate comprehension of my philosophy as I have never before encountered.”*[69] Later, however, in response to a question posed by his French follower **Jean Beaufret**,*[70] Heidegger distanced himself from Sartre's position and existentialism in general in his



French-Algerian philosopher, novelist, and playwright *Albert Camus*

Letter on Humanism.^[71] Heidegger's reputation continued to grow in France during the 1950s and 1960s. In the 1960s, Sartre attempted to reconcile existentialism and Marxism in his work *Critique of Dialectical Reason*. A major theme throughout his writings was freedom and responsibility.

Camus was a friend of Sartre, until their falling-out, and wrote several works with existential themes including *The Rebel*, *Summer in Algiers*, *The Myth of Sisyphus*, and *The Stranger*, the latter being “considered—to what would have been Camus's irritation—the exemplary existentialist novel.”^[72] Camus, like many others, rejected the existentialist label, and considered his works concerned with facing the absurd. In the titular book, Camus uses the analogy of the Greek myth of Sisyphus to demonstrate the futility of existence. In the myth, Sisyphus is condemned for eternity to roll a rock up a hill, but when he reaches the summit, the rock will roll to the bottom again. Camus believes that this existence is pointless but that Sisyphus ultimately finds meaning and purpose in his task, simply by continually applying himself to it. The first half of the book contains an extended rebuttal of what Camus took to be existentialist philosophy in the works of Kierkegaard, Shostakov, Heidegger, and Jaspers.

Simone de Beauvoir, an important existentialist who spent much of her life as Sartre's partner, wrote about feminist and existentialist ethics in her works, including *The Sec-*

ond Sex and *The Ethics of Ambiguity*. Although often overlooked due to her relationship with Sartre,^[73] de Beauvoir integrated existentialism with other forms of thinking such as feminism, unheard of at the time, resulting in alienation from fellow writers such as Camus.

Paul Tillich, an important existentialist theologian following Kierkegaard and Karl Barth, applied existentialist concepts to Christian theology, and helped introduce existential theology to the general public. His seminal work *The Courage to Be* follows Kierkegaard's analysis of anxiety and life's absurdity, but puts forward the thesis that modern humans must, via God, achieve selfhood in spite of life's absurdity. Rudolf Bultmann used Kierkegaard's and Heidegger's philosophy of existence to demythologize Christianity by interpreting Christian mythical concepts into existentialist concepts.

Maurice Merleau-Ponty, an existential phenomenologist, was for a time a companion of Sartre. Merleau-Ponty's *Phenomenology of Perception* (1945) was recognized as a major statement of French existentialism.^[74] It has been said that Merleau-Ponty's work *Humanism and Terror* greatly influenced Sartre. However, in later years they were to disagree irreparably, dividing many existentialists such as de Beauvoir, who sided with Sartre.

Colin Wilson, an English writer, published his study *The Outsider* in 1956, initially to critical acclaim. In this book and others (e.g. *Introduction to the New Existentialism*), he attempted to reinvigorate what he perceived as a pessimistic philosophy and bring it to a wider audience. He was not, however, academically trained, and his work was attacked by professional philosophers for lack of rigor and critical standards.^[75]

1.8 Influence outside philosophy

1.8.1 Art

Film and television

Stanley Kubrick's 1957 anti-war film *Paths of Glory* “illustrates, and even illuminates...existentialism” by examining the “necessary absurdity of the human condition” and the “horror of war”.^[76] The film tells the story of a fictional World War I French army regiment ordered to attack an impregnable German stronghold; when the attack fails, three soldiers are chosen at random, court-martialed by a “kangaroo court”, and executed by firing squad. The film examines existentialist ethics, such as the issue of whether objectivity is possible and the “problem of authenticity”.^[76] Orson Welles' 1962 film *The Trial*, based upon Franz Kafka's book of the same name (Der Pro-

cess), is characteristic of both existentialist and absurdist themes in its depiction of a man (Joseph K.) arrested for a crime for which the charges are neither revealed to him nor to the reader.

Neon Genesis Evangelion is a Japanese science fiction animation series created by the anime studio Gainax and was both directed and written by Hideaki Anno. Existential themes of individuality, consciousness, freedom, choice, and responsibility are heavily relied upon throughout the entire series, particularly through the philosophies of Jean-Paul Sartre and Søren Kierkegaard. Episode 16's title, "The Sickness Unto Death, And..." (死に至る病、そして *Shi ni itaru yamai, soshite*) is a reference to Kierkegaard's book, *The Sickness Unto Death*. Some contemporary films dealing with existentialist issues include *Fight Club*, *I ♥ Huckabees*, *Waking Life*, *The Matrix*, *Ordinary People*, and *Life in a Day*.^[77] Likewise, films throughout the 20th century such as *The Seventh Seal*, *Ikiru*, *Taxi Driver*, the *Toy Story* films, *The Great Silence*, *Ghost in the Shell*, *Harold and Maude*, *High Noon*, *Easy Rider*, *One Flew Over the Cuckoo's Nest*, *A Clockwork Orange*, *Groundhog Day*, *Apocalypse Now*, *Badlands*, and *Blade Runner* also have existentialist qualities.^[78]

Notable directors known for their existentialist films include Ingmar Bergman, François Truffaut, Jean-Luc Godard, Michelangelo Antonioni, Akira Kurosawa, Terrence Malick, Stanley Kubrick, Andrei Tarkovsky, Hideaki Anno, Wes Anderson, Woody Allen, and Christopher Nolan.^[79] Charlie Kaufman's *Synecdoche, New York* focuses on the protagonist's desire to find existential meaning.^[80] Similarly, in Kurosawa's *Red Beard*, the protagonist's experiences as an intern in a rural health clinic in Japan lead him to an existential crisis whereby he questions his reason for being. This, in turn, leads him to a better understanding of humanity. The French film, *Mood Indigo* (directed by Michel Gondry) embraced various elements of existentialism. The film *The Shawshank Redemption*, released in 1994, depicts life in a prison in Maine, United States to explore several existentialist concepts.^[81]

Literature

Existential perspectives are also found in modern literature to varying degrees, especially since the 1920s. Louis-Ferdinand Céline's *Journey to the End of the Night* (Voyage au bout de la nuit, 1932) celebrated by both Sartre and Beauvoir, contained many of the themes that would be found in later existential literature, and is in some ways, the proto-existential novel. Jean-Paul Sartre's 1938 novel *Nausea*^[82] was "steeped in Existential ideas", and is considered an accessible way of grasping his philosophical stance.^[83] Between 1900

and 1960, other authors such as Albert Camus, Franz Kafka, Rainer Maria Rilke, T.S. Eliot, Herman Hesse, Luigi Pirandello,^[25]^[26]^[28]^[84]^[85]^[86] Ralph Ellison,^[87]^[88]^[89]^[90] and Jack Kerouac, composed literature or poetry that contained, to varying degrees, elements of existential or proto-existential thought. The philosophy's influence even reached pulp literature shortly after the turn of the 20th century, as seen in the existential disparity witnessed in Man's lack of control of his fate in the works of H.P. Lovecraft.^[91] Since the late 1960s, a great deal of cultural activity in literature contains postmodernist as well as existential elements. Books such as *Do Androids Dream of Electric Sheep?* (1968) (now republished as *Blade Runner*) by Philip K. Dick, *Slaughterhouse-Five* by Kurt Vonnegut, and *Fight Club* by Chuck Palahniuk all distort the line between reality and appearance while simultaneously espousing existential themes.

Theatre

Jean-Paul Sartre wrote *No Exit* in 1944, an existentialist play originally published in French as *Huis Clos* (meaning *In Camera* or "behind closed doors"), which is the source of the popular quote, "Hell is other people." (In French, "L'enfer, c'est les autres"). The play begins with a Valet leading a man into a room that the audience soon realizes is in hell. Eventually he is joined by two women. After their entry, the Valet leaves and the door is shut and locked. All three expect to be tortured, but no torturer arrives. Instead, they realize they are there to torture each other, which they do effectively by probing each other's sins, desires, and unpleasant memories.

Existentialist themes are displayed in the Theatre of the Absurd, notably in Samuel Beckett's *Waiting for Godot*, in which two men divert themselves while they wait expectantly for someone (or something) named Godot who never arrives. They claim Godot is an acquaintance, but in fact, hardly know him, admitting they would not recognize him if they saw him. Samuel Beckett, once asked who or what Godot is, replied, "If I knew, I would have said so in the play." To occupy themselves, the men eat, sleep, talk, argue, sing, play games, exercise, swap hats, and contemplate suicide—anything "to hold the terrible silence at bay".^[92] The play "exploits several archetypal forms and situations, all of which lend themselves to both comedy and pathos."^[93] The play also illustrates an attitude toward human experience on earth: the poignancy, oppression, camaraderie, hope, corruption, and bewilderment of human experience that can be reconciled only in the mind and art of the absurdist. The play examines questions such as death, the meaning of human existence and the place of God in human existence.

Tom Stoppard's *Rosencrantz & Guildenstern Are Dead* is an absurdist tragicomedy first staged at the Edinburgh Festival Fringe in 1966.*[94] The play expands upon the exploits of two minor characters from Shakespeare's *Hamlet*. Comparisons have also been drawn to Samuel Beckett's *Waiting For Godot*, for the presence of two central characters who appear almost as two halves of a single character. Many plot features are similar as well: the characters pass time by playing Questions, impersonating other characters, and interrupting each other or remaining silent for long periods of time. The two characters are portrayed as two clowns or fools in a world beyond their understanding. They stumble through philosophical arguments while not realizing the implications, and muse on the irrationality and randomness of the world.

Jean Anouilh's *Antigone* also presents arguments founded on existentialist ideas.*[95] It is a tragedy inspired by Greek mythology and the play of the same name (*Antigone*, by Sophocles) from the 5th century BC. In English, it is often distinguished from its antecedent by being pronounced in its original French form, approximately "Ante-GÖN." The play was first performed in Paris on 6 February 1944, during the Nazi occupation of France. Produced under Nazi censorship, the play is purposefully ambiguous with regards to the rejection of authority (represented by *Antigone*) and the acceptance of it (represented by *Creon*). The parallels to the French Resistance and the Nazi occupation have been drawn. *Antigone* rejects life as desperately meaningless but without affirmatively choosing a noble death. The crux of the play is the lengthy dialogue concerning the nature of power, fate, and choice, during which *Antigone* says that she is, "... disgusted with [the]...promise of a humdrum happiness." She states that she would rather die than live a mediocre existence.

Critic Martin Esslin in his book *Theatre of the Absurd* pointed out how many contemporary playwrights such as Samuel Beckett, Eugène Ionesco, Jean Genet, and Arthur Adamov wove into their plays the existentialist belief that we are absurd beings loose in a universe empty of real meaning. Esslin noted that many of these playwrights demonstrated the philosophy better than did the plays by Sartre and Camus. Though most of such playwrights, subsequently labeled "Absurdist" (based on Esslin's book), denied affiliations with existentialism and were often staunchly anti-philosophical (for example Ionesco often claimed he identified more with 'Pataphysics or with Surrealism than with existentialism), the playwrights are often linked to existentialism based on Esslin's observation.*[96]

1.8.2 Psychoanalysis and psychotherapy

Main article: [Existential therapy](#)

A major offshoot of existentialism as a philosophy is existentialist psychology and psychoanalysis, which first crystallized in the work of Otto Rank, Freud's closest associate for 20 years. Without awareness of the writings of Rank, Ludwig Binswanger was influenced by Freud, Edmund Husserl, Heidegger, and Sartre. A later figure was Viktor Frankl, who briefly met Freud and studied with Jung as a young man.*[97] His *logotherapy* can be regarded as a form of existentialist therapy. The existentialists would also influence social psychology, antipositivist micro-sociology, symbolic interactionism, and post-structuralism, with the work of thinkers such as Georg Simmel*[98] and Michel Foucault. Foucault was a great reader of Kierkegaard even though he almost never refers this author, who nonetheless had for him an importance as secret as it was decisive.*[99]

An early contributor to existentialist psychology in the United States was Rollo May, who was strongly influenced by Kierkegaard and Otto Rank. One of the most prolific writers on techniques and theory of existentialist psychology in the USA is Irvin D. Yalom. Yalom states that

Aside from their reaction against Freud's mechanistic, deterministic model of the mind and their assumption of a phenomenological approach in therapy, the existentialist analysts have little in common and have never been regarded as a cohesive ideological school. These thinkers—who include Ludwig Binswanger, Medard Boss, Eugène Minkowski, V.E. Gebsattel, Roland Kuhn, G. Caruso, F.T. Buytendijk, G. Bally and Victor Frankl—were almost entirely unknown to the American psychotherapeutic community until Rollo May's highly influential 1958 book *Existence*—and especially his introductory essay—introduced their work into this country.*[100]

A more recent contributor to the development of a European version of existentialist psychotherapy is the British-based Emmy van Deurzen.

Anxiety's importance in existentialism makes it a popular topic in psychotherapy. Therapists often offer existentialist philosophy as an explanation for anxiety. The assertion is that anxiety is manifested of an individual's complete freedom to decide, and complete responsibility for the outcome of such decisions. Psychotherapists using an existentialist approach believe that a patient can harness his anxiety and use it constructively. Instead of suppressing anxiety, patients are advised to use it as grounds for change. By embracing anxiety as inevitable, a person can use it to achieve

his full potential in life. **Humanistic psychology** also had major impetus from existentialist psychology and shares many of the fundamental tenets. **Terror management theory**, based on the writings of **Ernest Becker** and **Otto Rank**, is a developing area of study within the academic study of psychology. It looks at what researchers claim are implicit emotional reactions of people confronted with the knowledge that they will eventually die.

Also, **Gerd B. Achenbach** has refreshed the socratic tradition with his own blend of **philosophical counseling**. So did **Michel Weber** with his Chromatiques Center in Belgium.

1.9 Criticisms

1.9.1 General criticisms

Walter Kaufmann criticized 'the profoundly unsound methods and the dangerous contempt for reason that have been so prominent in existentialism.'*[101] **Logical positivist** philosophers, such as **Rudolf Carnap** and **A. J. Ayer**, assert that existentialists are often confused about the verb "to be" in their analyses of "being".*[102] Specifically, they argue that the verb is transitive and pre-fixed to a **predicate** (e.g., an apple *is red*) (without a predicate, the word is meaningless), and that existentialists frequently misuse the term in this manner. **Colin Wilson** has stated in his book *The Angry Years* that existentialism has created many of its own difficulties: "we can see how this question of freedom of the will has been vitiated by post-romantic philosophy, with its inbuilt tendency to laziness and **boredom**, we can also see how it came about that existentialism found itself in a hole of its own digging, and how the philosophical developments since then have amounted to walking in circles round that hole".*[103]

1.9.2 Sartre's philosophy

Many critics argue **Jean-Paul Sartre's** philosophy is contradictory. Specifically, they argue that Sartre makes metaphysical arguments despite his claiming that his philosophical views ignore metaphysics. **Herbert Marcuse** criticized Sartre's 1943 *Being and Nothingness* for projecting anxiety and meaninglessness onto the nature of existence itself: "Insofar as Existentialism is a philosophical doctrine, it remains an idealistic doctrine: it **hypostatizes** specific historical conditions of human existence into ontological and metaphysical characteristics. Existentialism thus becomes part of the very ideology which it attacks, and its radicalism is illusory".*[104]

In *Letter on Humanism*, Heidegger criticized Sartre's existentialism:

Existentialism says existence precedes essence. In this statement he is taking *existentia* and *essentia* according to their metaphysical meaning, which, from Plato's time on, has said that *essentia* precedes *existentia*. Sartre reverses this statement. But the reversal of a metaphysical statement remains a metaphysical statement. With it, he stays with metaphysics, in oblivion of the truth of Being.*[105]

1.10 See also

- Abandonment (existentialism)
- Disenchantment
- Existential phenomenology
- Existentiell
- List of existentialists
- Meaning (existential)
- Meaning-making

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1.12 External links

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- “Existentialism” . *Internet Encyclopedia of Philosophy*.
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- Friesian interpretation of Existentialism
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- “Existentialism is a Humanism” , a lecture given by Jean-Paul Sartre
- *The Existential Primer*
- Buddhists, Existentialists and Situationists: Waking up in Waking Life

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- Stirrings Still: The International Journal of Existential Literature
- Existential Analysis published by The Society for Existential Analysis

Chapter 2

Existence precedes essence

This article is about the existentialist phrase coined by Jean-Paul Sartre. For the **transcendent theosophy** founder, see **Mulla Sadra**.

The proposition that **existence precedes essence** (French: *l'existence précède l'essence*) is a central claim of **existentialism**, which reverses the traditional philosophical view that the **essence** (the nature) of a thing is more fundamental and immutable than its **existence** (the mere fact of its being).^{*} [1] To existentialists, human beings —through their **consciousness**—create their own values and determine a meaning for their life because the human being does not possess any inherent **identity** or **value**. That identity or value must be created by the individual. By posing the acts that constitute him or her, they make their existence more significant.^{*} [2]^{*} [3]

The idea can be found in the works of philosopher **Søren Kierkegaard** in the 19th century,^{*} [4] but was explicitly formulated by philosopher **Jean-Paul Sartre** in the 20th century. The three-word formula originated in his 1946 lecture "Existentialism Is a Humanism",^{*} [5] though antecedent notions can be found in **Heidegger's** *Being and Time*.^{*} [6]

2.1 Sartre's view

The **Sartrean** claim is best understood in contrast to an established principle of **metaphysics** that *essence precedes existence*, i.e. a typical claim for this traditional thesis would be that man is essentially selfish, or that he is a rational being.

To Sartre, “existence precedes essence” means that a **personality** is not built over a previously designed model or a precise purpose, because it is the human being who chooses to engage in such enterprise. While not denying the constraining conditions of human existence, he answers to **Spinoza** who affirmed that man is determined by what surrounds him. Therefore, to Sartre an **oppressive situation** is not intolerable in itself, but once regarded as such by

those who feel oppressed the situation *becomes* intolerable. So by projecting my intentions onto my present condition, “It is I who freely transform it into action” . When he said that “the world is a **mirror of my freedom**” , he meant that the world obliged me to react, to overtake myself. It is this overtaking of a present constraining situation by a project to come that Sartre names **transcendence**. He added that “we are condemned to be free” .^{*} [7]

When it is said that man defines himself, it is often perceived as stating that man can “wish” to be something - anything, a bird, for instance - and then be it. According to Sartre's account, however, this would be a kind of **bad faith**. What is meant by the statement is that man is (1) defined only insofar as he acts and (2) that he is responsible for his actions. To clarify, it can be said that a man who acts cruelly towards other people is, by that act, defined as a cruel man and in that same instance, he (as opposed to his genes, for instance) is defined as being responsible for being this cruel man. Of course, the more positive therapeutic aspect of this is also implied: You can choose to act in a different way, and to be a good person instead of a cruel person. Here it is also clear that since man can choose to be either cruel or good, he is, in fact, neither of these things *essentially*.^{*} [8]

To claim that existence precedes essence is to assert that there is no such predetermined essence to be found in humans, and that an individual's essence is defined by him or her through how he or she creates and lives his or her life. As Sartre puts it in his **Existentialism is a Humanism**: “man first of all exists, encounters himself, surges up in the world – and defines himself afterwards.”^{*} [9]

Existentialism tends to focus on the question of human existence and the conditions of this existence. What is meant by existence is the concrete life of each individual, and their concrete ways of being in the world. Even though this concrete individual existence must be the primary source of information in the study of people, certain conditions are commonly held to be “endemic” to human existence. These conditions are usually in some way related to the inherent meaninglessness or absurdity of the earth and its apparent

contrast with our pre-reflexive lived lives which normally present themselves to us as meaningful. A central theme is that since the world “in-itself” is absurd, that is, not “fair”, then a meaningful life can at any point suddenly lose all its meaning. The reasons why this happens are many, ranging from a tragedy that “tears a person's world apart,” to the results of an honest inquiry into one's own existence. Such an encounter can make a person mentally unstable, and avoiding such instability by making people aware of their condition and ready to handle it is one of the central themes of existentialism. **Albert Camus**, for instance, famously claimed in *Le Mythe de Sisyphe* that “there is only one truly serious philosophical problem, and that is suicide.” *[10]

Aside from these “psychological” issues, it is also claimed that these encounters with the absurd are where we are most in touch with our condition as humans. Such an encounter cannot be without philosophical significance, and existentialist philosophers derive many metaphysical theories from these encounters. These are often related to the self, consciousness and freedom as well as the nature of meaning.

2.2 See also

- Metousiosis
- Social constructionism
- Tabula rasa

2.3 Notes

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- [2] (French) (Dictionary) “L'existencialisme” - see “l'identité de la personne”
- [3] (French) Encyclopédie de la jeunesse, 1979, p.567
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- [5] Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy
- [6] Sartre, in *Being and Nothingness* (1943), credits a slightly longer version of the claim to Heidegger: “Now freedom has no essence. It is not subject to any logical necessity; we must say of it what Heidegger said of the *Dasein* in general: 'In it existence precedes and commands essence.'" However, Sartre gives no page reference for this citation. In *Being and Time*, Heidegger writes: “The 'essence' of human-being lies in its existence.” (“Das 'Wesen' des Daseins liegt in seiner Existenz” , *Sein und Zeit*, p. 42.)
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- [8] Catalano p. 81
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- [10] Camus, *The Myth of Sisyphus*

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2.5 External links

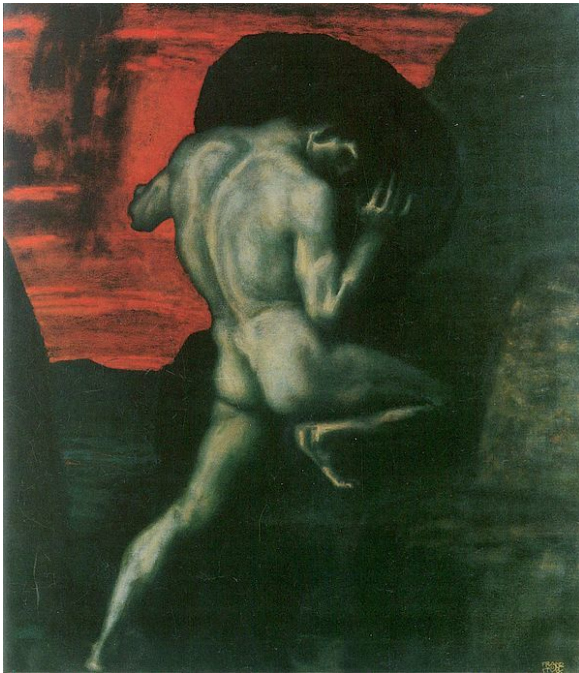
- Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy article <http://plato.stanford.edu/entries/existentialism/#ExiPreEss>

Chapter 3

Absurdism

This article is about the philosophy. For an extremely unreasonable, silly, or foolish thing, see **Absurdity**. For absurdist humour, see **surreal humour**. For the literary genre, see **Absurdist fiction**.

In philosophy, "**the Absurd**" refers to the conflict between



Sisyphus—the symbol of the absurdity of existence—by Franz Stuck.

the human tendency to seek **inherent value** and **meaning in life** and the human inability to find any. In this context *absurd* does not mean “logically impossible”, but rather “humanly impossible”.*[1] The universe and the human mind do not each separately cause the Absurd, but rather, the Absurd arises by the contradictory nature of the two existing simultaneously.

Accordingly, **absurdism** is a philosophical **school of thought** stating that the efforts of humanity to find inherent meaning will ultimately fail (and hence are absurd) be-

cause the sheer amount of information as well as the vast realm of the unknown make total certainty impossible. As a philosophy, absurdism furthermore explores the fundamental nature of the Absurd and how individuals, once becoming conscious of the Absurd, should respond to it. The absurdist philosopher **Albert Camus** stated that individuals should embrace the absurd condition of human existence while also defiantly continuing to explore and search for meaning.*[2]

Absurdism shares some concepts, and a common theoretical template, with **existentialism** and **nihilism**. It has its origins in the work of the 19th-century **Danish** philosopher **Søren Kierkegaard**, who chose to confront the crisis that humans face with the Absurd by developing his own existentialist philosophy.*[3] Absurdism as a belief system was born of the European existentialist movement that ensued, specifically when Camus rejected certain aspects of that philosophical line of thought*[4] and published his essay *The Myth of Sisyphus*. The aftermath of **World War II** provided the social environment that stimulated absurdist views and allowed for their popular development, especially in the devastated country of **France**.

3.1 Overview

"... in spite of or in defiance of the whole of existence he wills to be himself with it, to take it along, almost defying his torment. For to hope in the possibility of help, not to speak of help by virtue of the absurd, that for God all things are possible – no, that he will not do. And as for seeking help from any other – no, that he will not do for all the world; rather than seek help he would prefer to be himself – with all the tortures of hell, if so it must be."

Søren Kierkegaard, *The Sickness Unto Death**[5]

In absurdist philosophy, the Absurd arises out of the fundamental disharmony between the individual's search for meaning and the **meaninglessness** of the universe. As beings looking for meaning in a meaningless world, humans

have three ways of resolving the dilemma. Kierkegaard and Camus describe the solutions in their works, *The Sickness Unto Death* (1849) and *The Myth of Sisyphus* (1942), respectively:

- **Suicide** (or, “escaping existence”): a solution in which a person ends one's own life. Both Kierkegaard and Camus dismiss the viability of this option. Camus states that it does not counter the Absurd. Rather, the act of ending one's existence only becomes more absurd.
- **Religious, spiritual, or abstract belief in a transcendent realm, being, or idea**: a solution in which one believes in the existence of a reality that is beyond the Absurd, and, as such, has meaning. Kierkegaard stated that a belief in anything beyond the Absurd requires an irrational but perhaps necessary religious acceptance in such an intangible and empirically unprovable thing (now commonly referred to as a “**leap of faith**”). However, Camus regarded this solution, and others, as “philosophical suicide”.
- **Acceptance of the Absurd**: a solution in which one accepts the Absurd and continues to live in spite of it. Camus endorsed this solution, believing that by accepting the Absurd, one can achieve the greatest extent of their freedom, and that by recognizing no religious or other moral constraints and by revolting against the Absurd while simultaneously accepting it as unstopable, one could possibly be content from the personal meaning constructed in the process. Kierkegaard, on the other hand, regarded this solution as “demonic madness”: “*He rages most of all at the thought that eternity might get it into its head to take his misery from him!*”^[6]

3.2 Relationship to existentialism and nihilism

Absurdism originated from (as well as alongside) the 20th-century strains of **existentialism** and **nihilism**, and so it shares some prominent starting points with, though also entails conclusions that are uniquely distinct from, these other schools of thought. All three arose from the human experience of anguish and confusion stemming from the Absurd: the apparent meaninglessness in a world in which humans, nevertheless, are so compelled to find or create meaning.^[7] The three schools of thought diverge from there. Existentialists have generally advocated the individual's construction of his or her own meaning in life as well as the **free will** of the individual. Nihilists, on the contrary, contend that “it is futile to seek or to affirm meaning where

none can be found.”^[8] Absurdist, following Camus's formulation, hesitantly allow the possibility for some meaning or value in life, but are neither as certain as existentialists are about the value of one's own constructed meaning nor as nihilists are about the total inability to create meaning. Absurdist following Camus also devalue or outright reject free will, encouraging merely that the individual live defiantly and authentically *in spite of* the psychological tension of the Absurd.^[9]

Camus himself passionately worked to counter **nihilism**, as he explained in his essay “**The Rebel**,” while he also categorically rejected the label of “existentialist” in his essay “Enigma” and in the compilation *The Lyrical and Critical Essays of Albert Camus*, though he was, and still is, often broadly characterized by others as an existentialist.^[10] Both existentialism and absurdism entail consideration of the practical applications of becoming conscious of the truth of **existential nihilism**: i.e., how a driven seeker of meaning should act when suddenly confronted with the seeming concealment, or downright absence, of meaning in the universe. Camus's own understanding of the world (e.g., “a benign indifference”, in *The Stranger*), and every vision he had for its progress, however, sets him apart from the general existentialist trend.

3.3 Søren Kierkegaard

Main article: **Philosophy of Søren Kierkegaard**

A century before Camus, the 19th century Danish philosopher **Søren Kierkegaard** wrote extensively about the absurdity of the world. In his journals, Kierkegaard writes about the absurd:

What is the Absurd? It is, as may quite easily be seen, that I, a rational being, must act in a case where my reason, my powers of reflection, tell me: you can just as well do the one thing as the other, that is to say where my reason and reflection say: you cannot act and yet here is where I have to act... The Absurd, or to act by virtue of the absurd, is to act upon faith ... I must act, but reflection has closed the road so I take one of the possibilities and say: This is what I do, I cannot do otherwise because I am brought to a standstill by my powers of reflection.^[13]
—Kierkegaard, Søren, Journals, 1849

Here is another example of the Absurd from his writings:

What, then, is the absurd? The absurd is that the eternal truth has come into existence



Kierkegaard designed the relationship framework based (in part) on how a person reacts to despair. Absurdist philosophy fits into the 'despair of defiance' rubric.*[12]

in time, that God has come into existence, has been born, has grown up. etc., has come into existence exactly as an individual human being, indistinguishable from any other human being, inasmuch as all immediate recognizability is pre-Socratic paganism and from the Jewish point of view is idolatry.

—Kierkegaard, *Concluding Unscientific Postscript*, 1846, Hong 1992, p. 210

How can this absurdity be held or believed? Kierkegaard says:

I gladly undertake, by way of brief repetition, to emphasize what other pseudonyms have emphasized. The absurd is not the absurd or absurdities without any distinction (wherefore Johannes de Silentio: “How many of our age understand what the absurd is?”). The absurd is a category, and the most developed thought is required to define the Christian absurd accurately and with conceptual correctness. The absurd is

a category, the negative criterion, of the divine or of the relationship to the divine. When the believer has faith, the absurd is not the absurd — faith transforms it, but in every weak moment it is again more or less absurd to him. The passion of faith is the only thing which masters the absurd — if not, then faith is not faith in the strictest sense, but a kind of knowledge. The absurd terminates negatively before the sphere of faith, which is a sphere by itself. To a third person the believer relates himself by virtue of the absurd; so must a third person judge, for a third person does not have the passion of faith. Johannes de Silentio has never claimed to be a believer; just the opposite, he has explained that he is not a believer — in order to illuminate faith negatively.

—*Journals of Søren Kierkegaard* X6B 79*[14]

Kierkegaard provides an example in one of his works, *Fear and Trembling*. In the story of Abraham in the Book of Genesis, Abraham is told by God to kill his son Isaac. Just as Abraham is about to kill Isaac, an angel stops Abraham from doing so. Kierkegaard believes that through virtue of the absurd, Abraham, defying all reason and ethical duties (“you cannot act”), got back his son and reaffirmed his faith (“where I have to act”).*[15] However, it should be noted that in this particular case, the work was signed with the pseudonym *Johannes de Silentio*.

Another instance of absurdist themes in Kierkegaard's work appears in *The Sickness Unto Death*, which Kierkegaard signed with pseudonym *Anti-Climacus*. Exploring the forms of despair, Kierkegaard examines the type of despair known as defiance.*[16] In the opening quotation reproduced at the beginning of the article, Kierkegaard describes how such a man would endure such a defiance and identifies the three major traits of the Absurd Man, later discussed by Albert Camus: a rejection of escaping existence (suicide), a rejection of help from a higher power and acceptance of his absurd (and despairing) condition.

According to Kierkegaard in his autobiography *The Point of View of My Work as an Author*, most of his pseudonymous writings are not necessarily reflective of his own opinions. Nevertheless, his work anticipated many absurdist themes and provided its theoretical background.

3.4 Albert Camus

Though the notion of the 'absurd' pervades all Albert Camus's writing, *The Myth of Sisyphus* is his chief work on the subject. In it, Camus considers absurdity as a confrontation, an opposition, a conflict or a “divorce” between two ideals. Specifically, he defines the human condition as absurd,

as the confrontation between man's desire for significance, meaning and clarity on the one hand – and the silent, cold universe on the other. He continues that there are specific human experiences evoking notions of absurdity. Such a realization or encounter with the absurd leaves the individual with a choice: **suicide**, a **leap of faith**, or recognition. He concludes that recognition is the only defensible option.*[2]

For Camus, suicide is a “confession” that life is not worth living; it is a choice that implicitly declares that life is “too much.” Suicide offers the most basic “way out” of absurdity: the immediate termination of the self and its place in the universe.

The absurd encounter can also arouse a “leap of faith,” a term derived from one of Kierkegaard's early pseudonyms, *Johannes de Silentio* (although the term was not used by Kierkegaard himself),*[17] where one believes that there is more than the rational life (aesthetic or ethical). To take a “leap of faith,” one must act with the “virtue of the absurd” (as *Johannes de Silentio* put it), where a suspension of the ethical may need to exist. This faith has no expectations, but is a flexible power initiated by a recognition of the absurd. (Although at some point, one recognizes or encounters the existence of the Absurd and, in response, actively ignores it.) However, Camus states that because the leap of faith escapes rationality and defers to abstraction over personal experience, the leap of faith is not absurd. Camus considers the leap of faith as “philosophical suicide,” rejecting both this and physical suicide.*[17]*[18]

Lastly, a person can choose to embrace their own absurd condition. According to Camus, one's freedom – and the opportunity to give life meaning – lies in the recognition of absurdity. If the absurd experience is truly the realization that the universe is fundamentally devoid of absolutes, then we as individuals are truly free. “To live without appeal,”*[19] as he puts it, is a philosophical move to define absolutes and universals subjectively, rather than objectively. The freedom of humans is thus established in a human's natural ability and opportunity to create their own meaning and purpose; to decide (or think) for him- or herself. The individual becomes the most precious unit of existence, representing a set of unique ideals that can be characterized as an entire universe in its own right. In acknowledging the absurdity of seeking any inherent meaning, but continuing this search regardless, one can be happy, gradually developing meaning from the search alone.

Camus states in *The Myth of Sisyphus*: “Thus I draw from the absurd three consequences, which are my revolt, my freedom, and my passion. By the mere activity of consciousness I transform into a rule of life what was an invitation to death, and I refuse suicide.”*[20] “Revolt” here refers to the refusal of suicide and search for meaning despite the revelation of the Absurd; “Freedom” refers to

the lack of imprisonment by religious devotion or others' moral codes; “Passion” refers to the most wholehearted experiencing of life, since hope has been rejected, and so he concludes that every moment must be lived fully.

3.5 The meaning of life

According to absurdism, humans historically attempt to find **meaning in their lives**. Traditionally, this search results in one of two conclusions: either that life is meaningless, or life contains within it a purpose set forth by a **higher power** —a belief in **God**, or adherence to some **religion** or other abstract concept.

3.5.1 Elusion

Camus perceives filling the void with some invented belief or meaning as a mere “act of eluding”—that is, avoiding or escaping rather than acknowledging and embracing the Absurd. To Camus, elusion is a fundamental flaw in **religion**, **existentialism**, and various other schools of thought. If the individual eludes the Absurd, then he or she can never confront it. Camus also concedes that elusion is the most common.

3.5.2 God

Even with a spiritual power as the answer to meaning, another question arises: What is the purpose of a belief in God? **Kierkegaard** believed that there is no human-comprehensible purpose of God, making faith in God absurd itself. Camus on the other hand states that to believe in God is to “deny one of the terms of the contradiction” between humanity and the universe (and is therefore not absurd but what he calls “philosophical suicide”). Camus (as well as Kierkegaard), though, suggests that while absurdity does not lead to belief in God, neither does it lead to the denial of God. Camus notes, “I did not say 'excludes God', which would still amount to asserting” .*[21]

3.5.3 Personal meaning

For Camus, the beauty people encounter in life makes it worth living. People may create meaning in their own lives, which may not be the **objective** meaning of life (if there is one), but can still provide something to strive for. However, he insisted that one must always maintain an ironic distance between this invented meaning and the knowledge of the absurd, lest the fictitious meaning take the place of the absurd.

3.5.4 Freedom

Freedom cannot be achieved beyond what the absurdity of existence permits; however, the closest one can come to being absolutely free is through acceptance of the Absurd. Camus introduced the idea of “acceptance without resignation” as a way of dealing with the recognition of absurdity, asking whether or not man can “live without appeal”, while defining a “conscious revolt” against the avoidance of absurdity of the world. In a world devoid of higher meaning or judicial afterlife, the human nature becomes as close to absolutely free as is humanly possible.

3.5.5 Hope

The rejection of hope, in absurdism, denotes the refusal to believe in anything more than what this absurd life provides. Hope, Camus emphasizes, however, has nothing to do with despair (meaning that the two terms are not opposites). One can still live fully while rejecting hope, and, in fact, can only do so *without* hope. Hope is perceived by the absurdist as another fraudulent method of evading the Absurd, and by not having hope, one is motivated to live every fleeting moment to the fullest. In the words of Nikos Kazantzakis' epitaph: “I hope for nothing. I fear nothing. I am free.”

3.5.6 Integrity

The absurdist is not guided by morality, but rather, by their own integrity. The absurdist is, in fact, amoral (though not necessarily immoral). The Absurdist's view of morality implies an unwavering sense of definite right and wrong at all times, while integrity implies honesty with one's self and consistency in the motivations of one's actions and decisions.

3.6 See also

- Absurdist fiction
- *Credo quia absurdum*
- Discordianism
- Existential nihilism
- Existentialism
- Irrationality
- Lottery of birth
- Nihilism
- Non sequitur (literary device)
- 'Pataphysics
- Peter Wessel Zapffe
- *The Stranger* (novel)
- Theatre of the Absurd
- Absurdistan
- Church of the SubGenius
- Use–mention distinction

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3.9 External links

- Fiction of the Absurd
- Absurdist Monthly Review Magazine
- The Absurdist (Literary Journal)

Chapter 4

Facticity

In philosophy, **facticity** (French: *facticité*, German: *Faktizität**[1]) has a multiplicity of meanings from “factuality” and “contingency” to the intractable conditions of human existence.*[2]

4.1 Early usage

The term is first used by German philosopher **Johann Gottlieb Fichte** (1762-1814) and has a variety of meanings. It can refer to facts and factuality, as in nineteenth-century **positivism**, but comes to mean that which resists explanation and interpretation in **Wilhelm Dilthey** and **Neo-Kantianism**. The Neo-Kantians contrasted facticity with ideality, as does **Jürgen Habermas** in *Between Facts and Norms* (*Faktizität und Geltung*).

4.2 Heidegger

German philosopher **Martin Heidegger** (1889-1976) discusses “facticity”*[1] as the “thrownness” (*Geworfenheit*) of individual existence, which is to say we are “thrown into the world.” By this, he is not only referring to a brute fact, or the factuality of a concrete historical situation, e.g., “born in the '80s.” Facticity is something that already informs and has been taken up in existence, even if it is unnoticed or left unattended. As such, facticity is not something we come across and directly behold. In moods, for example, facticity has an enigmatic appearance, which involves both turning toward and away from it. For Heidegger, moods are conditions of thinking and willing to which they must in some way respond. The *thrownness* of human existence (or *Dasein*) is accordingly disclosed through moods.

4.3 Sartre and de Beauvoir

In the mid-20th Century works of French existentialists **Jean-Paul Sartre** and **Simone de Beauvoir**, facticity signifies all of the concrete details against the background of which human freedom exists and is limited. For example, these may include the time and place of birth, a language, an environment, an individual's previous choices, as well as the inevitable prospect of their death. For example: currently, the situation of a person who is born without legs precludes their freedom to walk on the beach; if future medicine were to develop a method of growing new legs for that person, their facticity might no longer exclude this activity.

4.4 Recent usage

It is a term that takes on a more specialized meaning in 20th century **continental philosophy**, especially in **phenomenology** and **existentialism**, including **Edmund Husserl**, **Martin Heidegger**, **Jean-Paul Sartre**, **Maurice Merleau-Ponty** and **Theodor Adorno**. Recent philosophers such as **Giorgio Agamben**, **Jean-Luc Nancy**, and **François Raffoul** have taken up the notion of facticity in new ways.

Facticity plays a key part in **Quentin Meillassoux's** philosophical project to challenge the thought-world relationship of **correlationism**. It is defined by him as “the absence of reason for any reality; in other words, the impossibility of providing an ultimate ground for the existence of any being.”*[3]

4.5 See also

- Being for itself

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Chapter 5

Authenticity (philosophy)



Philosopher *Jean-Paul Sartre* viewed jazz as a representation of freedom and authenticity. (Pictured is *Johnny Hodges*.)^[1]

Authenticity is a technical term used in psychology as well as existentialist philosophy and aesthetics (in regard to various arts and musical genres). In existentialism, authenticity is the degree to which one is true to one's own personality, spirit, or character, despite external pressures; the **conscious self** is seen as coming to terms with being in a material world and with encountering external forces, pressures, and influences which are very different from, and **other** than, itself. A lack of authenticity is considered in existentialism to be *bad faith*.^[2]

Views of authenticity in cultural activities vary widely. For instance, the philosophers **Jean Paul Sartre** and **Theodor Adorno** had opposing views regarding jazz, with Sartre considering it authentic and Adorno inauthentic. The concept of authenticity is often aired in musical subcultures, such as **punk rock** and **heavy metal**, where a purported lack of authenticity is commonly labeled with the epithet "**poseur**".^[3] There is also a focus on authenticity in music genres such as "...house, **grunge**, **garage**, **hip-hop**, **techno**, and **showtunes**".^[4]

5.1 Theories

5.1.1 Existentialism

One of the greatest problems facing such abstract approaches is that the drives people call the "needs of one's inner being" are diffuse, subjective and often culture bound. For this reason among others, authenticity is often "at the limits" of language; it is described as the negative space around inauthenticity, with reference to examples of inauthentic living.^[5] Sartre's novels are perhaps the easiest access to this mode of describing authenticity: they often contain characters and **antiheroes** who base their actions on external pressures—the pressure to appear to be a certain kind of person, the pressure to adopt a particular mode of living, the pressure to ignore one's own moral and aesthetic objections in order to have a more comfortable existence. His work also includes characters who do not understand their own reasons for acting, or who ignore crucial facts about their own lives in order to avoid uncomfortable truths; this connects his work with the philosophical tradition.

Sartre is concerned also with the "**vertiginous**" experience of absolute freedom. In Sartre's view, this experience, necessary for the state of authenticity, can be so unpleasant that it leads people to inauthentic ways of living. Typically, authenticity is seen as a very general concept, not attached to any particular political or aesthetic ideology. This is a necessary aspect of authenticity: because it concerns a person's

relation with the world, it cannot be arrived at by simply repeating a set of actions or taking up a set of positions. In this manner, authenticity is connected with creativity: the impetus to action must arise from the person in question, and not be externally imposed. Heidegger takes this notion to the extreme, by speaking in very abstract terms about modes of living (his terminology was adopted and simplified by Sartre in his philosophical works). Kierkegaard's work (e.g. "Panegyric Upon Abraham" from *Fear and Trembling*) often focuses on biblical stories which are not directly imitable. Sartre, as has been noted above, focused on inauthentic existence as a way to avoid the paradoxical problem of appearing to provide prescriptions for a mode of living that rejects external dictation.*[6]

Authenticity, according to Kierkegaard, is reliant on an individual finding authentic faith and becoming true to oneself. Kierkegaard develops the idea that news media and the bourgeois church-Christianity present challenges for an individual in society trying to live authentically. Kierkegaard thus sees "both the media and the church as intervening agencies, blocking people's way to true experiences, authenticity, and God."*[7] His conviction lies with the idea that mass-culture creates a loss of individual significance, which he refers to as "levelling." Kierkegaard views the media as supporting a society that does not form its own opinions but utilizes the opinions constructed by the news. Similarly, he interprets religion as a tradition that is passively accepted by individuals, without the inclusion of authentic thought. Kierkegaard believes that authentic faith can be achieved by "facing reality, making a choice and then passionately sticking with it."*[7] The goal of Kierkegaard's existentialist philosophy is to show that, in order to achieve authenticity, one must face reality and form his own opinions of existence. So as not to be discouraged by levelling, Kierkegaard suggests, "One must make an active choice to surrender to something that goes beyond comprehension, a leap of faith into the religious."*[7] Even if one does not want to put forth the effort of developing his own views, he must do so in the quest for authentic faith.

Nietzsche's view of authenticity is an atheist interpretation of Kierkegaard. He rejects the role of religion in finding authenticity because he believes in finding truth without the use of virtues. Nietzsche believes of the authentic man as the following: Someone who elevates himself over others in order to transcend the limits of conventional morality in an attempt to decide for oneself about good and evil, without regard for the virtues "on account of which we hold our grandfathers in esteem."*[8] Nietzsche rejects the idea of religious virtues due to the lack of questioning by the individual. One must avoid what he calls "herding animal morality,"*[8] if he is to find authenticity. To "stand alone" and avoid religiously constructed principles, it is essential to be "strong and original enough to initi-

ate opposite estimates of value, to transvaluate and invert 'eternal valuations.'"*[8] One must be a free thinker and theorize views outside of their predilections. The commonality of Kierkegaard and Nietzsche's existential philosophies is "the responsibilities they place on the individual to take active part in the shaping of one's beliefs and then to be willing to act on that belief."*[7] For Nietzsche, the secular mentality is a form of weakness and, for authenticity to be achieved, one must truly transcend conventional morality.

Existential journalism

Existential philosophers like Kierkegaard, Nietzsche, and Heidegger investigate the existential-ontological significance of societally constructed norms to decipher authenticity. For an existential journalist, this aversion to, and turning away from, an unquestioning acceptance of norms contributes to the production of an authentic work. Merrill believes that authentic journalism can exist if the journalist is true to one's self and rejects conformism. There are traditions that exist in media and news outlets that prevent journalists from achieving authenticity. Like Kierkegaard's view of media and church, Merrill believes that journalists are "gladly sacrificing individual authenticity to adapt nicely to the highly regimented, depersonalized corporate structure."*[9] Journalists are restricted by "institutional red tape" and, thus, cannot achieve authenticity. It is beneficial for a journalist to adhere to the "red tape" because his work will be published.

Actively shaping one's own belief and then acting upon that belief is a laborious task. A journalist that hesitates in writing a story because it is not within the norm is unable to achieve authenticity because of the notion that following the norm is more valuable than being authentic. The contention is, however, that "individual freedom and courage to act is more valuable than collective adherence to journalistic codes of conduct."*[7] As journalists make conscious decisions to write authentically, they are able to contribute more value in their work. The consequence of authentic writing is positive and ensures that the journalist, according to Merrill, "grows, matures, creates himself, and projects himself into the future."*[9]

Criticisms

Philosopher Jacob Golomb argues that the existentialist notion of authenticity is incompatible with a morality that values all persons.*[10]

5.1.2 Erich Fromm

A very different definition of authenticity was proposed by **Erich Fromm***[11] in the mid-1900s. He considered behavior of any kind, even that wholly in accord with societal mores, to be authentic if it results from personal understanding and approval of its drives and origins, rather than merely from conformity with the received wisdom of the society. Thus a Frommean authentic may behave consistently in a manner that accords with cultural norms, for the reason that those norms appear on consideration to be appropriate, rather than simply in the interest of conforming with current norms. Fromm thus considers authenticity to be a positive outcome of enlightened and informed motivation rather than a negative outcome of rejection of the expectations of others. He described the latter condition – the drive primarily to escape external restraints typified by the “absolute freedom” of Sartre – as “the illusion of individuality” ,*[12] as opposed to the genuine individuality that results from authentic living.

5.1.3 Other perspectives

Those who advocate **social reform** value the study of authenticity since it can provide a radical manifesto and an overview of the shortcomings of social structures. Michael Kernis and Brian Goldman defined authenticity as “the unimpeded operation of one's true or core self in one's daily enterprise.” *[13]

While authenticity may be a goal intrinsic to “the good life,” it is often a difficult state to actually achieve, due in part to social pressures to live inauthentically and in part to a person's own character. It is also described as a revelatory state, where one perceives oneself, other people, and sometimes even things, in a radically new way. Some writers argue that authenticity also requires self-knowledge, and that it alters a person's relationships with other people. Authenticity also carries with it its own set of moral obligations, which often exist regardless of race, gender and class. The notion of authenticity also fits into **utopian** ideology, which requires authenticity among its citizens to exist, or which claims that such a condition would remove physical and economic barriers to pursuing authenticity.

5.2 History

Secular and religious notions of authenticity have coexisted for centuries under different guises; perhaps the earliest account of authenticity that remains popular is **Socrates'** admonition that “the unexamined life is not worth living” . In aesthetics, “authenticity” describes the perception of art as

faithful to the artist's self, rather than conforming to external values such as historical tradition, or commercial worth. A common definition of “authenticity” in **psychology** refers to the attempt to live one's life according to the needs of one's inner being, rather than the demands of society or one's early conditioning. *[14]*[15]*[16]

In the twentieth century, Anglo-American discussions of authenticity often center around the writings of a few key figures associated with **existentialist philosophy**, where the term originated; because most of these writers wrote in languages other than English, the process of translating and anthropologizing has had a strong impact on the debate. **Walter Kaufmann** might be credited with creating a “canon” of existentialist writers which include **Søren Kierkegaard**, **Martin Heidegger**, and **Jean-Paul Sartre**. For these writers, the **conscious self** is seen as coming to terms with being in a material world and with encountering external forces and influences which are very different from itself; authenticity is one way in which the self acts and changes in response to these pressures.

5.3 Cultural activities

Due to different groups' and individual's different experiences, views of authenticity regarding cultural activities vary widely and often differ between groups and individuals. *[17] For Sartre, **jazz** music was a representation of freedom; this may have been in part because jazz was associated with **African American** culture, and was thus in opposition to Western culture generally, which Sartre considered hopelessly inauthentic. **Theodor Adorno**, however, another writer and philosopher concerned with the notion of authenticity, despised jazz music because he saw it as a false representation that could give the appearance of authenticity but that was as much bound up in concerns with appearance and audience as many other forms of art. Heidegger in his later life associated authenticity with non-technological modes of existence, seeing technology as distorting a more “authentic” relationship with the natural world.

Some writers on authenticity in the twentieth century considered the predominant **cultural norms** to be inauthentic; not only because they were seen as forced on people, but also because, in themselves, they required people to behave inauthentically towards their own desires, obscuring true reasons for acting. **Advertising**, in as much as it attempted to give people a reason for doing something that they did not already possess, was a “textbook” example of how Western culture distorted the individual for external reasons. Race relations are seen as another limit on authenticity, as they demand that the self engage with others on the basis of external attributes. An early example of the connection between inauthenticity and capitalism was made by

Karl Marx, whose notion of "alienation" can be linked to the later discourse on the nature of inauthenticity.



The punk subculture classifies members as "poseurs" if they are deemed to not understand or respect the subculture's values.

Individuals concerned with living authentically have often led unusual lives that opposed cultural norms; the rise of the counter-culture in the 1960s in Europe and America was seen by many as a new opportunity to live an authentic existence. Many, however, have pointed out that anti-authoritarianism and eccentricity does not necessarily constitute an authentic state of being. The connection of the violation of cultural norms to authenticity, however, is strong and real, and continues today: among artists who explicitly violate the conventions of their profession, for example. The connection of inauthenticity to capitalism is contained in the notion of "selling out," used to describe an artist whose work has become inauthentic after achieving commercial success and thus becoming to an extent integrated into an inauthentic system.

5.3.1 In music

See also: [Rockism and Punk ideologies](#)

The concept of authenticity is often raised in the [punk rock](#) and [heavy metal](#) musical subcultures, in which people or bands are criticized for their purported lack of authenticity by being labeled with the epithet "poseur".*[3] "Poseur" is used to refer to a person (or band) who copies the dress, speech, and/or mannerisms of a group or subculture, generally for attaining acceptability within the group, yet who is deemed not to share or understand the values or philosophy of the subculture. "The code of authenticity, which is central to the [heavy metal subculture](#), is demonstrated in many ways", such as through clothing, the use of an emotional singing voice and having serious themes in the songs.*[18] In metal, one study of how fans sought out authenticity within the metal scene noted three elements to authenticity: long-term dedication to the scene; knowing key events of metal culture; and making the right choices based on one's authentic inner voice.*[19] In [Black metal](#), an [extreme metal](#) genre, sincerity, authenticity and extremity are valued above all else."*[20] In the metal and hardcore punk subcultures, a band that began from a working class milieu that later signs to a major record label for a lucrative recording contract may be deemed to have "sold out" and lost their authenticity. In addition to the focus on authenticity in "...punk, [house](#), grunge, garage, and hip-hop, ideas of authenticity have seeped into even such transparently "inauthentic" genres as...techno (*Moby*) and show-tunes (*Rent*)."*[4]

5.4 See also

- [Akrasia](#)
- [Alessandro Ferrara](#)
- [Authentic self](#)
- [Individuation](#)
- [Invented tradition](#)
- [Integrity](#)
- [Persona \(psychology\)](#)

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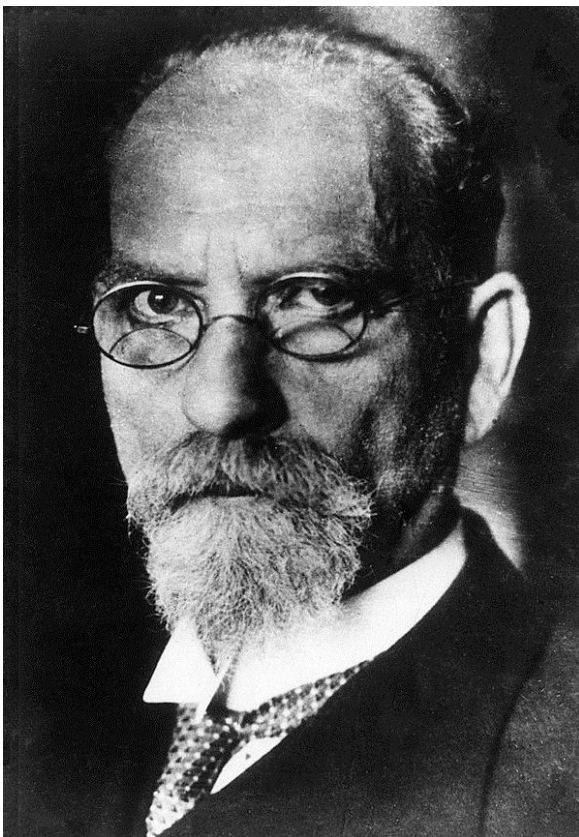
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Chapter 6

Other

For other uses, see [Other \(disambiguation\)](#).

In [phenomenology](#), the terms **the Other** and **the Con-**



The founder of phenomenology, Edmund Husserl, identified the Other as one of the conceptual bases of [intersubjectivity](#), of the relations among people.

stitutive Other identify the other human being, in his and her differences from the Self, as being a cumulative, constituting factor in the self-image of a person; as his or her acknowledgement of [being real](#); hence, the Other is dissimilar to and the opposite of the Self, of Us, and of the Same.*[1]*[2] The Constitutive Other is the relation between the [personality](#) (essential nature) and the person

(body) of a human being; it is the relation of [essential](#) and superficial characteristics of [personal identity](#) that corresponds to the relation between opposite, but corresponding, characteristics of the Self, because the difference is inner-difference, within the Self.*[3]*[4]

The condition and quality of **Otherness**, the characteristics of the Other, is the state of being different from and alien to the [social identity](#) of a person and to the [identity of the Self](#).*[5] In the [discourse](#) of philosophy, the term Otherness identifies and refers to the characteristics of *Who?* and *What?* of the Other, which are distinct and separate from the [Symbolic](#) order of things; from the [Real](#) (the authentic and unchangeable); from the [aesthetic](#) (art, beauty, taste); from [political philosophy](#); from [social norms](#) and [social identity](#); and from the Self. Therefore, the condition of Otherness is a person's non-conformity to and with the social norms of society; and Otherness is the condition of [disenfranchisement](#) (political exclusion), effected either by the State or by the social institutions (e.g. the [professions](#)) invested with the corresponding socio-political power. Therefore, the imposition of Otherness [alienates](#) the labelled person from the centre of society, and places him or her at the margins of society, for being the Other.*[6]

The term **Othering** describes the reductive action of labelling a person as someone who belongs to a subordinate social category defined as the Other. The practice of Othering is the exclusion of persons who do not fit the norm of the [social group](#), which is a version of the Self.*[7] Likewise, in the field of [human geography](#), the action term **to Other** identifies and excludes a person from the social group, placing him or her at the margins of society, where the social norms do not apply to and for the person labelled as the Other.*[8]

6.1 History



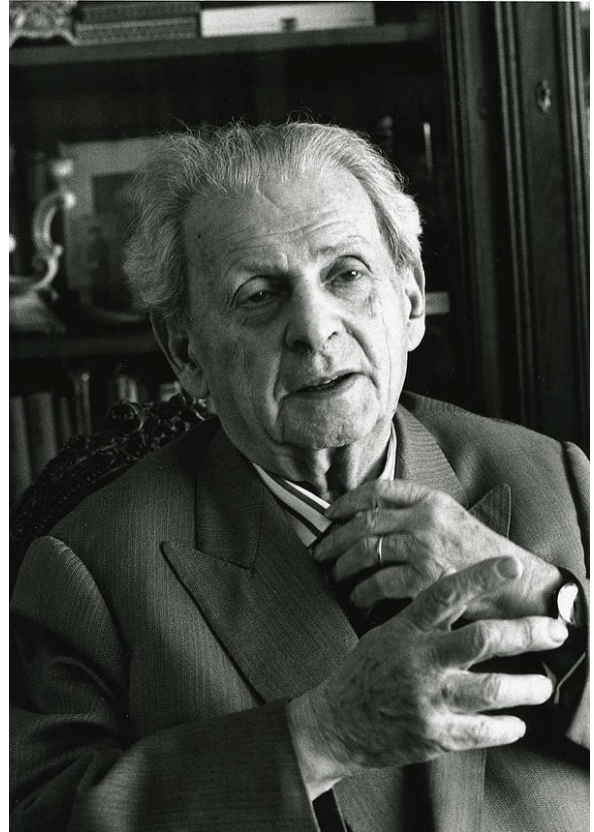
The idealist philosopher G. F. W. Hegel introduced the concept of the Other as constituent part of human preoccupation with the Self.

6.1.1 Philosophy

The concept of the Self requires the existence of **the Other** as the counterpart entity required for **defining the Self**; in the late 18th century, Georg Wilhelm Friedrich Hegel (1770–1831) introduced the concept of the Other as a constituent part of self-consciousness (preoccupation with the Self),^[9] which complements the propositions about self-awareness (capacity for introspection) proffered by Johann Gottlieb Fichte (1762–1814).^[10] See: *The Phenomenology of Spirit* (1807)

Edmund Husserl (1859–1938) applied the concept of the Other as a basis for intersubjectivity, the psychological relations among people. In *Cartesian Meditations: An Introduction to Phenomenology* (1931), Husserl said that the Other is constituted as an *alter ego*, as an other self. As such, the Other person posed and was an epistemological problem—of being only a perception of the consciousness of the Self.^[11]

In *Being and Nothingness: An Essay on Phenomenological Ontology* (1943), Jean-Paul Sartre (1905–1980) applied the dialectic of intersubjectivity to describe how the world is altered by the appearance of the Other, of how the world then appears to be oriented to the Other person, and not to the Self. The Other appears as a psychological phenomenon in the course of a person's life, and not as a radical threat



The ethical philosopher Emmanuel Lévinas associated the concept of the Other with the ethical systems proposed in scripture and tradition.

to the existence of the Self. In that mode, in *The Second Sex* (1949), Simone de Beauvoir (1908–1986) applied the concept of Otherness to Hegel's dialectic of the "Lord and Bondsman" (*Herrschaft und Knechtschaft*) and found it to be like the dialectic of the Man–Woman relationship, thus a true explanation for society's treatment and mistreatment of women.

6.1.2 Psychology

The psychoanalyst Jacques Lacan (1901–1981) and the Ethical philosopher Emmanuel Lévinas (1906–1995) established the contemporary definitions, usages, and applications of the Other, as the radical counterpart of the Self. Lacan associated the Other with language and with the symbolic order of things. Lévinas associated the Other with the ethical metaphysics of scripture and tradition; the ethical proposition is that the Other is superior and prior to the Self.

In the event, Lévinas re-formulated the face-to-face encounter (wherein a person is responsible to the Other person) to include the propositions of Jacques Derrida (1930–

2004) about the impossibility of the Other (person) being an entirely **metaphysical pure-presence**. That the Other could be an entity of pure Otherness (of **alterity**) personified in a **representation** created and depicted with language that identifies, describes, and classifies. The conceptual reformulation of the nature of the Other also included Lévinas's analysis of the distinction between "the saying and the said"; nonetheless, the nature of the Other retained the priority of **ethics** over **metaphysics**.

In the psychology of the mind (e.g. R. D. Laing), the Other identifies and refers to the **unconscious mind**, to **silence**, to **insanity**, and to language ("to what is referred and to what is unsaid").*[12] Nonetheless, in such psychologic and analytic usages, there might arise a tendency to **relativism** if the Other person (as a being of pure, abstract alterity) leads to ignoring the commonality of **truth**. Likewise, problems arise from unethical usages of the terms The Other, Otherness, and Othering to reinforce **ontological divisions** of reality: of **being**, of **becoming**, and of **existence**.*[11]

6.1.3 Ethics

In *Totality and Infinity: An Essay on Exteriority* (1961) Emmanuel Lévinas said that previous philosophy had reduced the Other person to an object of consciousness, by not preserving its absolute **alterity**—the innate condition of otherness, by which the Other radically transcends the Self and the totality of the human network into which the Other is being placed. As a challenge to self-assurance, the existence of the Other is a matter of ethics, because the ethical priority of the Other equals the primacy of ethics over ontology in real life.*[11]

From that perspective, Lévinas described the nature of the Other as "insomnia and wakefulness"; an **ecstasy** (an exteriority) towards the Other that forever remains beyond any attempt at fully capturing the Other, whose Otherness is infinite; even in the murder of an Other, his or her Otherness remains uncontrolled and not negated. The infinity of the Other allowed Lévinas to derive other aspects of philosophy and science as secondary to that ethic; thus:

The others that obsess me in the Other do not affect me as examples of the same **genus** united with my neighbor, by resemblance or common nature, **individuations** of the human race, or chips off the old block ... The others concern me from the first. Here, fraternity precedes the commonness of a genus. My relationship with the Other as neighbor gives meaning to my relations with all the others.

—*Otherwise than Being or Beyond Essence* (1974), p. 159.*[13]

6.1.4 Critical theory

Derrida proposed that the absolute **alterity** of the Other is compromised because the Other is *other than* the Self and the group. That logical problem has especially negative consequences in the realm of human geography when the Other person is denied ethical priority in geopolitical discourse. Hence, the use of the language of Otherness in the anthropological discourse (**Oriental Studies**) about Western encounters with non-Western cultures preserves the dominantor-dominated discourse of **hegemony**, just as misrepresenting the feminine as Other reasserts **male privilege** as primary in social discourse.*[1]

In *The Colonial Present: Afghanistan, Palestine and Iraq* (2004), the geographer Derek Gregory said that the responses of U.S. President George W. Bush (2001–2009) to the terrorist attacks on 11 September 2001 reinforced philosophic divisions of connotation and denotation that perpetuated the negative representation of the non-Western Other, when he rhetorically asked the U.S. populace *Why do they hate us?* as political prelude to the **War on Terror**.*[14]

President Bush's rhetorical question led the U.S. populace to make an artificial, Us-and-Them division in the relations between the U.S. and the countries and cultures of the Middle East, which artifice is a basic factor of the perpetual war on **terrorism**, and is a step away from eradicating the imaginary representations of the Self and the Other created with the **Orientalist** geographies produced by **Oriental Studies**; about which the cultural critic Edward Saïd said that:

To build a conceptual framework around a notion of Us-versus-Them is, in effect, to pretend that the principal consideration is **epistemological** and natural—our civilization is known and accepted, theirs is different and strange—whereas, in fact, the framework separating us from them is belligerent, constructed, and situational.

—*The Colonial Present: Afghanistan, Palestine and Iraq* (2004), p. 24.*[15]

6.2 Imperialism and colonialism

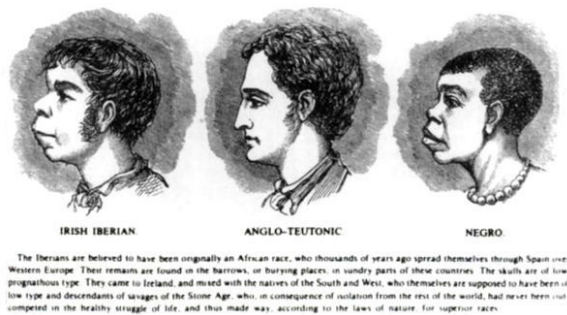
The contemporary, world system of **post-colonial**, nation-states (with interdependent politics and economies) was preceded by the European imperial system of **colonies** (settler and economic) in which "the creation and maintenance

of an unequal economic, cultural, and territorial relationship, usually between states, and often in the form of an empire, [was] based on **domination** and **subordination**.” * [16] In the imperialist world system, political and economic affairs were fragmented, and the discrete empires “provided for most of their own needs ... [and disseminated] their influence solely through conquest [empire] or the threat of conquest [hegemony].” * [17]

6.2.1 Orientalism

The imperial conquest of “non-white” countries was intellectually justified with the **fetishization** of the Eastern world, which was effected with cultural generalizations that divided the peoples of the world into the artificial, binary-relationship of “The Eastern World and The Western World”, the dichotomy which identified, designated, and subordinated the peoples of the Orient as the Other—as the non-European Self.* [18] The process of fetishization of people and things is a function of **Orientalism**, which the colonialist ideologue realises with three actions: (i) Homogenization (all Oriental peoples are the same folk); (ii) Feminization (Oriental people are the lessers in the East–West binary relationship); and (iii) Essentialization (a people reduced to the artificial essence of universal, innate characteristics); thus, the praxis of Othering reduced to cultural inferiority the people, places, and things of the Eastern world, which then justified colonialism by establishing the West as the superior standard of culture.* [18]* [19]

6.2.2 Race



Scientific racism of the Other: In the late-19th century, H. Strickland Constable justified anti-Irish racism among white people by claiming similarity between the cranial features of “the Irish-Iberian” man (left) and “the Negro” man (right), as proof that each man is racially inferior to the Anglo-Teutonic man (centre) possessed of the cranial ideal.

The practice of Othering was the prevalent cultural perspective of the European imperial powers, which was supported by the fabrications of **scientific racism**, such as the

pseudo-intellectual belief that the size of the cranium of the non-European Other was indicative of the inferior intelligence of the coloured peoples designated as the non-white Other.* [20]

In 1951, the United Nations officially declared that the differences among the races were insignificant in relation to the anthropological sameness among the peoples who are the human race. Despite the facts, in the U.S., the artificial distinctions against the Other remain, especially in government forms that ask a U.S. citizen to identify and place him or herself into a racial category, as in the questionnaires of the census bureau.* [20] In practice of Othering, immigrants and refugees endure the experience of socio-political reductionism with the artifice of racial classification, as implied in the terms such as “illegal immigrant” (from overseas) and “illegal alien” (for Mexicans) in the U.S.* [20]

6.2.3 The subaltern native

Maintaining an empire requires the **cultural subordination** of the Other into the **subaltern native** (the colonized people), which facilitates the exploitation of their labour, of their lands, and of the natural resources of their country as a colony of the motherland. To realise those ends, the process of Othering culturally justifies the domination and subordination of the native people, by placing them (as the Other) at the social periphery of the geopolitical enterprise that is colonial imperialism. The colonizer creates the Other with a false dichotomy of “native weakness” (social and political, cultural and economic) against the “colonial strength” of imperial **power**, which can be resolved only with the **noblesse oblige** of racialism—the “moral responsibility” that psychologically authorizes the colonialist Self to unilaterally assume a **civilizing mission** to educate, convert, and culturally assimilate the Other into the empire.* [21]

In the praxis of **colonialism**, the native populace constitute the Other whom the colonizers mean to dominate in order to civilise and save them in the course of exploiting the natural and human resources of the natives’ homeland.* [22] As such, a colony is a way to dominate and dispose of two groups of people (colonists and colonised) who can be used to define the Other.* [23] The practice of Othering establishes the unequal relationship between the native people and the colonizers, who believe themselves essentially superior to the natives whom they reduced to inhuman inferiority, as “the Other”.* [24] The dehumanisation of colonialism—the colonist “Self” against the colonised “Other”—is maintained with the false binary-relations of social class and race, of sex and gender, and of nation and religion.* [22] The proper, profitable functioning of a colony features continual protection of such cultural demarcations, which establish and enforce the socio-economic binary relation be-

tween “civilized man” (the colonist) and “savage man” (the colonial subaltern).^{*} [24]

6.3 Sex and gender



The existential philosopher Simone de Beauvoir applied the concept of The Other to the man–woman binary relation, in critical of the dominator–dominated relation, which historically characterised sexual inequality.

The existential philosopher Simone de Beauvoir applied Hegel's conception of “the Other” (as a constituent part of self-consciousness) to describe a male-dominated culture that represents Woman as the sexual Other in relation to Man. In the cultural context of the Man–Woman binary relation, the sexual Other is a minority, the least-favoured social group, usually the women of the community, because “a man represents both the positive and the neutral, as indicated by the common use of [the word] *Man* to designate human beings in general; whereas [the word] *Woman* represents only the negative, defined by limiting criteria, without reciprocity” from the first sex, from Man.^{*} [25] See: *The Second Sex* (1949)

In 1957, Betty Friedan substantiated the ordinate–subordinate nature of the Man–Woman sexual relation as social identity. When queried about their post-graduate

lives, the majority of women interviewed, at a university-class reunion, used binary gender language, and referred to and identified themselves as their roles (wife, mother, manager) in the private sphere. They did not identify their own achievements (career, job, business) in the public sphere of life. Unawares, the women had conventionally automatically identified themselves as the social Other. Although the nature of the social Other is influenced by the society's social constructs (social class, sex, gender), as a human organisation, society holds the power (social and political) to formally change the social relation between the male-defined Self and *Woman*, the non-male Other.^{*} [26] See: *The Feminine Mystique* (1963)

The feminist philosopher Cheshire Calhoun deconstructed the concept of “the Other” as the female-half of the binary-gender relation of the “Man and Woman” concept. Deconstruction of the word *Woman*—from subordinate in the “Man and Woman” relation—conceptually reconstructed the female Other as the Woman who exists independently of male definition (rationalisation); independent of the patriarchy who formally realise female subordination with binary-gender usages of the word *Woman*.^{*} [27]



In “Feminism is Humanism. So Why the Debate?” (2012), Prof. Sarojini Sahoo said that despite equality with men, women possess a discrete identity that is independent of the male definition of woman.

In the essay “Feminism is Humanism. So Why the Debate?” (2012), the academic Sarojini Sahoo, agrees with De Beauvoir's proposition that women can be free of social subordination by “thinking, taking action, working, creating,

on the same terms as men; instead of seeking to disparage them, she declares herself their equal.” Yet counters De Beauvoir that despite having the same human-being status as men, women have a unique sexual **identity** different from men. In feminist definition, Women are the Other (but not the Hegelian Other) and are not existentially defined by the demands of Man. Women are the social Other who unknowingly accept subjugation as part of **subjectivity**.*[28] Whilst the identity of woman is constitutionally different from the identity of man, as human beings, men and women are equal. Hence, the harm of Othering arises from the asymmetric nature of sex and gender roles, which arises accidentally and “passively” from natural and unavoidable **intersubjectivity**.*[29]

The social-exclusion function of Othering a person or a social group from society, for being different from the norm (of the Self), is understood in the socio-economic functions of gender (a **social construct**) and sex (biological reality). In a society where heterosexuality is the social norm, “the Other” refers to and identifies the same-sex orientation, lesbians (women who love women) and gays (men who love men), people identified as “deviant” from the binary socio-sexual norm.*[30] Negative usages of “the Other” are applied to the lesbian and gay, bisexual, and transgender (LGBT) communities to diminish their social status and political power by social Othering to the margins of society. To neutralise Othering, LGBT communities *queer* a city, create social spaces, that use the city's spatial and temporal plans to allow the LGBT community free expression of **social identity** (i.e. a gay-pride parade); as such, *queering* is a political means for the sexual Other to establish their reality as part of the urban body politic.*[31]

6.4 Knowledge

6.4.1 Representations

Regarding the production of **knowledge** about the Other, Michel Foucault and the **Frankfurt School** identified the process of **Othering** as everything to do with the creation and maintenance of imaginary representations — “knowledge of the Other”—in service to geopolitical **power** and **domination**. The **representations** of the Other (metaphoric, metonymic, anthropomorphic) are manifestations of the Western cultural attitudes inherent to the European historiographies of the non-European peoples labelled as “the Other”. Using analytical discourses (academic and commercial, geopolitical and military) the **dominant ideology** of the colonialist culture explains the Eastern world to the Western world, using the binary relationship of the European Self confronting the non-European Other from overseas.*[32]

In the 19th-century **historiographies** of the **Orient** as a place, European **Orientalists** studied only what they argued was the **high culture**—the languages and literatures, the arts and philologies—of the Middle East as a cultural region, rather than as a geopolitical place inhabited by different peoples and societies.*[33] About such cultural misrepresentation, Saïd said that “the Orient that appears in Orientalism, then, is a system of representations framed by a whole set of forces that brought the Orient into Western learning, Western consciousness, and later, Western empire. If this definition of Orientalism seems more political than not, that is simply because I think Orientalism was, itself, a product of certain political forces and activities. Orientalism is a school of interpretation whose material happens to be the Orient, its civilisations, peoples, and localities. Its objective discoveries—the work of innumerable devoted scholars who edited texts and translated them, codified grammars, wrote dictionaries, reconstructed dead epochs, produced positivistically verifiable learning—are and always have been conditioned by the fact that its truths, like any truths delivered by language, are embodied in language, and, what is the truth of language?, Nietzsche once said, but”:

A mobile army of **metaphors**, **metonyms**, and **anthropomorphisms**—in short, a sum of human relations, which have been enhanced, transposed, and embellished poetically and rhetorically, and which, after long use, seem firm, canonical, and obligatory to a people: truths are illusions about which one has forgotten that this is what they are.

—*Orientalism* (1978) pp. 202–203.*[34]*:202

Saïd concludes that Nietzsche's perspective might be too **nihilistic**, but that it draws attention to the fact that, in so far as “the Orient” occurred in the **existential** awareness of the Western world, the Orient was a word that later accrued to it a wide field of meanings, associations, and connotations, which did not refer to the real Eastern world, but to the field of study surrounding “the Orient” as a word.*[35]

6.4.2 The Academy

In the Eastern world, the field of **Occidentalism**, the investigation programme and academic curriculum of and about the **essence** of **The West**—i.e. geographic Europe as a culturally homogenous place—did not exist as a counterpart to Orientalism.*[36] Moreover, in the Orientalist practices of **historical negationism**, the writing of distorted history about the places and peoples of “The East” continue in the **postmodern** era, especially in contemporary journal-

ism; e.g. in the Third World, political parties practice intra-national Othering with fabricated “facts”, such as threat-reports about non-existent threats (political, social, military) that are meant to aggravate the character faults of the opponent political parties, which usually are composed of people from the social and ethnic groups identified and designated as the Other in that society.*[37]

The process of Othering a person or a social group, by means of an ideal **ethnocentricity** (belief that one's ethnic group is the superior group), and the cultural tendency to evaluate and assign **meaning** to Other ethnicities, which are negatively measured against the ideal standard of the Self—is realised through mundane methods of investigation, such as **cartography**.*[38]:179

Historically, the drawing of maps emphasised and bolstered specific lands and the associated national-identities, the natural resources and cultures of the native inhabitants. In early cartography, the distortion (proportionate, proximate, and commercial) of actual places and true distances established the Western cartographer's **homeland** as the centre of the *mapamundi*; thus British cartographers centred Britain in their maps, and drew the British islands proportionally larger than the true geography might allow. In contemporary cartography, polar-perspective maps of the northern hemisphere, drawn by American cartographers, distort real geographic spatial relations (distance, size, mass) of and between the U.S. and Russia, to emphasise American superiority (military, cultural, geopolitical) and the inferiority of the Russian Other.*[38]:10

6.4.3 Practical perspectives

In *Key Concepts in Political Geography* (2009), Alison Mountz proposed concrete definitions of the Other as a philosophic concept and term within the field of phenomenology; when used as a noun, the Other identifies and refers to a person and to a group of persons; when used as a verb, the Other identifies and refers to a category and a label for persons and things.

Post-colonial scholarship demonstrated that, in pursuit of empire, “the colonizing powers narrated an 'Other' whom they set out to save, dominate, control, [and] civilize ... [in order to] extract resources through colonization” of the homeland of the people labelled as the Other.*[30] As facilitated by **Orientalist representations** of the non-Western Other, **colonisation**—the economic exploitation of a people and their land—is misrepresented as being for the material, spiritual, and cultural benefit of the colonised peoples.

Counter to the post-colonial perspective of the Other as part of a Dominator–Dominated binary relationship, post-modern philosophy presents the Other and Otherness as

phenomenological and **ontological** progress for Man and society. Public knowledge of the **social identity** of peoples classified as “Outsiders” is *de facto* acknowledgement of their being **real**, and so they are part of the **body politic**, especially in the cities. As such, “the post-modern city is a geographical celebration of **difference** that moves sites once conceived of as 'marginal' to the [social] centre of discussion and analysis” of the **human relations** between the Outsiders and the Establishment.*[30]

6.5 See also

- *L'épreuve de l'étranger*
- *Orientalism* (1978), by Edward Saïd
- **Otherness of childhood**
- **Allosemitism**
- **Allophilia**
- **Xenocentrism**
- **Exoticism**
- **Social alienation**

Sexual difference

- Judith Butler
- Julia Kristeva
- Luce Irigaray
- Sarojini Sahoo

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6.9 External links

- Definitions of Other/Othering
- The Centre for Studies in Otherness

6.8 Further reading

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Chapter 7

Angst

For other uses, see [Angst \(disambiguation\)](#).



Edvard Munch tried to represent “an infinite scream passing through nature” in The Scream (1893).

Angst means fear or anxiety (*anguish* is its Latinate equivalent, and *anxious*, *anxiety* are of similar origin). The word *angst* was introduced into English from the Danish, Norwegian and Dutch word *angst* and the German word *Angst*. It is attested since the 19th century in English translations of the works of Kierkegaard and Freud.*[1]*[2]*[3] It is used in English to describe an intense feeling of apprehension, anxiety, or inner turmoil.

In German, the technical terminology of psychology and philosophy distinguishes between *Angst* and *Furcht* in that *Furcht* is a negative anticipation regarding a concrete threat,

while *Angst* is a non-directional and unmotivated emotion. In common language, however, *Angst* is the normal word for “fear”, while *Furcht* is an elevated synonym.*[4]

In other languages having the meaning of the Latin word *pavor* for “fear”, the derived words differ in meaning, e.g. as in the French *anxiété* and *peur*. The word *Angst* has existed since the 8th century, from the Proto-Indo-European root **anghu-*, “restraint” from which Old High German *angust* developed.*[5] It is pre-cognate with the Latin *angustia*, “tensity, tightness” and *angor*, “choking, clogging”; compare to the Ancient Greek ἄγκω (*ankho*) “strangle”.

7.1 Existentialism

In Existentialist philosophy the term *angst* carries a specific conceptual meaning. The use of the term was first attributed to Danish philosopher Søren Kierkegaard (1813–1855). In *The Concept of Anxiety* (also known as *The Concept of Dread*, depending on the translation), Kierkegaard used the word *Angest* (in common Danish, *angst*, meaning “dread” or “anxiety”) to describe a profound and deep-seated condition. Where animals are guided solely by instinct, said Kierkegaard, human beings enjoy a freedom of choice that we find both appealing and terrifying.*[5]*[6] Kierkegaard's concept of angst reappeared in the works of existentialist philosophers who followed, such as Friedrich Nietzsche, Jean-Paul Sartre and Martin Heidegger, each of whom developed the idea further in individual ways. While Kierkegaard's angst referred mainly to ambiguous feelings about moral freedom within a religious personal belief system, later existentialists discussed conflicts of personal principles, cultural norms, and existential despair.

7.2 Music

Existential angst makes its appearance in classical musical composition in the early twentieth century as a result of



Ludger Gerdes, *Angst*, 1989

both philosophical developments and as a reflection of the war-torn times. Notable composers whose works are often linked with the concept include Gustav Mahler, Richard Strauss (operas *Elektra* and *Salome*, Claude-Achille Debussy (opera *Pelleas et Melisande*, ballet *Jeux*, other works), Jean Sibelius (especially the Fourth Symphony), Arnold Schoenberg (*A Survivor from Warsaw*, other works), Alban Berg, Francis Poulenc (opera *Dialogues of the Carmelites*), Dmitri Shostakovich (opera *Lady Macbeth of the Mtsensk District*, symphonies and chamber music), Béla Bartók (opera *Bluebeard's Castle*, other works), and Krzysztof Penderecki (especially *Threnody to the Victims of Hiroshima*).

Angst began to be discussed in reference to popular music in the mid- to late 1950s amid widespread concerns over international tensions and nuclear proliferation. Jeff Nuttall's book *Bomb Culture* (1968) traced angst in popular culture to Hiroshima. Dread was expressed in works of folk rock such as Bob Dylan's *Masters of War* (1963) and *A Hard Rain's a-Gonna Fall*. The term often makes an appearance in reference to punk rock, grunge, nu metal, and works of emo where expressions of melancholy, existential despair or nihilism predominate.

7.3 See also

- Anger
- Byronic hero
- Emotion
- Existentialism
- Kafkaesque
- List of emotions

- Fear of death
- *Sehnsucht*
- Alienation
- *Sturm und Drang*
- Terror management theory
- The Mean Reds
- *Weltschmerz*

7.4 References

- [1] “Angst - Definition of Angst by Merriam-Webster” .
- [2] “Angst - Define Angst at Dictionary.com” . *Dictionary.com*.
- [3] “Online Etymology Dictionary” .
- [4] “Duden - Furcht - Rechtschreibung, Bedeutung, Definition, Synonyme, Herkunft” .
- [5] “Angst - definition of angst by The Free Dictionary” . *The-FreeDictionary.com*.
- [6] Marino, Gordon (March 17, 2012). “The Danish Doctor of Dread” . New York City: The New York Times. Retrieved May 18, 2013.

7.5 External links

- The dictionary definition of angst at Wiktionary

Chapter 8

Philosophy of Søren Kierkegaard

Søren Kierkegaard's philosophy has been a major influence in the development of 20th-century philosophy, especially **existentialism** and **postmodernism**. Kierkegaard was a 19th-century Danish philosopher who has been called the “Father of Existentialism” .*[1] His philosophy also influenced the development of **existential psychology**.*[2]

Kierkegaard criticized aspects of the philosophical systems that were brought on by philosophers such as **Georg Wilhelm Friedrich Hegel** before him and the Danish **Hegelians**. He was also indirectly influenced by the philosophy of **Immanuel Kant**.*[3] He measured himself against the model of philosophy which he found in **Socrates**, which aims to draw one's attention not to explanatory systems, but rather to the issue of how one exists.*[4]

One of Kierkegaard's recurrent themes is the importance of subjectivity, which has to do with the way people relate themselves to (objective) truths. In *Concluding Unscientific Postscript to Philosophical Fragments*, he argues that “subjectivity is truth” and “truth is subjectivity.” What he means by this is that most essentially, truth is not just a matter of discovering objective facts. While objective facts are important, there is a second and more crucial element of truth, which involves how one relates oneself to those matters of fact. Since how one acts is, from the ethical perspective, more important than any matter of fact, truth is to be found in subjectivity rather than objectivity.*[5]

8.1 Note on pseudonyms

See also: **Indirect Communication and Pseudonymous Authorship**

Many of Kierkegaard's earlier writings from 1843 to 1846 were written pseudonymously. In the non-pseudonymous *The Point of View of My Work as an Author*, he explained that the pseudonymous works are written from perspectives which are not his own: while Kierkegaard himself was a religious author, the pseudonymous authors wrote from points

of view that were aesthetic or speculative. One exception to this is *Anti-Climacus*, a pseudonymous author developed after the writing of *The Point of View*: Anti-Climacus is a religious author who writes from a Christian perspective so ideal that Kierkegaard did not wish it to be attributed to himself.*[6]

Because the pseudonymous authors write from perspectives which are not Kierkegaard's own, some of the philosophy mentioned in this article may or may not necessarily reflect Kierkegaard's own beliefs. Just as other philosophers bring up viewpoints in their essays to discuss and criticize them, Kierkegaard assigns pseudonyms to explore a particular viewpoint in-depth, which may take up a whole book or two in some instances, and Kierkegaard, or another pseudonym, critiques that position. For example, the author, *Johannes Climacus* is not a Christian and he argues from a non-Christian viewpoint. *Anti-Climacus*, as mentioned earlier, is a Christian to a high degree and he argues from a devout Christian viewpoint. Kierkegaard places his beliefs in-between these two authors.*[6]

Most of Kierkegaard's later philosophical and religious writings from 1846 to 1855 were written and authored by himself, and he assigned no pseudonyms to these works. Subsequently, these works are considered by most scholars to reflect Kierkegaard's own beliefs.*[7] Where appropriate, this article will mention the respective author, pseudonymous or not.

8.2 Themes in his philosophy

8.2.1 Alienation

Alienation is a term philosophers apply to a wide variety of phenomena, including any feeling of separation from, and discontent with, society; feeling that there is a moral breakdown in society; feelings of powerlessness in the face of the solidity of social institutions; the impersonal, dehumanised nature of large-scale and bureaucratic social or-

ganisations.* [8] Kierkegaard recognizes and accepts the notion of alienation, although he phrases it and understands it in his own distinctly original terms. For Kierkegaard, the present age is a reflective age—one that values objectivity and thought over action, lip-service to ideals rather than action, discussion over action, publicity and advertising over reality, and fantasy over the real world. For Kierkegaard, the meaning of values has been removed from life, by lack of finding any true and legitimate authority. Instead of falling into any claimed authority, any “literal” sacred book or any other great and lasting voice, self-aware humans must confront an existential uncertainty.

Humanity has lost meaning because the accepted criterion of reality and truth is ambiguous and subjective thought—that which cannot be proven with logic, historical research, or scientific analysis. Humans cannot think out choices in life, we must live them; and even those choices that we often think about become different once life itself enters into the picture. For Kierkegaard, the type of objectivity that a scientist or historian might use misses the point—humans are not motivated and do not find meaning in life through pure objectivity. Instead, they find it through passion, desire, and moral and religious commitment. These phenomena are not objectively provable—nor do they come about through any form of analysis of the external world; they come about through a direct relationship between one and the external world. Here Kierkegaard's emphasis is on relationship rather than analysis. This relationship is a way of looking at one's life that evades objective scrutiny.

Kierkegaard's analysis of the present age uses terms that resemble but are not exactly coincident with Hegel and Marx's theory of alienation. However Kierkegaard expressly means that human beings are alienated from God because they are living too much in the world. Individuals need to gain their souls from the world because it actually belongs to God. Kierkegaard has no interest in external battles as Karl Marx does. His concern is about the inner fight for faith.

Let us speak further about the wish and thereby about sufferings. Discussion of sufferings can always be beneficial if it addresses not only the self-willfulness of the sorrow but, if possible, addresses the sorrowing person for his upbuilding. It is a legitimate and sympathetic act to dwell properly on the suffering, lest the suffering person become impatient over our superficial discussion in which he does not recognize his suffering, lest he for that reason impatiently thrust aside consolation and be strengthened in double-mindedness. It certainly is one thing to go out into life with the wish when what is wished becomes the deed and the task; it is something else to go out into life away from the wish.

Abraham had to leave his ancestral home and emigrate to an alien nation, where nothing reminded him of what he loved – indeed, sometimes it is no doubt a consolation that nothing calls to mind what one wishes to forget, but it is a bitter consolation for the person who is full of longing. Thus a person can also have a wish that for him contains everything, so that in the hour of the separation, when the pilgrimage begins, it is as if he were emigrating to a foreign country where nothing but the contrast reminds him, by the loss, of what he wished; it can seem to him as if he were emigrating to a foreign country even if he remains at home perhaps in the same locality – by losing the wish just as among strangers, so that to take leave of the wish seems to him harder and more crucial than to take leave of his senses.

Apart from this wish, even if he still does not move from the spot, his life's troublesome way is perhaps spent in useless sufferings, for we are speaking of those who suffer essentially, not of those who have the consolation that their sufferings are for the benefit of a good cause, for the benefit of others. It was bound to be thus – the journey to the foreign country was not long; in one moment he was there, there in that strange country where the suffering ones meet, but not those who have ceased to grieve, not those whose tears eternity cannot wipe away, for as an old devotional book so simply and movingly says, “How can God dry your tears in the next world if you have not wept?” Perhaps someone else comes in a different way, but to the same place.

- Søren Kierkegaard, *Upbuilding Discourses in Various Spirits*, Hong 1993 p. 102-103

Albert Camus wrote about the idea of being a stranger in the world but reversed Kierkegaard's meaning. A stranger for Camus was someone living in the world who is forced to exist in a Christian way even though the individual does not want to be a Christian. But Kierkegaard was discussing the Christian who wants to be a Christian living in a world that has abandoned Christianity. Both Camus and Kierkegaard had in common an equal distaste for a Christian Democracy where all are forced to take a positive part in Christianity because freedom of choice would be lacking and in a non-Christian Democracy where none are allowed to take an active part in Christianity. Kierkegaard was against voting about Christianity, for him, Christ was the only authority. Camus called “the existential attitude philosophical suicide.” This is how he put it in *The Myth of Sisyphus and Other Writings*

Now, it is admitted that the absurd is the con-

trary of hope, it is seen that existential thought for Chestov (Lev Shestov 1866-1938) presupposes the absurd but proves it only to dispel it. Such subtlety of thought is a conjuror's emotional trick. When Chestov elsewhere sets his absurd in opposition to current morality and reason, he calls it truth and redemption. Hence, there is basically in that definition of the absurd an approbation that Chestov grants it. What is perceptible in Leo Chestov will be perhaps even more so in Kierkegaard. To be sure, it is hard to outline clear propositions in so elusive a writer. But, despite apparently opposed writings, beyond the pseudonyms, the tricks, and the smiles, can be felt throughout that work, as it were, the presentiment (at the same time as the apprehension) of a truth which eventually bursts forth in the last works: Kierkegaard likewise takes the leap. Kierkegaard's view that despair is not a fact but a state: the very state of sin. For sin is what alienates from God. The absurd, which is the metaphysical state of the consciousness of man, does not lead to God. Perhaps this notion will become clearer if I risk this shocking statement: the absurd is sin without God. It is a matter of living in that state of the absurd. I am taking the liberty at this point of calling the existential attitude philosophical suicide. But this does not imply a judgment. It is a convenient way of indicating the movement by which a thought negates itself and tends to transcend itself in its very negation. For the existential negation is their God. To be precise, that god is maintained only through the negation of human reason. (Let me assert again: it is not the affirmation of God that is questioned here, but rather the logic leading to that affirmation.) Albert Camus, *The Myth of Sisyphus and other essays* p. 26-32 Vintage books 1955 Alfred A Knopf

Kierkegaard put it this way in *Three Edifying Discourses* 1843 and *Concluding Unscientific Postscript* (1846).

Getting the majority vote on one's side and one's God-relationship transformed into a speculative enterprise on the basis of probability and partnership and fellow shareholders is the first step toward becoming objective.

- *Concluding Unscientific Postscript*, Hong p. 66

The love which covers a multitude of sins in never deceived. When the heart is niggardly, when one

gives with one eye and with seven eyes looks to see what one will get in return, then one easily discovers a multitude of sins. But when the heart is filled with love, then the eye is never deceived; for love when it gives, does not scrutinize the gift, but its eye is fixed on the Lord. When the heart is filled with envy, then the eye has power to call forth uncleanness even in the pure; but when love dwells in the heart, then the eye has the power to foster the good in the unclean; but this eye does not see the evil but the pure, which it loves and encourages it by loving it. Certainly there is a power in this world which by its words turns good into evil, but there is a power above which turns the evil into good; that power is the love which covers a multitude of sins.

When hate dwells in the heart, then sin lies at a man's door, and its manifold desires exist in him; but when love dwells in the heart, then sin flees far away, and he sees it no more. When disputes, malice, wrath, quarrels, dissensions, factions fill the heart, does one then need to go far in order to discover the multitudinousness of sin, or does a man need to love very long to produce these outside of himself! But when joy, peace, longsuffering, gentleness, goodness, faith, meekness and temperance dwell in the heart, what wonder, then, that a man, even if he were surrounded by a multitude of sins, remains an alien, a stranger, who understands only a very little about the customs of the country, even if these were explained to him? Would not this, then, be a covering of the multitude of sins?

- Soren Kierkegaard *Three Edifying Discourses* 1843, Swenson translation 1943 p. 69

Love does not seek its own. Love does not seek its own, for there are no mine and yours in love. But "mine" and "yours" are only relational specifications of "one's own"; thus, if there are no mine and yours, there is no "one's own" either. But if there is no "one's own" at all, then it is of course impossible to seek one's own. Justice is identified by its giving each his own, just as it also in turn claims its own. This means that justice pleads the cause of its own, divides and assigns, determines what each can lawfully call his own, judges and punishes if anyone refuses to make any distinction between mine and yours. The individual has the right to so as he pleases with this contentious and yet legally entitled mine; and if he seeks his own in no other way than that which justice allows, justice has nothing

with which to reproach him and has no right to upbraid him for anything. As soon as someone is defrauded of his own, or as soon as someone defrauds another of his own, justice intervenes, because it safeguards the common security in which everyone has his own, which he rightfully has.- But sometimes a change intrudes, a revolution, a war, an earthquake, or some such terrible misfortune, and everything is confused. Justice tries in vain to secure for each person his own; it cannot maintain the distinction between mine and yours; in the confusion it cannot keep the balance and therefore throws away the scales-it despairs! Terrible spectacle! Yet does not love in a certain sense, even if in the most blissful way, produce the same confusion? But love, it too is an event, the greatest of all, yet also the happiest. Love is a change, the most remarkable of all, but the most desirable-in fact we say in a very good sense that someone who is gripped by love is changed or becomes changed. Love is a revolution, the most profound of all, but the most blessed!

- Søren Kierkegaard, *Works of Love*, 1847, Hong 1995 264-265

8.2.2 Abstraction

An element of Kierkegaard's critique of modernity in his socio-political work, *Two Ages*, is the mention of **money**—which he calls an **abstraction**.^[9]^[10] An abstraction is something that only has a reality in an *ersatz* reality. It is not tangible, and only has meaning within an artificial context, which ultimately serves devious and deceptive purposes. It is a figment of thought that has no **concrete** reality, neither now nor in the future.

How is money an abstraction? Money gives the illusion that it has a direct relationship to the work that is done. That is, the work one does is worth so much, equals so much money. In reality, however, the work one does is an expression of who one is as a person; it expresses one's goals in life and associated meaning. As a person, the work one performs is supposed to be an external realization of one's relationship to others and to the world. It is one's way of making the world a better place for oneself and for others. What reducing work to a monetary value does is to replace the concrete reality of one's everyday struggles with the world—to give it shape, form and meaning—with an abstraction. Kierkegaard lamented that “a young man today would scarcely envy another his capacities or skill or the love of a beautiful girl or his fame, no, but he would envy him his money. Give me money, the young man will say, and I will be all right.”^[11] But Kierkegaard thinks

this emphasis on money leads to a denial of the gifts of the spirit to those who are poor and in misery.

Do not forget to do good and to share – Hebrews 13.16 - But do not forget either that this incessant talk by worldliness about beneficence and benevolence and generosity and charitable donations and gift upon gift is almost merciless. Ah, let the newspaper writers and tax collectors and parish beadles talk about generosity and count and count; but let us never ignore that Christianity speaks essentially of mercifulness, that Christianity would least of all be guilty of mercilessness, as if poverty and misery not only needed money etc. but also were excluded from the highest, from being able to be generous, beneficent, benevolent. But people prattle and prate ecclesiastically-worldly and worldly-ecclesiastically about generosity, beneficence-but forget, even in the sermon, mercifulness. Preaching should indeed be solely and only about mercifulness. If you know how to speak effectually about this, then generosity will follow of itself and come by itself accordingly as the individual is capable of it. But bear in mind, that if a person raised money, money, money by speaking about generosity-bear this in mind, that by being silent about mercifulness he would be acting mercilessly toward the poor and miserable person for whom he procured relief by means of the money of wealthy generosity. Bear this I mind, that if poverty and misery disturb us with their pleas, we can of course manage to get help for them through generosity; but bear this in mind, that it would be much more appalling if we constrained poverty and misery “to hinder our prayers,” as Scripture says (1 Peter 3:7), by grumbling against us to God-because we were atrociously unfair to poverty and misery by not telling that they are able to practice mercifulness. We shall now adhere to this point in this discourse about mercifulness and guard ourselves against confusing mercifulness with what is linked to external conditions, that is, what love as such does not have in its power, whereas it truly has mercifulness in its power just as surely as it has a heart in its bosom. It does not follow that because a person has a heart in his bosom he has money in his pocket, but the first is still more important and certainly is decisive with regard to mercifulness. Søren Kierkegaard, *Works of Love* Hong 1995 p. 315-316

Below are three quotes concerning Kierkegaard's idea of abstraction which cannot be thought about without thinking

about concretion. He moves from the world historical, the general, to the single individual, the specific. The first from the esthete and the second from the ethicist in *Either/Or* and the third from the book that explained all his previous works; *Concluding Unscientific Postscript*.

As has already been noted above, all classic productions stand equally high, because each one stands infinitely high. If, despite this fact, one were to attempt to introduce an order of rank into the classic procession, one would evidently have to choose as a basis for such a distinction, something that was not essential; for if the basis were essential, the difference itself would become an essential difference; from that it would again follow that the word "classic" was wrongly predicated of the group as a whole. The more abstract the idea is, the smaller the probability of a numerous representation. But how does the idea become concrete? By being permeated with the historical consciousness. The more concrete the idea, the greater the probability. The more abstract the medium, the smaller the probability; the more concrete, the greater. But what does it mean to say that the medium is concrete, other than to say it is language, or is seen in approximation to language; for language is the most concrete of all media. The idea, for example, which comes to expression in sculpture is wholly abstract, and bears no relation to the historical; the medium through which it is expressed is likewise abstract, consequently there is a great probability that the section of the classic works which includes sculpture will contain only a few. In this I have the testimony of time and experience on my side. If, on the other hand, I take a concrete idea and a concrete medium, then it seems otherwise. Homer is indeed a classic poet, but just because the epic idea is a concrete idea, and because the medium is language, it so happens that in the section of the classics which contains the epic, there are many epics conceivable, which are all equally classic, because history constantly furnishes us with new epic material. In this too, I have the testimony of history and the assent of experience. *Either/Or Part I*, Swenson p. 49, 53

The two positions touched on here could be regarded as attempts to actualize an ethical life-view. The reason that they do not succeed is that the individual has chosen himself in his isolation or has chosen himself abstractly. To say it in other words, the individual has not chosen himself ethically. He therefore has no connec-

tion with actuality, and when that is the case no ethical way of life can be put into practice. But the person who chooses himself ethically chooses himself concretely as this specific individual, and he achieves this concretion because this choice is identical with the repentance, which ratifies the choice. The individual with these capacities, these inclinations, these drives, these passions, influenced by this specific social milieu, as this specific product of a specific environment. But as he becomes aware of all this, he takes upon himself responsibility for all of it. He does not hesitate over whether he will take this particular thing or not, for he knows that if he does not do it something much more important will be lost. In the moment of choice, he is in complete isolation, for he withdraws from his social milieu, and yet at the same moment he is in absolute continuity, for he chooses himself as a product. And this choice is freedom's choice in such a way that in choosing himself as product he can just as well be said to produce himself. At the moment of choice, he is at the point of consummation, for his personality is consummating itself, and yet at the same moment he is at the very beginning, because he is choosing himself according to his freedom. *Either/Or Part II*, Hong p. 251

When in pure thinking mention is made of an immediate unity of reflection-in-itself and reflection-in-the-other and of the annulment of this immediate unity, then something must indeed come between the elements of the immediate unity. What is this? Yes, it is time. But time cannot be assigned a place within pure thinking. What, then, do annulment and transition and a new unity signify? What, if anything, does it mean to think in such a way that one always merely makes a show of it because everything that is said is absolutely revoked? And what does it mean not to admit that one thinks this way but then continually to proclaim from the housetops the positive truth of this pure thinking? Just as existence has joined thinking and existing, inasmuch as an existing person is a thinking person, so are there two media: the medium of abstraction and the medium of actuality. But pure thinking is yet a third medium, very recently invented. It begins, it is said, after the most exhaustive abstraction. Pure thinking is-what shall I say-piously or thoughtlessly unaware of the relation that abstraction still continually has to that from which it abstracts. Here in this pure thinking there is rest for every doubt; here is the eter-

nal positive truth and whatever one cares to say. This means that pure thinking is a phantom. And if Hegelian philosophy is free from all postulates, it has attained this with one insane postulate: the beginning of pure thinking. For the existing person, existing is for him his highest interest, and his interestedness in existing in his actuality. What actuality is cannot be rendered in the language of abstraction. Actuality is an *interesse* [between being] between thinking and being in the hypothetical unity of abstraction. Abstraction deals with possibility and actuality, but its conception of actuality is a false rendition, since the medium is not actuality but possibility. Only by annulling actuality can abstraction grasp it, but to annul it is precisely to change it into possibility. Within abstraction everything that is said about actuality in the language of abstraction is said within possibility. That is, in the language of actuality all abstraction is related to actuality as a possibility, not to an actuality within abstraction and possibility. Actuality, existence, is the dialectical element in a trilogy, the beginning and end of which cannot be for an existing person, who *qua* existing is in the dialectical element. Abstraction merges the trilogy. Quite right. But how does it do it? Is abstraction a something that does it, or is it not the act of the abstractor? But the abstractor is, after all, an existing person, and as an existing person is consequently in the dialectical element, which he cannot mediate or merge, least of all absolutely, as long as he is existing. If he does do it, then this must be related as a possibility to actuality, to the existence which he himself is. He must explain how he goes about it—that is, how he as an existing person goes about it, or whether he ceases to be an existing person, and whether an existing person has a right to do that. As soon as we begin to ask such questions, we are asking ethically and are maintaining the claim of the ethical upon the existing person, which cannot be that he is supposed to abstract from existence, but that he is supposed to exist, which is also the existing person's highest interest.

- Søren Kierkegaard, *Concluding Unscientific Postscript*, Vol 1, p. 314-315 Hong translation

8.2.3 Death

Death is inevitable and temporally unpredictable. Kierkegaard believed that individuals needed to sin-

cerely and intensely come to realize the truth of that fact in order to live passionately. Kierkegaard accuses society of being in death-denial. Even though people see death all around them and grasp as an objective fact that everyone dies, few people truly understand, subjectively and inwardly, that they will die someday. For example, in *Concluding Unscientific Postscript*, Kierkegaard notes that people never think to say, “I shall certainly attend your party, but I must make an exception for the contingency that a roof tile happens to blow down and kill me; for in that case, I cannot attend.” *[12] This is just as far as Kierkegaard is concerned. But there is also earnestness involved in the thought of death. Kierkegaard said the following about death in his *Three Upbuilding Discourses*, 1844.

We shall not decide which life fights the good fight most easily, but we all agree that every human being ought to fight the good fight, from which no one is shut out, and yet this is so glorious that if it were granted only once to a past generation under exceptional circumstances—yes, what a description envy and discouragement would then know how to give! The difference is about the same as that in connection with the thought of death. As soon as a human being is born, he begins to die. But the difference is that there are some people for whom the thought of death comes into existence with birth and is present to them in the quiet peacefulness of childhood and the buoyancy of youth; whereas others have a period in which this thought is not present to them until, when the years run out, the years of vigor and vitality, the thought of death meets them on their way. Who, now, is going to decide which life was easier, whether it was the life of those who continually lived with a certain reserve because the thought of death was present to them or the life of those who so abandoned themselves to life that they almost forgot the existence of death?*[13]

8.2.4 Dread or anxiety

For Kierkegaard's author, *Vigilius Haufniensis*, anxiety/dread/angst (depending on the translation and context) is unfocused fear. Haufniensis uses the example of a man standing on the edge of a tall building or cliff. From this height he can see all the possibilities of life. He's reflecting on what he could become if he only threw himself into the power of his own choice. As long as he stands there he stands at the crossroads of life, unable to make a decision and live within its boundaries. The

mere fact that one has the possibility and freedom to do something, even the most terrifying of possibilities, triggers immense feelings of dread. Haufniensis called this our “dizziness of freedom.”

Anxiety may be compared with dizziness. He whose eye happens to look down into the yawning abyss becomes dizzy. But what is the reason for this? It is just as much in his own eye as in the abyss, for suppose he had not looked down. Hence, anxiety is the dizziness of freedom, which emerges when the spirit wants to posit the synthesis and freedom looks down into its own possibility, laying hold of finiteness to support itself. Freedom succumbs to dizziness. Further than this, psychology cannot and will not go. In that very moment everything is changed, and freedom, when it again rises, sees that it is guilty. Between these two moments lies the leap, which no science has explained and which no science can explain. He who becomes guilty in anxiety becomes as ambiguously guilty as it is possible to become. Vigilius Haufniensis, *The Concept of Anxiety* p. 61

In *The Concept of Anxiety*, Haufniensis focuses on the first anxiety experienced by man: Adam's choice to eat from God's forbidden tree of knowledge or not. Since the concepts of good and evil did not come into existence before Adam ate the fruit, which is now dubbed original sin, Adam had no concept of good and evil, and did not know that eating from the tree was evil. What he did know was that God told him not to eat from the tree. The anxiety comes from the fact that God's prohibition itself implies that Adam is free and that he could choose to obey God or not. After Adam ate from the tree, sin was born. So, according to Kierkegaard, anxiety precedes sin, and it is anxiety that leads Adam to sin. Haufniensis mentions that anxiety is the presupposition for hereditary sin.

However, Haufniensis mentions that anxiety is a way for humanity to be saved as well. Anxiety informs us of our choices, our self-awareness and personal responsibility, and brings us from a state of un-self-conscious immediacy to self-conscious reflection. (Jean-Paul Sartre calls these terms pre-reflexive consciousness and reflexive consciousness.) An individual becomes truly aware of their potential through the experience of dread. So, anxiety may be a possibility for sin, but anxiety can also be a recognition or realization of one's true identity and freedoms.

Whoever has learned to be anxious in the right way has learned the ultimate. ...Anxiety is freedom's possibility, and only such anxiety

is through faith absolutely educative, because it consumes all finite ends and discovers all their deceptiveness. And no Grand Inquisitor has such dreadful torments in readiness as anxiety has, and no secret agent knows as cunningly as anxiety to attack his suspect in his weakest moment or to make alluring the trap in which he will be caught, and no discerning judge understands how to interrogate and examine the accused as does anxiety, which never lets the accused escape, neither through amusement, nor by noise, nor during work, neither by day nor by night.

—Vigilius Haufniensis, *The Concept of Anxiety* p. 155-156

8.2.5 Despair

Is despair a merit or a defect? Purely dialectically it is both. If one were to think of despair only in the abstract, without reference to some particular despairer, one would have to say it is an enormous merit. The possibility of this sickness is man's advantage over the beast, and it is an advantage which characterizes him quite otherwise than the upright posture, for it bespeaks the infinite erectness or loftiness of his being spirit. The possibility of this sickness is man's advantage over the beast; to be aware of this sickness is the Christian's advantage over natural man; to be cured of this sickness is the Christian's blessedness.

—Anti-Climacus, *The Sickness Unto Death* p. 45

Most emphatically in *The Sickness Unto Death*, Kierkegaard's author argues that the human self is a composition of various aspects that must be brought into conscious balance: the finite, the infinite, a consciousness of the “relationship of the two to itself,” and a consciousness of “the power that posited” the self. The finite (limitations such as those imposed by one's body or one's concrete circumstances) and the infinite (those capacities that free us from limitations such as imagination) always exist in a state of tension. That tension between two aspects of the “self” that must be brought into balance. When the self is out of balance, i.e., has the wrong understanding of who it is because it conceives itself too much in terms of its own limiting circumstances (and thus fails to recognize its own freedom to determine what it will be) or too much in terms of what it would like to be, (thus ignoring its own circumstances), the person is in a state of despair.

Notably, Anti-Climacus says one can be in despair even if one feels perfectly happy. Despair is not just an emotion, in a deeper sense it is the loss of self, i.e., it describes the state when one has the wrong conception of oneself. In *Either/Or*, A and *Judge William* each has one epistolary novel in two volumes. The A is an aesthete well aware that he can use the power of interpretation to define who he is and what he takes to be valuable. He knows he can shape and reshape his own self-identity. Nothing binds him to his relationships. Nothing binds him to his past actions. In the end though, he also knows he lacks a consistent understanding of who he is. He lacks a self that resists his own power of reinterpretation. His older friend *Judge William*, argues that a deeper concept of selfhood is discovered as one commits to one's actions, and takes ownership of the past and present. A concept of oneself, as this particular human being, begins to take form in one's own consciousness. Another perspective, one in which an individual can find some measure of freedom from despair, is available for the person with religious "faith." This attunes the individual so that he or she can recognize what has always been there: a self to be realized within the circumstances it finds itself right now, i.e., this inner attunement brings about a sort of synthesis between the infinite and the finite. In *Fear and Trembling*, *Johannes de Silentio* argues that the choice of Abraham to obey the private, unethical, commandment of God to sacrifice his son reveals what faith entails: he directs his consciousness absolutely toward "the absolute" rather than the merely ethical, i.e., he practices an inner spirituality that seeks to be "before god" rather than seeking to understand himself as an ethically upright person. His God requires more than being good, he demands that he seek out an inner commitment to him. If Abraham were to blithely obey, his actions would have no meaning. It is only when he acts *with fear and trembling* that he demonstrates a full awareness that murdering a son is absolutely wrong, ethically speaking.

Despair has several specific levels that a person can find themselves, each one further in despair than the last as laid out in *The Sickness Unto Death*.

The first level is "The despair that is ignorant of being despair or the despairing ignorance of having a self and an eternal self." Essentially this level is one which has the wrong conception of what a self is, i.e., is ignorant of how to realize the self one already potentially is. In this sense, the person does not recognize his own despair because he often measures the success of his life based on whether he himself judges himself to be happy. Regardless of whether you know you are in despair or not, Kierkegaard asserts, you can still be in that state. He notes that this is the most common in the world.

The next level of despair is "The despair that is conscious of being despair and therefore is conscious of having a self in which there is something eternal and then either in despair does not will to be itself or in despair wills to be itself." The first form of this conscious despair is "In despair not to will or want to be oneself." This becomes further subdivided into three categories: the one already mentioned, the despair not to will to be a self, and lowest, the despair to wish for a new self. These three divisions are mostly the self-worth the person has and the amount to which they understand their own despair. The despair to not be oneself is pretty straightforward. A person sees themselves as unworthy and as such does not see themselves as worthy before something they do not understand. The despair not to be a self is deeper, because to not wish to be a self is to wish to not have a relation to God or at the very least see one's relation to God as unworthy, and thus shrink from it. The lowest form of this group, however, is the desire to be a new self. This is logically the deepest form as it assumes the deepest understanding of one's despair. Once in despair, without a complete relation to God one will always be in despair, so to be in this level one understands the permanence of the despair. The despair in this group arises from the nature of sensate things and physical desires. These three subgroups are also grouped under the heading "Despair over the earthly."

The second level of conscious despair under the heading "Despair over the eternal." Someone in this level views themselves in light of their own weakness. Unlike in the upper level, this weakness is understood and as such, instead of turning to faith and humbling oneself before God, they despair in their own weakness and unworthiness. In this sense, they despair over the eternal and refuse to be comforted by the light of God.

The last and lowest form of despair is the desire "In despair to will to be oneself." This last form of despair is also referred to by Kierkegaard as "demonic despair" (Note that the term demonic is used in the Classical Greek Sense, not the modern sense). In this form of despair, the individual finds him or herself in despair, understands they are in despair, seeks some way to alleviate it, and yet no help is forthcoming. As a result, the self becomes hardened against any form of help and "Even if God in heaven and all the angels offered him aid, he would not want it." At this level of despair the individual revels in their own despair and sees their own pain as lifting them up above the base nature of other humans who do not find themselves in this state. This is the least common form of despair and Kierkegaard claims it is mostly found in true poets. This despair can also be called the despair of defiance, as it is the despair that strikes out against all that is eternal. One last note is that as one travels further down the forms of despair, the number of people in each group becomes fewer.

8.2.6 Ethics



In Fear and Trembling, Johannes de Silentio analyzes Abraham's action to sacrifice Isaac. Silentio argues that Abraham is a knight of faith.

Many philosophers who initially read Kierkegaard, especially Kierkegaard's (written under the pseudonym of *Johannes de Silentio*) *Fear and Trembling*, often come to the conclusion that Kierkegaard supports a **divine command** law of ethics. The divine command theory is a **metaethical** theory which claims moral values are whatever is commanded by a god or gods. However, Kierkegaard is not arguing that morality is created by **God**; instead, he would argue that a divine command from God *transcends* ethics. This distinction means that God does not necessarily create human morality: it is up to us as individuals to create our own morals and values. But any religious person must be prepared for the event of a divine command from God that would take precedence over all moral and rational obligations. Kierkegaard called this event the *teleological suspension of the ethical*. Abraham, the **knight of faith**, chose to obey God unconditionally, and was rewarded with his son, his faith, and the title of *Father of Faith*. Abraham transcended ethics and leaped into faith.

But there is no valid logical argument one can make to claim that morality ought to be or can be suspended in any given circumstance, or ever. Thus, Silentio believes ethics and faith are separate stages of consciousness. The choice to obey God unconditionally is a true existential 'either/or' decision faced by the individual. Either one chooses to live in faith (the religious stage) or to live ethically (the ethical stage).

In *Either/Or*, Kierkegaard insists that the single individual has ethical **responsibility** of his life. However, everyone wants to enjoy themselves and ethics gets in the way of a person's enjoyment of life if taken to extremes. This results in a battle between those who want to live for pleasure and

those who demand an ethical existence. But Kierkegaard always points toward the religious goal, an "eternal happiness", or the **salvation** of the **soul** as the highest good. He says, be whatever you want, but remember that your soul belongs to God, not to the world.

By now you have easily seen that in his life the ethical individual goes through stages we previously set forth as **separate stages**. He is going to develop in his life the **personal**, the **civic**, the **religious** virtues, and his life advances through his continually translating himself from one stage to another. As soon as a person thinks that one of these stages is adequate and that he dares to concentrate on it one-sidedly, he has not chosen himself ethically but has failed to see the significance of either isolation or continuity and above all has not grasped that the truth lies in the identity of the two. The person who has ethically chosen and found himself possess himself defined in his entire concretion. He then possesses himself as an **individual** who has these **capacities**, these **passions**, these **inclinations**, these **habits**, who is subject to these external influences, who is influenced in one direction thus and in another thus. Here he then possesses himself as a task in such a way that it is chiefly to order, shape, temper, inflame, control-in short, to produce an evenness in the soul, a harmony, which is the fruit of the personal virtues. *Either/Or Part 2*, Hong p. 262

Resignation has made the **individual** face or has seen to it that he face toward an eternal happiness as the **τέλος** ("end", "purpose", or "goal"). This **τέλος** is not an element among other elements. Thus the both-and of mediation is not much better, even though less naïve, than the previously described jovial chatter that includes everything. At the moment of resignation, of collecting oneself, of choice the individual is allowed to salute the absolute **τέλος**-but then, then comes the mediation. So, too, a dog can be taught to walk on two legs for a moment but then, then comes the mediation, and the dog walks on four legs – mediation also does that. Spiritually understood, a human being's upright walk is his absolute respect for the absolute **τέλος**, otherwise he walks on all fours. When it is a matter of relative elements mediation has its significance (that they are all equal before mediation), but when it is a matter of the absolute end or goal, mediation means that the absolute **τέλος** is reduced to a **relative** **τέλος**. It is not true, either, that the absolute **τέλος** becomes concrete in the relative ends,

because resignation's absolute distinction will at every moment safeguard the absolute τέλος against all fraternizing. It is true that the individual oriented toward the absolute τέλος, is in the relative ends, but he is not in them in such a way that the absolute τέλος is exhausted in them. It is true that before God and before the absolute τέλος we are all equal, but it is not true that God or the absolute τέλος is equal with everything else for me or for a particular individual. It may be very commendable for a particular individual to be a councilor of justice, a good worker in the office, no.1 lover in the society, almost a virtuoso on the flute, captain of the popinjay shooting club, superintendent of the orphanage, a noble and respected father-in short, a devil of a fellow who can both-and has time for everything. But let the councilor take care that he does not become too much a devil of a fellow and proceed to do both all this and have time to direct his life toward the absolute τέλος. In other words, this both-and means that the absolute τέλος is on the same level with everything else. But the absolute τέλος has the remarkable quality of wanting to be the absolute τέλος at every moment. If, then, at the moment of resignation, of collecting oneself, of choice, an individual has understood this, it surely cannot mean that he is supposed to have forgotten it the next moment. Therefore, as I said before, resignation remains in the individual and the task is so far from getting the absolute τέλος mediated into all sorts of both-and that, on the contrary, it is to aim at the form of existence that permanently has the pathos of the great moment. *Concluding Unscientific Postscript*, Hong, p. 400-401

In *Works of Love* and *Purity of Heart*, Kierkegaard skillfully examines Christian ethics and the maxim, *Love Thy Neighbour*.*[14]*[15] Kierkegaard stressed that it was Christianity that “discovered the neighbor” .*[16]

Test it, place as the middle term between the lover and the beloved the neighbor, whom one shall love, place as a middle term between two friends the neighbor, whom one shall love, and you will immediately see jealousy. Yet the neighbor is self-denial's middle term that steps in between self-love's I and I, but also between erotic love's and friendship's I and the other I. Love for the neighbor is therefore the eternal equality in loving. Equality is simply not to make distinctions and eternal equality is unconditionally not to make the slightest distinction, unqualifiedly

not to make the slightest distinction. The essential Christian is itself too weighty, in its movements too earnest to scurry about, dancing, in the frivolity of such facile talk about the higher, highest, and the supremely highest. Think of the most cultured person, one of whom we all admiringly say, “He is so cultured!” Then think of Christianity, which says to him, “You shall love the neighbor!” of course, a certain social courtesy, a politeness toward all people, a friendly condescension toward inferiors, a boldly confident attitude before the mighty, a beautifully controlled freedom of spirit, yes, this is culture – do you believe that it is also loving the neighbor? With the neighbor you have the equality of a human being before God. God is the middle term. Søren Kierkegaard, *Works of Love*, 1847, Hong p. 44-61

8.2.7 Individuality

For Kierkegaard, true individuality is called selfhood. Becoming aware of our true self is our true task and endeavor in life—it is an ethical imperative, as well as preparatory to a true religious understanding. Individuals can exist at a level that is less than true selfhood. We can live, for example, simply in terms of our pleasures—our immediate satisfaction of desires, propensities, or distractions. In this way, we glide through life without direction or purpose. To have a direction, we must have a purpose that defines for us the meaning of our lives. Kierkegaard puts it this way in *Either/Or*,

Here, then, I have your view of life, and, believe me, much of your life will become clear to you if you will consider it along with me as thought-despair. You are a hater of activity in life—quite appropriately, because if there is to be meaning in it life must have continuity, and this your life does not have. You keep busy with your studies, to be sure; you are even diligent; but it is only for your sake, and it is done with as little teleology as possible. Moreover, you are unoccupied; like the laborers in the Gospel standing idle in the marketplace, you stick your hands in your pocket and contemplate life. Now you rest in despair. Nothing concerns you; you step aside for nothing; “If someone threw a roof tile down I would still not step aside.” You are like a dying person. You die daily, not in the profound, earnest sense in which one usually understands these words, but life has lost its reality and you “Always count the days of your life from one

termination-notice to the next.” You let everything pass you by; nothing makes any impact. But then something suddenly comes along that grips you, an idea, a situation, a young girl’s smile, and now you are “involved,” for just on certain occasions you are not “involved,” so at other times you are “at your service” in every way. Whenever there is something going on you join in. You behave in life as you usually do in a crowd. “You work yourself into the tightest group, see to it, if possible, to get yourself shoved up over the others so that you come to be above them, and as soon as you are up there you make yourself as comfortable as possible, and in this way you let yourself be carried through life.” But when the crowd is gone, when the event is over, you again stand on the street corner and look at the world. *Either/Or Part II* p. 195-196, 272ff

In *Sickness Unto Death* specifically Kierkegaard deals with the self as a product of relations. In this sense, a human results from a relation between the Infinite (Noumena, spirit, eternal) and Finite (Phenomena, body, temporal). This does not create a true self, as a human can live without a “self” as he defines it. Instead, the Self or ability for the self to be created from a relation to the Absolute or God (the Self can only be realized through a relation to God) arises as a relation between the relation of the Finite and Infinite relating back to the human. This would be a positive relation.

An individual person, for Kierkegaard, is a particular that no abstract formula or definition can ever capture. Including the individual in “the public” (or “the crowd” or “the herd”) or subsuming a human being as simply a member of a species is a reduction of the true meaning of life for individuals. What philosophy or politics try to do is to categorize and pigeonhole individuals by group characteristics, each with their own individual differences. In *Four Upbuilding Discourses*, 1843 Kierkegaard says the differences aren’t important, the likeness with God is what brings equality.

In the hallowed places, in every upbuilding view of life, the thought arises in a person’s soul that help him to fight the good fight with flesh and blood, with principalities and powers, and in the fight to free himself for equality before God, whether this battle is more a war of aggression against the differences that want to encumber him with worldly favoritism or a defensive war against the differences that want to make him anxious in worldly perdition. Only in this way is equality the divine law, only in this way is the

struggle the truth, only in this way does the victory have validity- only when the single individual fights for himself with himself within himself and does not unseasonably presume to help the whole world to obtain external equality, which is of very little benefit, all the less so because it never existed, if for no other reason than that everyone would come to thank him and become unequal before him, only in this way is equality the divine law. *Eighteen Upbuilding Discourses*, by Søren Kierkegaard Hong, p. 143

Kierkegaard’s critique of the modern age, therefore, is about the loss of what it means to be an individual. Modern society contributes to this dissolution of what it means to be an individual. Through its production of the false idol of “the public”, it diverts attention away from individuals to a mass public that loses itself in abstractions, communal dreams, and fantasies. It is helped in this task by the media and the mass production of products to keep it distracted. Even the fight for temporal equality is a distraction. In *Works of Love* he writes,

To bring about similarity among people in the world, to apportion to people, if possible equally, the conditions of temporality, is indeed something that preoccupies worldliness to a high degree. But even what we may call the well-intentioned worldly effort in this regard never comes to an understanding with Christianity. Well-intentioned worldliness remains piously, if you will, convinced that there must be one temporal condition, one earthly dissimilarity – found by means of calculations and surveys or in whatever other way – that is equality. *Works of Love*, by Søren Kierkegaard, 1847, Hong 1995 p. 71-72 see p. 61-90

Although Kierkegaard attacked “the public”, he is supportive of communities:

In community, the individual is, crucial as the prior condition for forming a community. ... Every individual in the community guarantees the community; the public is a chimera, numerality is everything...
—Søren Kierkegaard, *Journals** [6]

8.2.8 Pathos (passion)

For Kierkegaard, in order to apprehend the absolute, the mind must radically empty itself of objective content. What

supports this radical emptying, however, is the desire for the absolute. Kierkegaard names this desire *Passion*.^{*} [17]

According to Kierkegaard, the human self desires that which is beyond reason. Desire itself appears to be a desire for the infinite, as Plato once wrote. Even the desire to propagate, according to Plato, is a kind of desire for immortality—that is, we wish to live on in time through our children and their children. Erotic love itself appears as an example of this desire for something beyond the purely finite. It is a taste of what could be, if only it could continue beyond the boundaries of time and space. As the analogy implies, humans seek something beyond the here and now. The question remains, however, why is it that human pathos or passion is the most precious thing? In some ways, it might have to do with our status as existential beings. It is not thought that gets us through life—it is action; and what motivates and sustains action is passion, the desire to overcome hardships, pain, and suffering. It is also passion that enables us to die for ideals in the name of a higher reality. While a scientist might see this as plain emotion or simple animal desire, Kierkegaard sees it as that which binds to the source of life itself. The desire to live, and to live in the right way, for the right reasons, and with the right desires, is a holy and sacred force. For Kierkegaard all Christian action should have its ground in love, which is a passion.

If anyone is unwilling to learn from Christianity to love himself in the right way, he cannot love the neighbor either. He can perhaps hold together with another or a few other persons, “through thick and thin,” as it is called, but this is by no means loving the neighbor. To love yourself in the right way and to love the neighbor correspond perfectly to one another, fundamentally they are one and the same thing. When the Law’s *as yourself* has wrested from you the self-love that Christianity sadly enough must presuppose to be in every human being, then you actually have learned to love yourself. The Law is therefore: you shall love yourself in the same way as you love your neighbor when you love him as yourself.

Whoever has any knowledge of people will certainly admit that just as he has often wished to be able to move them to relinquish self-love, he has also had to wish that it were possible to teach them to love themselves. When the hustler wastes his time and powers in the service of the futile, inconsequential pursuits, is that not because he has not learned rightly to love himself? When the light-minded person throws himself almost like a nonentity into the folly of the moment and makes nothing of it, is this not because he does not know how to love himself rightly?

When the depressed person desires to be rid of life, indeed of himself, is this not because he is unwilling to learn earnestly and rigorously to love himself? When someone surrenders to despair because the world or another person has faithlessly left him betrayed, what then is his fault (his innocent suffering is not referred to here) except not loving himself in the right way? When someone self-tormentingly thinks to do God a service by torturing himself, what is his sin except not willing to love himself in the right way? And if, alas, a person presumptuously lays violent hands upon himself, is not his sin precisely this, that he does not rightly love himself in the sense in which a person *ought* to love himself?

Oh, there is a lot of talk in the world about treachery, and faithlessness, and, God help us, it is unfortunately all too true, but still let us never because of this forget that the most dangerous traitor of all is the one every person has within himself. This treachery whether it consists in selfishly loving oneself or consists in selfishly not willing to love oneself in the right way – this treachery is admittedly a secret. No cry is raised as it usually is in the case of treachery and faithlessness. But is it not therefore all the more important that Christianity’s doctrine should be brought to mind again and again, that a person shall love his neighbor as himself, that is as he ought to love himself? ...You shall love – this, then is the word of the royal Law. *Works of Love*, Hong p. 22-24

One can also look at this from the perspective of what the meaning of our existence is. Why suffer what humans have suffered, the pain and despair—what meaning can all of this have? For Kierkegaard, there is no meaning unless passion, the emotions and will of humans, has a divine source.

Passion is closely aligned with faith in Kierkegaard’s thought. Faith as a passion is what drives humans to seek reality and truth in a transcendent world, even though everything we can know intellectually speaks against it. To live and die for a belief, to stake everything one has and is in the belief in something that has a higher meaning than anything in the world—this is belief and passion at their highest.

Kierkegaard wrote of the subjective thinker’s task in his *Concluding Unscientific Postscript*. Intellectual reason had been deified by Hegel in his theology and Kierkegaard felt this would lead to the objectification of religion.

There is an old proverb: *oratio, tentatio, meditatio, faciunt theologum* [prayer, trial, meditation, make a theologian]. Similarly, for a subjec-

tive thinker, **imagination**, **feeling** and dialectics in impassioned existence-inwardness are required. But first and last, passion, because for an existing person it is impossible to think about existence without becoming passionate, inasmuch as existing is a prodigious contradiction from which the subjective thinker is not to abstract, for then it is easy, but in which he is to remain. In a world-historical dialectic, individuals fade away into humankind; in a dialectic such as that it is impossible to discover you and me, an individual existing human being, even if new magnifying glasses for the concrete are invented. The subjective thinker is a **dialectician** oriented to the **existential**; he has the intellectual passion to hold firm the qualitative disjunction. But, on the other hand, if the qualitative disjunction is used flatly and simply, if it is applied altogether abstractly to the **individual human being**, then one can run the ludicrous risk of saying something infinitely decisive, and of being right in what one says, and still not say the least thing. Therefore, in the psychological sense it is really remarkable to see the absolute disjunction deceitfully used simply for evasion. When the death penalty is placed on every crime, the result is that no crimes at all are punished. It is the same with the absolute disjunction when applied flatly and simply; it is just like a silent letter—it cannot be pronounced or, if it can be pronounced, it says nothing. The **subjective thinker**, therefore, has with intellectual **passion** the absolute disjunction as belonging to existence, but he has it as the final decision that prevents everything from ending in a quantifying. Thus he has it readily available, but not in such a way that by abstractly recurring to it, he just frustrates **existence**. The subjective thinker, therefore, has also **esthetic** passion and **ethical** passion, whereby concretion is gained. All existence-issues are passionate, because existence, if one becomes **conscious** of it, involves passion. To think about them so as to leave out passion is not to think about them at all, is to forget the point that one indeed is oneself and existing person. Yet the subjective thinker is not a poet even if he is also a poet, not an ethicist even if he is also an ethicist, but is also a dialectician and is himself essentially existing, whereas the poet's existence is inessential in relation to the poem, and likewise the ethicist's in relation to the teaching, and the dialectician's in relation to the thought. The subjective thinker is not a scientist-scholar; he is an artist. To exist is an art. The subjective thinker is esthetic enough for his life to have esthetic content, ethical enough to

regulate it, dialectical enough in thinking to master it. The subjective thinker's task is to understand himself in existence. p. 350-351

8.2.9 Subjectivity

Johannes Climacus, in *Concluding Unscientific Postscript to Philosophical Fragments*, writes the following cryptic line: "Subjectivity is Truth". To understand Climacus's concept of the individual, it is important to look at what he says regarding subjectivity. What is subjectivity? In very rough terms, subjectivity refers to what is personal to the individual—what makes the individual *who he is in distinction from others*. It is what is inside—what the individual can see, feel, think, imagine, dream, etc. It is often opposed to objectivity—that which is outside the individual, which the individual and others around can feel, see, measure, and think about. Another way to interpret subjectivity is the *unique* relationship between the subject and object.

Johann Fichte wrote similarly about subjectivity in his 1799 book *The Vocation of Man*.

I must, however, remind my reader that the "I" who speaks in the book is not the author himself, but it is his earnest wish that the reader should himself assume this character, and that he should not rest contented with a mere historical apprehension of what is here said, but really and truly, during reading, hold converse with himself, deliberate, draw conclusions, and form resolutions, like his representative in the book, and, by his own labour and reflection, developed out of his own soul, and build up within himself, that mode of thought the mere picture of which is laid before him in the work. Preface

Scientists and historians, for example, study the objective world, hoping to elicit the truth of nature—or perhaps the truth of **history**. In this way, they hope to predict how the future will unfold in accordance with these laws. In terms of history, by studying the past, the individual can perhaps elicit the laws that determine how events will unfold—in this way the individual can predict the future with more exactness and perhaps take control of events that in the past appeared to fall outside the control of humans.

In most respects, Climacus did not have problems with science or the scientific endeavor. He would not disregard the importance of objective knowledge. Where the scientist or historian finds certainty, however, Climacus noted very accurately that results in science change as the tools of observation change. But Climacus's special interest was in history. His most vehement attacks came against those who

believed that they had understood history and its laws—and by doing so could ascertain what a human's true self is. That is, the assumption is that by studying history someone can come to know who he really is as a person. Kierkegaard especially accused Hegel's philosophy of falling prey to this assumption. He explained this in, *Concluding Unscientific Postscript*:

It is the existing **spirit** who asks about **truth**, presumably because he wants to exist in it, but in any case the questioner is **conscious** of being an existing individual human being. In this way I believe I am able to make myself understandable to every Greek and to every **rational** human being. If a German philosopher follows his inclination to put on an act and first transforms himself into a superrational something, just as alchemists and sorcerers bedizen themselves fantastically, in order to answer the question about truth in an extremely satisfying way, this is of no more concern to me than his satisfying answer, which no doubt is extremely satisfying—if one is fantastically dressed up. But whether a German philosopher is or is not doing this can easily be ascertained by anyone who with enthusiasm concentrates his soul on willing to allow himself to be guided by a sage of that kind, and uncritically just uses his guidance compliantly by willing to form his **existence** according to it. When a person as a **learner** enthusiastically relates in this way to such a German professor, he accomplishes the most superb epigram upon him, because a speculator of that sort is anything but served by a learner's honest and enthusiastic zeal for expressing and accomplishing, for existentially appropriating his **wisdom**, since this wisdom is something that the Herr Professor himself has **imagined** and has written books about but has never attempted himself. It has not even occurred to him that it should be done. Like the customers clerk who, in the belief that his business was merely to write, wrote what he himself could not read, so there are speculative thinkers who merely write, and write that which, if it is to be read with the aid of action, if I may put it that way, proves to be nonsense, unless it is perhaps intended only for fantastical beings. P. 191

Hegel wanted to philosophize about Christianity but had no intention to ever become a Christian. For Climacus, the individual comes to know who he is by an intensely personal and passionate pursuit of what will give meaning to his life. As an existing individual, who must come to terms with everyday life, overcome its obstacles and setbacks, who must

live and die, the single individual has a life that no one else will ever live. In dealing with what life brings his way, the individual must encounter them with all his psycho-physical resources.

Subjectivity is that which the individual—and no one else—has. But what does it mean to have something like this? It cannot be understood in the same way as having a **car** or a bank account. It means to be someone who is becoming someone—it means being a person with a past, a present, and a future. No one can have an individual's past, present or future. Different people experience these in various ways—these experiences are unique, not anyone else's. Having a past, present, and future means that a person is an existing individual—that a person can find meaning in time and by existing. Individuals do not think themselves into existence, they are born. But once born and past a certain age, the individual begins to make choices in life; now those choices can be his, his parents', society's, etc. The important point is that to exist, the individual must make choices—the individual must decide what to do the next moment and on into the future. What the individual chooses and how he chooses will define who and what he is—to himself and to others. Kierkegaard put it this way in *Works of Love*, 1847:

We are truly reluctant to make a young person arrogant prematurely and teach him to get busy judging the world. God forbid that anything we say should be able to contribute to developing this malady in a person. Indeed, we think we ought to make his life so strenuously inwardly that from the very beginning he has something else to think about, because it no doubt is a morbid hatred of the world that, perhaps without having considered the enormous responsibility, wants to be persecuted. But on the other hand we are also truly reluctant to deceive a young person by suppressing the difficulty and by suppressing it at the very moment we endeavor to recommend Christianity, inasmuch as that is the very moment we speak. We put our confidence in boldly daring to praise Christianity, also with the addition that in the world its reward, to put it mildly, is ingratitude. We regard it as our duty continually to speak about it in advance, so that we do not sometimes praise Christianity with an omission of what is essentially difficult, and at other times, perhaps on the occasion of a particular text, hit upon a few grounds of comfort for the person tried and tested in life. No, just when Christianity is being praised most strongly, the difficulty must simultaneously be emphasized. (···) Christianly the world's opposition stands in an essential relationship to the inwardness of Christianity. Moreover, the person who chooses Christianity should

at that very moment have an impression of its difficulty so that he can know what it is that he is choosing. Soren Kierkegaard, *Works of Love*, Hong 1995, p. 193-194

The goal of life, according to Socrates, is to know thyself. Knowing oneself means being aware of who one is, what one can be and what one cannot be. Kierkegaard uses the same idea that Socrates used in his own writings. He asks the one who wants to be a single individual the following questions in his 1847 book, *Upbuilding Discourses in Various Spirits*

Everyone must make an accounting to God as an individual; the king must make an accounting to God as an individual, and the most wretched beggar must make an accounting to God as an individual – lest anyone be arrogant by being more than an individual, lest anyone despondently think that he is not an individual, perhaps because in the busyness of the world he does not even have a name but is designated only by a number. What else, indeed, is the accounting of eternity than that the voice of conscience is installed eternally in its eternal right to be the only voice! Are you now living in such a way that you are aware of being a single individual and thereby aware of your eternal responsibility before God; are you living in such a way that this awareness can acquire the time and stillness and liberty to withdraw from life, from an honorable occupation, from a happy domestic life – on the contrary, that awareness will support and transfigure and illuminate your conduct in the relationships of life. You are not to withdraw and sit brooding over your eternal accounting, whereby you only take on a new responsibility. You will find more and more time for your duties and tasks, while concern for your eternal responsibility will keep you from being busy and from busily taking part in everything possible – an activity that can best be called a waste of time. Have you made up your mind about how you want to perform your work, or are you continually of two minds because you want to be in agreement with the crowd? Do you stick to your bid, not defiantly, not despondently, but eternally concerned; do you, unchanged, continue to bid on the same thing and want to buy only the same thing while the terms are variously being changed? Are you hiding nothing suspicious in your soul, so that you would still wish things were different, so that you would dare robber-like to seize the reward for yourself, would dare to parade it, would dare

to point to it; so that you would wish the adversity did not exist because it constrains in you the selfishness that, although suppressed, yet foolishly deludes you into thinking that if you were lucky you would do something for the good that would be worth talking about, deludes you into forgetting that the devout wise person wishes no adversity away when it befalls him because he obviously cannot know whether it might not indeed be a good for him, into forgetting that the devout wise person wins his most beautiful victory when the powerful one who persecuted him wants, as they say, to spare him, and the wise one replies: I cannot unconditionally wish it, because I cannot definitely know whether the persecution might not indeed be a good for me. Are you doing good only out of the fear of punishment, so that you scowl even when you will the good, so that in your dreams at night you wish the punishment away and to that extent also the good, and in your daydreams delude yourself into thinking that one can serve the good with a slavish mind?

- Soren Kierkegaard, *Upbuilding Discourses in Various Spirits*, 1847, Hong p. 127-140

Subjectivity comes with consciousness of myself as a self. It encompasses the emotional and intellectual resources that the individual is born with. Subjectivity is what the individual is as a human being. Now the problem of subjectivity is to decide how to choose—what rules or models is the individual going to use to make the right choices? What are the right choices? Who defines right? To be truly an individual, to be true to himself, his actions should in some way be expressed so that they describe who and what he is to himself and to others. The problem, according to Kierkegaard, is that we must choose who and what we will be based on subjective interests—the individual must make choices that will mean something to him as a reasoning, feeling being.

Kierkegaard decided to step up to the *Tree of the knowledge of good and evil* for himself, replacing Adam, and make his choice in the presence of God, where no one was there to accuse or judge him but his Creator. This is what he had Abraham do in *Fear and Trembling*. This is how Kierkegaard thought learning about oneself takes place. Here is where the single individual learns about *guilt* and *innocence*. His book, *The Concept of Anxiety*, makes clear that Adam did have knowledge when he made his choice and that was the knowledge of freedom. The prohibition was there but so was freedom and Eve and Adam decided to use it.

In Kierkegaard's meaning, purely theological assertions are *subjective truths* and they cannot be either verified or invalidated by science, i.e. through objective knowledge.* [18] For him, choosing if one is for or against a certain sub-

jective truth is a purely arbitrary choice.*[18] He calls the jump from objective knowledge to religious faith a **leap of faith**, since it means subjectively accepting statements which cannot be rationally justified.*[18] For him the Christian faith is the result of the trajectory initiated by such choices, which don't have and cannot have a rational ground (meaning that reason is neither for or against making such choices).*[18] Objectively regarded, purely theological assertions are neither true nor false.*[18]

8.2.10 Three stages of life

Early American Kierkegaard scholars tried to reduce the complexity of Kierkegaard's authorship by focusing on three levels of individual existence, which are named in passing by one of Kierkegaard's pseudonyms, Johannes Climacus, who wrote *Concluding Unscientific Postscript*. Though the stages represent only one way of interpreting Kierkegaard's thought, it has become a popular way of introducing his authorship. In continental European circles, stage theory never took hold in the same way. This typifies what Kierkegaard was talking about throughout his writing career. "Early American scholars" and "European circles" denote partitions of thought concerning the writings of his works. He was against "reflecting oneself out of reality" and partitioning the "world of the spirit" because the world of the spirit cannot be objectively divided. He wrote about Hegel's stages in his book, *Lectures on the Philosophy of Religion*:

These stages may be compared to those of the ages of man. The child is still in the primal immediate unity of the will with nature, as representing both his own nature and the nature which surrounds him. The second stage, adolescence, when individuality is in process of becoming independent, is the living spirituality, the vitality of Spirit, which while setting no end before it as yet, moves forward, has aspirations, and takes an interest in everything which comes its way. The third is the age of manhood; this is the period of work for a particular end, to which the man makes himself subserviently, to which he devotes his energies. Finally, old age might be considered as a last stage, which having the Universal before it as an end, and recognizing this end, has turned back from the particular interests of life and work to the uni-

versal aim, the absolute final end, and has, as it were, gathered itself together out of the wide and manifold interests of actual outward existence and concentrated itself in the infinite depths of its inner life. Such are the determinations which follow in a logical manner from the nature of the Notion. At the close it will become apparent that even the original immediacy does not exist as immediacy, but is something posited. The child itself is something begotten. George Wilhelm Friedrich Hegel, *Lectures on the Philosophy of Religion vol I* translated by Rev. E B Speiers 1895 p. 266ff*[19]

In the world of the spirit, the different stages are not like cities on a journey, about which it is quite all right for the traveler to say directly, for example: We left Peking and came to Canton and were in Canton on the fourteenth. A traveler like that changes places, not himself; and thus it is alright for him to mention and to recount the change in a direct, unchanged form. But in the world of the spirit to change place is to be changed oneself, and there all direct assurance of having arrived here and there is an attempt at a **Munchausen**. The presentation itself demonstrates that one has reached that far place in the world of spirit. ... The **pseudonymous** author and I along with them were all **subjective**. I ask for nothing better than to be known in our *objective* times as the only person who was not capable of being objective. That subjectivity, inwardness, is truth, that existing is the decisive factor, that this was the way to take to Christianity, which is precisely inwardness, but please note, not every inwardness, which was why the preliminary stages definitely had to be insisted upon—that was my idea, I thought that I had found a similar endeavor in the pseudonymous writings, and I have tried to make clear my interpretation of them and their relation to my *Fragments*. Søren Kierkegaard, *Concluding Unscientific Postscript to*

Philosophical Fragments, 1846, Hong
translation 1992

In one popular interpretation of stage theory, each of the so-called levels of existence envelops those below it: an ethical person is still capable of aesthetic enjoyment, for example, and a religious person is still capable of aesthetic enjoyment and ethical duty. The difference between these ways of living are internal, not external, and thus there are no external signs one can point to determine at what level a person is living. This inner and outer relationship is commonly determined by an individual by looking to others to gauge one's action, Kierkegaard believed one should look to oneself and in that relationship look to Christ as the example instead of looking at others because the more you look at others the less you see of yourself. This makes it easier to degrade your neighbor instead of loving your neighbor. But one must love the person one sees not the person one wishes to see. Either love the person you see as that person is the person he is or stop talking about loving everyone.* [20]

Back to the Stages. It is markedly different from *Either/Or* by a tripartition. There are three stages, an esthetic, an ethical, a religious, yet not abstract as the immediate mediate, the unity, but concrete in the qualification of existence categories as pleasure-perdition, action-victory, suffering. But despite this tripartition, the book is nevertheless an either/or. That is, the ethical and the religious stages have an essential relation to each other. The inadequacy of *Either/Or* is simply that the work ended ethically, as has been shown. In *Stages* that has been made clear, and the religious is maintained in its place. A story of suffering; suffering is the religious category. In *Stages* the esthete is no longer a clever fellow frequenting B's living room —a hopeful man, etc., because he still is only a possibility; no, he is existing [*existerer*]. “It is exactly the same as *Either/Or*.” Constantin Constantius and the Young Man placed together in *Quidam* of the experiment. (*Humor* advanced.) *Concluding Unscientific Postscript*, Hong p. 294, *Journals of Søren Kierkegaard*, VIB 41:10

Christ's love for Peter was boundless in this way: in loving Peter he accomplished loving the person one sees. He did not say, “Peter must first change and become another person before I can love him again.” No, he said exactly the opposite, “Peter is Peter, and I love him. My love, if anything will help him to become another person.” Therefore he did not break off the friendship in order perhaps to renew it if Peter would

have become another person; no, he preserved the friendship unchanged and in that way helped Peter to become another person. Do you think that Peter would have been won again without Christ's faithful friendship? But it is so easy to be a friend when this means nothing else than to request something in particular from the friend and, if the friend does not respond to the request, then to let the friendship cease, until it perhaps begins again if he responds to the request. Is this a relationship of friendship? Who is closer to helping an erring one than the person who calls himself his friend, even if the offense is committed against the friend! But the friend withdraws and says (indeed, it is as if a third person were speaking): When he has become another person, then perhaps he can become my friend again. We are not far from regarding such behavior as magnanimous. But truly we are far from being able to say of such a friend that in loving he loves the person he sees. Christ's love was boundless, as it must be if this is to be fulfilled: in loving to love the person one sees. This is very easy to perceive. However much and in whatever way a person is changed, he still is not changed in such a way that he becomes invisible. If this—the impossible—is not the case, then of course we do see him, and the duty is to love the person one sees. Ordinarily we think that if a person has essentially changed for the worse, he is then so changed that we are exempt from loving him. But Christianity asks: Can you because of this change no longer see him? The answer to that must be: Certainly I can see him; I see that he is no longer worth loving. But if you see this, then you do not really see him (which you certainly cannot deny you are doing in another sense), you see only the unworthiness and the imperfection and thereby admit that when you loved him you did not see *him* in another sense but merely saw his excellence and perfections, which you loved.

- Søren Kierkegaard, *Works of Love* (1847)
Hong 1995 p. 172-173

When a person to whom the possible pertains relates himself equally to the duality of the possible, we say: He expects. To expect contains within itself the same duality that the possible has, and to expect is to relate oneself to the possible purely and simply as such. Then the relationship divides according to the way the expecting person chooses. To relate oneself expectantly to the possibility of the good is to hope, which for that very reason cannot be any temporal ex-

pectancy but is an eternal hope. To relate oneself expectantly to the possibility of evil is to fear. But both the one who hopes and the one who fears are expecting. As soon, however, as the choice is made, the possible is changed, because the possibility of the good is the eternal. It is only in the moment of contact that the duality of the possible is equal; therefore, by the decision to choose hope, one decided infinitely more than it seems, because it is an eternal decision.

People think that they are speaking with ample experience in dividing a person's life into certain periods and ages and then call the first period the age of hope or of possibility. What nonsense! Thus, in talk about hope they completely leave out the eternal and yet speak about hope. But how is this possible, since hope pertains to the possibility of the good, and thereby to the eternal! On the other hand, how is it possible to speak about hope in such a way that it is assigned to a certain age! Surely the eternal extends over the whole of life and there is and should be hope to the end; then there is no period that is the age of hope, but a person's whole life should be the time of hope! And then they think they are speaking with ample experience about hope-by abolishing the eternal.

- Søren Kierkegaard, *Works of Love* (1847)
Hong 1995 p. 249-251

Stage one: aesthetic

Kierkegaard was interested in *aesthetics*, and is sometimes referred to as the “poet-philosopher” because of the passionate way in which he approached *philosophy*. But he is often said to be interested in showing the inadequacy of a life lived entirely in the aesthetic level. Aesthetic life is defined in numerous different ways in Kierkegaard's authorship, including a life defined by intellectual enjoyment, sensual desire, and an inclination to interpret oneself as if one were “on stage.” There are many degrees of this aesthetic existence and a single definition is thus difficult to offer. At bottom, one might see the purely unreflective lifestyle. At the top, we might find those lives which are lived in a reflective, independent, critical and socially apathetic way. But many interpreters of Kierkegaard believe that most people live in the least reflective sort of aesthetic stage, their lives and activities guided by everyday tasks and concerns. Fewer aesthetically guided people are the reflective sort. Whether such people know it or not, their lives will inevitably lead to complete despair. Kierkegaard's author A is an example of an individual living the aesthetic life.

You love the accidental. A smile from a pretty girl in an interesting situation, a stolen glance, that is what you are hunting for, that is a motif for your aimless fantasy. You who always pride yourself on being an observateur must, in return, put up with becoming an object of observation. Ah, you are a strange fellow, one moment a child, the next an old man; one moment you are thinking most earnestly about the most important scholarly problems, how you will devote your life to them, and the next you are a lovesick fool. But you are a long way from marriage. *Either/Or Part II* p. 7-8

Just consider, your life is passing; for you, too, the time will eventually come even to you when your life is at an end, when you are no longer shown any further possibilities in life, when recollection alone is left, recollection, but not in the sense in which you love it so much, this mixture of fiction and truth, but the earnest and faithful recollection of your conscience. Beware that it does not unroll a list for you-presumably not of actual crimes but of wasted possibilities, showdown pictures it will be impossible for you to drive away. The *intellectual* agility you possess is very becoming to youth and diverts the eye for a time. We are astonished to see a clown whose joints are so loose that all the restraints of man's gait and posture are annulled. You are like that in an intellectual sense; you can just as well stand on your head as on your feet. Everything is *possible* for you, and you can surprise yourself and others with this possibility, but it is unhealthy, and for your own peace of mind I beg you to watch out lest that which is an advantage to you end by becoming a curse. Any man who has a conviction cannot at his pleasure turn himself and everything topsy-turvy in this way. Therefore I do not warn you against the world but against yourself and the world against you. *Either/Or II*, Hong p. 16

Stage two: ethical

The second level of existence is the ethical. This is where an individual begins to take on a true direction in life, becoming aware of and personally responsible for good and evil and forming a commitment to oneself and others. One's actions at this level of existence have a consistency and coherence that they lacked in the previous sphere of existence. For many readers of Kierkegaard, the ethical is central. It calls each individual to take account of their lives and to scrutinize their actions in terms of absolute responsibility, which is what Kierkegaard calls *repentance*. If we compare Kierkegaard's idea of ethics with Vedic system of four aims of life, this Ethical system probably correlates most with *Dharma* - following this or that religion, set of rules, laws etc. (Hindus would call any religion as "dharma", though dharma is also a law).

"He repents himself back into himself, back into the family, back into the race, until he finds himself in God. Only on this condition can he choose himself. And this is the only condition he wants, for only in this way can he choose himself absolutely." "I repent myself out of the whole existence. Repentance specifically expresses that evil essentially belongs to me and at the same time expresses that it does not essentially belong to me. If the evil in me did not essentially belong to me, I could not choose it; but if there were something in me that I could not choose absolutely, then I would not be choosing myself absolutely at all, then I myself would not be the absolute but only a product." "It is a sign of a well brought up child to be inclined to say it is sorry without too much pondering whether it is in the right or not, and it is likewise a sign of a high-minded person and a deep soul if he is inclined to repent, if he does not take God to court but repents and loves God in his repentance. Without this, his life is nothing, only like foam." ... "The *Either/Or* I erected between living esthetically and living ethically is not an unqualified dilemma, because it actually is a matter of only one choice. Through this choice, I actually choose between good and evil, but I choose the good, I choose *eo ipso* the choice between good and evil. The original choice is forever present in every succeeding choice." Søren Kierkegaard, *Either/Or* Part II, Hong, p. 216-217, 224, 237-238, 219

"Judge Wilhelm," a pseudonymous author of *Either/Or* and the voice who defines the ethical consciousness, argues that the commitment to take responsibility for one's own choices

must be made individually. To take responsibility for the various relationships in which an individual finds him- or herself is a possibility open to every human being, but it does not follow that every human being chooses to do so as a matter of course. The meaning of a person's life for Wilhelm depends on how he takes responsibility for his current and future choices, and how he takes ownership of those choices already made. For Wilhelm, the ethically governed person takes responsibility for past actions, some good and some bad, seeks consistency, and takes seriously the obligation to live in a passionate and devoted way.

The Christian God is spirit and Christianity is spirit, and there is discord between the flesh and the spirit but the flesh is not the sensuous-it is the selfish. In this sense, even the spiritual can become sensuous-for example, if a person took his spiritual gifts in vain, he would then be carnal. And of course I know that it is not necessary for the Christian that Christ must have been physically beautiful; and it would be grievous-for a reason different from the one you give-because if beauty were some essential, how the believer would long to see him; but from all this it by no means follows that the sensuous is annihilated in Christianity. The first love has the element of beauty in itself, and the joy and fullness that are in the sensuous in its innocence can very well be caught up in Christianity. But let us guard against one thing, a wrong turn that is more dangerous than the one you wish to avoid; let us not become too spiritual. *Either/Or* Part II p. 50

The question, namely, is this: Can this love be actualized? After having conceded everything up to this point, you perhaps will say: Well, it is just as difficult to actualize marriage as to actualize first love. To that I must respond: No, for in marriage there is a law of motion. First love remains an unreal in itself that never acquires inner substance because it moves only in the external medium. In the ethical and religious intention, marital love has the possibility of an inner history and is as different from first love as

the historical is from the unhistorical. This love is strong, stronger than the whole world, but the moment it doubts it is annihilated; it is like a sleepwalker who is able to walk the most dangerous places with the complete security but plunges down when someone calls his name. Marital love is armed, for in the intention not only is attentiveness directed to the surrounding world but the will is directed toward itself, toward the inner world. Either/Or II p. 94

The choice itself is crucial for the content of the personality: through the choice the personality submerges itself in that which is being chosen, and when it does not choose, it withers away in atrophy. ... Imagine a captain of a ship the moment a shift of direction must be made; then he may be able to say: I can do either this or that. But if he is not a mediocre captain he will also be aware that during all this the ship is ploughing ahead with its ordinary velocity, and thus there is but a single moment when it is inconsequential whether he does this or does that. So also with a person—if he forgets to take into account the velocity—there eventually comes a moment where it is no longer a matter of an Either/Or, not because he has chosen, but because he has refrained from it, which also can be expressed by saying: Because others have chosen for him—or because he has lost himself. Either/Or II p. 163-164

Stage three: religious

The ethical and the religious are intimately connected: a person can be ethically serious without being religious, but the religious stage includes the ethical. Whereas living in the ethical sphere involves a commitment to some moral absolute, living in the religious sphere involves a commitment and relation to the Christian God. Kierkegaard explained this in *Concluding Unscientific Postscript* like this:

Johannes the Seducer ends with the thesis that woman is only the moment. This in its general sense is the essential esthetic thesis, that the

moment is all and to that extent, in turn, essentially nothing, just as the Sophistic thesis that everything is true is that nothing is true. On the whole the conception of time is the decisive element in every standpoint up to the paradox, which paradoxically accentuates time. To the degree that time is accentuated, to the same degree there is movement from the esthetic, the metaphysical, to the ethical, the religious, and the Christian-religious. Where Johannes the Seducer ends, the Judge begins: Woman's beauty increases with the years. Here time is accentuated ethically, but still not in such a way that precludes the possibility of recollection's withdrawal out of existence into the eternal. p. 298-299

If a man like Kant, standing on the pinnacle of scientific scholarship, were to say in reference to demonstrations of the existence of God: Well, I do not know anything more about that than that my father told me it was so—this is humorous and actually says more than a whole book about demonstrations, if the book forgets this. p. 552-553

The Kierkegaardian pseudonyms who speak of stage theory consider religion to be the highest stage in human existence. In one discussion of religious life, one of Kierkegaard's pseudonyms, Johannes Climacus, distinguishes two types within this stage, which have been called *Religiousness A* and *Religiousness B*.^[21] One type is symbolized by the Greek philosopher Socrates, whose passionate pursuit of the truth and individual conscience came into conflict with his society. Another type of religiousness is one characterized by the realization that the individual is sinful and is the source of untruth. In time, through revelation and in direct relationship with the paradox that is Jesus, the individual begins to see that his or her eternal salvation rests on a paradox—God, the transcendent, coming into time in human form to redeem human beings. For Kierkegaard, the very notion of this occurring was scandalous to human reason—indeed, it must be, and if it is not then one does not truly understand the Incarnation nor the meaning of human sinfulness. For Kierkegaard, the impulse towards an awareness of a transcendent power in the universe is what religion is. Religion has a social and an individual (not just personal) dimension. But it begins with the individual and his or her awareness of sinfulness. Here are several quotes from Kierkegaard's where he discusses his concept of sin.

The sin/faith opposition is the Christian one which transforms all ethical concepts in a Christian way and distils one more decoction from them. At the root of the opposition lies the crucial Christian specification: before God; and that

in turn has the crucial Christian characteristic: the absurd, the paradox, the possibility of offense. And it is of the utmost importance that this is demonstrated in every specification of the Christian, since offense is the Christian protection against all speculative philosophy. In what, then, do we find the possibility of offense here? In the fact that a person should have the reality of his being, as a particular human being, directly before God, and accordingly, again, and by the same token, that man's sin should be of concern of God. This notion of the single human being before God never occurs to speculative thought; it only universalizes particular human phantastically into the human race. It is exactly for this reason that a disbelieving Christianity came up with the idea that sin is sin, that it is neither here nor there whether it is before God. In other words, it wanted to get rid of the specification 'before God', and to that end invented a new wisdom, which nevertheless, curiously enough, was neither more nor less than what the higher wisdom generally is—old paganism. *The Sickness Unto Death*, Hannay, 1989 p. 115

Admittance is only through the consciousness of sin; to want to enter by any other road is high treason against Christianity. ...The simple soul who humbly acknowledges himself to be a sinner, himself personally (the single individual), has no need at all to learn about all the difficulties that come when one is neither simple or humble. ...To the extent Christianity, terrifying, will rise up against him and transform itself into madness or horror until he either learns to give up Christianity or—by means of what is anything but scholarly propaedeutics, apologetics, etc., by means of the anguish of a contrite conscience, all in proportion to his need—learns to enter into Christianity by the narrow way, through the consciousness of sin. *Practice in Christianity*, Hong, 1991, p. 67-68

8.3 Kierkegaard's thoughts on other philosophers

8.3.1 Kierkegaard and Fichte

Kierkegaard wrote much about Johann Gottlieb Fichte in his thesis *The Concept of Irony**[22] as well as in his first book *De omnibus dubitandum est*, written under the pseudonym Johannes Climacus, and his Journals. Fichte



Fichte

wrote the book *The Vocation of Man* (1800) which called for a progression in the life of the human being from doubt to knowledge and then to faith. *De omnibus dubitandum est* is from Descartes and means everything must be doubted. Both Kierkegaard and Fichte were interested in this idea of beginning with doubt as well as subjectivity. Kierkegaard wrote: "In Fichte, subjectivity became free, infinite, negative. But in order for subjectivity to get out of this movement of emptiness in which it moved in infinite abstraction, it had to be negated; in order for thought to become actual, it had to become concrete." *[23]

Our whole age is imbued with a formal striving. This is what led us to disregard congeniality and to emphasize symmetrical beauty, to prefer conventional rather than sincere social relations. It is this whole striving which is denoted by—to use the words of another author—Fichte's and the other philosophers' attempts to construct systems by sharpness of mind and Robespierre's attempt to do it with the help of the guillotine; it is this which meets us in the flowing butterfly verses of our poets and in Auber's music, and finally, it is this which produces the many revolutions in the political world. I agree perfectly with this whole effort to cling to form, insofar as it continues to be the medium through which we have the idea, but it should not be forgotten that it is the idea which should determine the form, not

the form which determines the idea. We should keep in mind that life is not something abstract but something extremely individual. We should not forget that, for example, from a poetic genius' position of immediacy, form is nothing but the coming into existence of the idea in the world, and that the task of reflection is only to investigate whether or not the idea has gotten the properly corresponding form. Form is not the basis of life, but life is the basis of form. Imagine that a man long infatuated with the Greek mode of life had acquired the means to arrange for a building in the Greek style and a Grecian household establishment —whether or not he would be satisfied would be highly problematical, or would he soon prefer another form simply because he had not sufficiently tested himself and the system in which he lived. But just as a leap backward is wrong (something the age, on the whole, is inclined to acknowledge), so also a leap forward is wrong —both of them because a natural development does not proceed by leaps, and life's earnestness will ironize over every such experiment, even if it succeeds momentarily. Søren Kierkegaard, *Journals*, Our Journalistic Literature November 28, 1835

8.3.2 Kierkegaard and Hegel



Hegel

Many philosophers think that one of Kierkegaard's greatest contributions to philosophy is his critique of **Georg Wilhelm Friedrich Hegel**. Indeed, many of Kierkegaard's works are written in response to or as a critique of Hegel. Although Kierkegaard strongly criticized some aspects of Hegelian philosophy, his work also shows that he was also positively influenced by Hegel, and had respect for Hegel himself.

Now everything is set in motion, and usually this also involves making the system popular — per systema influxus physici it lays hold of all men. How **Kant** was treated in his time is well known, and therefore I need only mention the infinite mass of lexicons, summaries, popular presentations, and explanations for everyman, etc. And how did Hegel fare later, Hegel, the most modern **philosopher**, who because of his rigorous form would most likely command silence? Has not the logical trinity been advanced in the most ludicrous way? And therefore it did not astound me that my shoemaker had found that it could also be applied to the development of boots, since, as he observes, the dialectic, which is always the first stage in life, finds expression even here, however insignificant this may seem, in the squeaking, which surely has not escaped the attention of some more profound research psychologist. Unity, however, appears only later, in which respect his shoes far surpass all others, which usually disintegrate in the dialectic, a unity which reached the highest level in that pair of boots Carl XII wore on his famous ride, and since he as an orthodox shoemaker proceeded from the thesis that the immediate (feet without shoes — shoes without feet) is a pure **abstraction** and took it [the dialectical] as the first stage in the development. And now our modern **politicians**! By veritably taking up Hegel, they have given a striking example of the way one can serve two masters, in that their revolutionary striving is paired with a life-outlook which is a remedy for it, an excellent remedy for lifting part of the illusion which is necessary for encouraging their fantastic striving. And the actuality of the **phenomenon** will surely not be denied if one recalls that the words “immediate or spontaneous unity” occur just as necessarily in every scientific-scholarly treatise as a brunette or a blonde in every well-ordered romantic household. At the happy moment everyone received a copy of Holy Scriptures, in which there was one book which was almost always too brief and sometimes almost invisible, and this was, I regret —the **Acts of the**

Apostles. And how curious it is to note that the present age, whose social striving is trumpeted quite enough, is ashamed of the monks and nuns of the **Middle Ages**, when at the same time, to confine ourselves to our own native land, a society has been formed here which seems to embrace almost the entire kingdom and in which a speaker began thus: Dear Brothers and Sisters. How remarkable to see them censure the Jesuitry of the Middle Ages, since precisely the liberal development, as does every one-sided enthusiasm, has led and must lead to that. And now Christianity —how has it been treated? I share entirely your disapproval of the way every Christian concept has become so volatilized, so completely dissolved in a mass of fog, that it is beyond all recognition. To the concepts of faith, incarnation, tradition, inspiration, which in the Christian sphere are to lead to a particular historical fact, the philosophers choose to give an entirely different, ordinary meaning, whereby faith has become the immediate consciousness, which essentially is nothing other than the *vital Fluidum* of mental life, its atmosphere, and tradition has become the content of a certain experience of the world, while inspiration has become nothing more than God's breathing of the life-spirit into man, and incarnation no more than the presence of one or another idea in one or more individuals. —Journals IA 328 1836 or 1837

In a journal entry made in 1844, Kierkegaard wrote:

If Hegel had written the whole of his logic and then said, in the preface or some other place, that it was merely an experiment in thought in which he had even begged the question in many places, then he would certainly have been the greatest thinker who had ever lived. As it is, he is merely comic.

—Søren Kierkegaard, (Journals, 1844* [6])

While Kierkegaard was a student of theology at the University of Copenhagen, **Hegelianism** had become increasingly popular. **Johan Ludvig Heiberg** and **Hans Lassen Martensen** were key figures in Danish Hegelianism. Kierkegaard remarked in his journal on 17 May 1843 that Heiberg's writings were “borrowed” from Hegel, implying Heiberg would have been a nobody without Hegel.

Kierkegaard objected to Hegel's claim that he had devised a system of thought that could explain the whole of reality, with a **dialectical** analysis of history leading the way to

this whole. Hegel claimed that the doctrines and history of Christianity could be explained as a part of the rational unfolding and development of our understanding of the natural world and our place within it. Kierkegaard considered Hegel's explanation of Christianity as a necessary part of world history to be a distortion of the Christian message and a misunderstanding of the limits of human reason. He attempted to refute this aspect of Hegel's thought by suggesting that many doctrines of Christianity - including the **doctrine of Incarnation**, a God who is also human - cannot be explained rationally but remain a logical paradox. However, he was in favor of youthful striving after truth.

Let a doubting youth, but an existing doubter with youth's lovable, boundless confidence in a hero of scientific scholarship, venture to find in Hegelian positivity the truth, the truth of existence—he will write a dreadful epigram on Hegel. Do not misunderstand me. I do not mean that every youth is capable of overcoming Hegel, far from it. If a young person is conceited and foolish enough to try that, his attack is inane. No, the youth must never think of wanting to attack him; he must rather be willing to submit unconditionally to Hegel with feminine devotedness, but nevertheless with sufficient strength also to stick to his question—then he is a satirist without suspecting it. The youth is an existing doubter; continually suspended in **doubt**, he grasps for the truth—so that he can exist in it. Consequently, he is negative, and Hegel's philosophy is, of course, positive—no wonder he puts his trust in it. But for an existing person pure thinking is a **chimera** when the truth is supposed to be the truth in which to exist. Having to exist with the help of the guidance of pure thinking is like having to travel in Denmark with a small map of Europe on which Denmark is no larger than a steel pen-point, indeed, even more impossible. The youth's admiration, his enthusiasm, and his limitless confidence in Hegel are precisely the satire on Hegel. This would have been discerned long ago if pure thinking had not maintained itself with the aid of a reputation that impresses people, so that they dare not say anything except that it is superb, that they have understood it—although in a certain sense that it is indeed impossible, since no one can be led by this philosophy to understand himself, which is certainly an absolute condition for all other understanding. Socrates has rather ironically said that he did not know for sure whether he was a human being or something else, but in the confessional a Hegelian can say with all solemnity: I do not know whether I am a human

being-but I have understood the system. I prefer to say: I know that I am a human being, and I know that I have not understood the system. And when I have said that very directly, I shall add that if any of our Hegelians want to take me into hand and assist me to an understanding of the system, nothing will stand in the way from my side. In order that I can learn all the more, I shall try hard to be as obtuse as possible, so as not to have, if possible, a single presupposition except my ignorance. And in order to be sure of learning something, I shall try hard to be as indifferent as possible to all charges of being unscientific and unscholarly. Existing, if this is to be understood as just any sort of existing, cannot be done without passion.

- Søren Kierkegaard 1846, *Concluding Unscientific Postscript to Philosophical Fragments*, Hong p. 310-311

To refute Hegel's claim that Christianity should be understood as a part of the necessary evolution of thought, or in Hegelian terms, Spirit, in *Fear and Trembling*, Kierkegaard attempts to use the story of *Abraham* to show that there is a goal higher than that of ethics (questioning the Hegelian claim that doing one's ethical duty is the highest that can be said of a human being) and that faith cannot be explained by Hegelian ethics, (disproving Hegel's claim that Christianity can be rationally explained by philosophy). Either way, this work can be read as a challenge to the Hegelian notion that a human being's ultimate purpose is to fulfill ethical demands.

Kierkegaard's strategy was to invert this dialectic by seeking to make everything more difficult. Instead of seeing scientific knowledge as the means of human redemption, he regarded it as the greatest obstacle to redemption. Instead of seeking to give people more knowledge he sought to take away what passed for knowledge. Instead of seeking to make God and Christian faith perfectly intelligible he sought to emphasize the absolute transcendence by God of all human categories. Instead of setting himself up as a religious authority, Kierkegaard used a vast array of textual devices to undermine his authority as an author and to place responsibility for the existential significance to be derived from his texts squarely on the reader. ...Kierkegaard's tactic in undermining Hegelianism was to produce an elaborate parody of Hegel's entire system. The pseudonymous authorship, from *Either/Or* to *Concluding Unscientific Postscript*, presents an inverted Hegelian dialectic which is designed to

lead readers away from knowledge rather than towards it.

—Søren Kierkegaard, William McDonald

By doing this, Hegelian critics accuse Kierkegaard of using the dialectic to disprove the dialectic, which seems somewhat contradictory and hypocritical. However, Kierkegaard would not claim the dialectic itself is bad, only the Hegelian premise that the dialectic *would lead to a harmonious reconciliation of everything*, which Hegel called the *Absolute*. Kierkegaard stated this most clearly in his book *The Concept of Anxiety*,

Dogmatics must not explain hereditary sin but rather explain it by presupposing it, like that vortex about which Greek speculation concerning nature had so much to say, a moving something that no science can grasp. That such is the case with dogmatics will readily be granted if once again time is taken to understand *Schleiermacher's* immortal service to this science. He was left behind long ago when men chose Hegel. Yet Schleiermacher was a thinker in the beautiful Greek sense, a thinker who spoke only of what he knew. Hegel, on the contrary, despite all his outstanding ability and stupendous learning, reminds us again and again by his performance that he was in the German sense a professor of philosophy on a large scale, because he *a tout prix* [at any price] must explain all things. *The Concept of Anxiety*, by Reidar Thomte Princeton University Press 1980 P. 20

Kierkegaardian scholars have made several interpretations of how Kierkegaard proceeds with parodying Hegel's dialectic. One of the more popular interpretations argues the aesthetic-ethical-religious stages are the triadic process Kierkegaard was talking about. See section *Spheres of existence* for more information. Another interpretation argues for the world-individual-will triadic process. The dialectic here is either to assert an individual's own desire to be independent and the desire to be part of a community. Instead of reconciliation of the world and the individual where problems between the individual and society are neatly resolved in the Hegelian system, Kierkegaard argues that there's a delicate bond holding the interaction between them together, which needs to be constantly reaffirmed. *Jean-Paul Sartre* takes this latter view and says the individual is in a constant state of reaffirming his or her own identity, else one falls into *bad faith*.

This process of reconciliation leads to a “both/and” view of life, where both thesis and antithesis are resolved into

a synthesis, which negates the importance of personal responsibility and the human choice of either/or. The work *Either/Or* is a response to this aspect of Hegel's philosophy. A passage from that work exemplifies Kierkegaard's contempt for Hegel's philosophy. Note the comparison between "A" and "B" (Judge Vilhelm) in *Either/Or* and *Stages on Life's Way*.

Marry, and you will regret it. Do not marry, and you will also regret it. Marry or do not marry, you will regret it either way. Whether you marry or you do not marry, you will regret it either way. Laugh at the stupidities of the world, and you will regret it; weep over them, and you will also regret it. Laugh at the stupidities of the world or weep over them, you will regret it either way. Whether you laugh at the stupidities of the world or you weep over them, you will regret it either way. Trust a girl, and you will regret it. Do not trust her, and you will also regret it. ... Hang yourself or do not hang yourself, you will regret it either way. Whether you hang yourself or do not hang yourself, you will regret it either way. This, gentlemen, is the quintessence of all the wisdom of life.

—Søren Kierkegaard, *Either/Or* Part I, Hong

My dear reader, if you do not have the time and opportunity to take a dozen years of your life to travel around the world to see everything a world traveler is acquainted with, if you do not have the capability and qualifications from years of practice in a foreign language to penetrate to the differences in national characteristics as these become apparent to the research scholar, if you are not bent upon discovering a new astronomical system that will displace both the Copernican and the Ptolemaic—then marry; and if you have time for the first, the capability for the second, the idea for the last, then marry *also*. Even if you did not manage to see the whole globe or to speak in many tongues or to know all about the heavens, you will not regret it, for marriage is and remains the most important voyage of discovery a human being undertakes; compared with a married man's knowledge of life, any other knowledge of it is superficial, for he and he alone has properly immersed himself in life.

—Søren Kierkegaard, Judge Vilhelm, *Stages on Life's Way*, Hong p. 89

Here are two more from 1846

As is well known, Hegelian philosophy has canceled the principle of contradiction, and Hegel himself has more than once emphatically held judgment day on the kind of thinkers who remained in the sphere of understanding and reflection and who have therefore insisted that there is an either/or. Since that time, it has become a popular game, so that as soon as someone hints at an aut/aut [either/or] a Hegelian comes riding trip-trap-trap on horse and wins a victory and rides home again. Among us, too, the Hegelians have several times been on the move, especially against Bishop Mynster, in order to win speculative thought's brilliant victory; and Bishop Mynster, has more than once become a defeated standpoint, even though for being a defeated standpoint he is holding up very well, and it is rather to be feared that the enormous exertion of the victory has been too exhausting to the undefeated victors. And yet there may be a misunderstanding at the root of the conflict and the victory, Hegel is perfectly and absolutely right in maintaining that, looked at eternally, *sub specie aeterni*, there is no aut/aut either/or in the language of abstraction, in pure thought and pure being. Where the devil would it be, since abstraction, after all, simply removes the contradiction; therefor [sic] Hegel and the Hegelians should instead take the trouble to explain what is meant by the masquerade of getting contradiction, movement, transition, etc. into logic. The defenders of aut/aut are in the wrong if they push their way into the territory of pure thinking and want to defend their cause there. *Concluding Unscientific Postscript to Philosophical Fragments, Volume I* p. 305

According to Hegel the truth is the continuous world-historical process. Each generation, each stage of this process, is legitimated and yet is only an element of the truth. Short of resorting to a bit of charlatanry, which helps by assuming that the generation in which Hegel lived or the one after him is *imprimatur*, and this generation is the last and world history is past, we are all implicated in skepticism. The passionate question of truth does not even come up, because philosophy has first tricked the individuals into becoming objective. The positive Hegelian truth is just as deceptive as happiness was in paganism. Not until afterward does one come to know whether or not one has been happy, and

thus the next generation comes to know what truth was in the preceding generation. The great secret of the system is close to Protagoras' sophism "Everything is relative", except that here everything is relative in the continuous process. But no living soul is served by that ... *Concluding Unscientific Postscript to Philosophical Fragments Volume I*, by Johannes Climacus, edited by Søren Kierkegaard, Copyright 1846 – Edited and Translated by Howard V. Hong and Edna H. Hong 1992, Princeton University Press. Note p. 33

The whole idea of one generation spending all its time studying past generations and then the next generation spending their time studying past generations and making moral and social comments about preceding generations was called, "The Hegelian cud-chewing process with three-stomachs - first immediacy - then regurgitation - then down again." He said, "Maybe a succeeding master-mind could continue this with four stomachs, etc., down once more and up again. I don't know if the master-mind grasps what I mean." * [24]

8.3.3 Kierkegaard and Schelling



Schelling

In 1841–1842, Kierkegaard attended the Berlin lectures of Friedrich Wilhelm Joseph von Schelling. Schelling was a critic of Georg Hegel and a professor at the University

of Berlin. The university started a lecture series given by Schelling in order to espouse a type of positive philosophy which would be diametrically opposed to Hegelianism. Kierkegaard was initially delighted with Schelling. Before he left Copenhagen to attend Schelling's lectures in Berlin, he wrote to his friend Peter Johannes Sprang:

Schelling lectures to a select, numerous, and yet also *undique conflatum auditorium*. During the first lectures it was almost a matter of risking one's life to hear him. I have never in my life experienced such uncomfortable crowding—still, what would one not do to be able to hear Schelling? His main point is always that there are two philosophies, one positive and one negative. The negative is given, but not by Hegel, for Hegel's is neither negative nor positive but a refined Spinozism. The positive is yet to come. In other words, in the future it will not be only the lawyers who become the *doctores juris utriusque*, for I venture to flatter myself that without submitting another dissertation I shall become a *magister philosophiae utriusque*.
—Søren Kierkegaard, (Journals, 1841)* [6]

At Berlin, Kierkegaard gave high praises to Schelling. In a journal entry made sometime around October or November 1841, Kierkegaard wrote this piece about Schelling's second lecture:

I am so pleased to have heard Schelling's second lecture -- indescribably! I have sighed for long enough and my thoughts have sighed within me; when he mentioned the word, "reality" in connection with the relation of philosophy to reality the fruit of my thought leapt for joy within me. I remember almost every word he said from that moment on. ... Now I have put all my hopes in Schelling!
—Søren Kierkegaard, (Journals, 1841)* [6]

As time went on, however, Kierkegaard, as well as many in Schelling's audience, began to become disillusioned with Schelling. In a particularly insulting letter about Schelling, Kierkegaard wrote to his brother, Peter Kierkegaard:

Schelling drivels on quite intolerably! If you want to form some idea what this is like then I ask you to submit yourself to the following experiment as a sort of self-inflicted sadistic punishment. Imagine person R's meandering

philosophy, his entirely aimless, haphazard knowledge, and person Hornsyld's untiring efforts to display his learning: imagine the two combined and in addition to an impudence hitherto unequalled by any philosopher; and with that picture vividly before your poor mind go to the workroom of a prison and you will have some idea of Schelling's philosophy. He even lectures longer to prolong the torture. ... Consequently, I have nothing to do in Berlin. I am too old to attend lectures and Schelling is too old to give them. So I shall leave Berlin as soon as possible. But if it wasn't for Schelling, I would never have travelled to Berlin. I must thank him for that. ... I think I should have become utterly insane if I had gone on hearing Schelling.

—Søren Kierkegaard, (Journals, 27 February 1842)*[6]

It is common knowledge that Aristotle used the term first philosophy primarily to designate metaphysics, though he included within it a part that accorded to our conception belongs to theology. In paganism it is quite in order for theology to be treated there. It is related to the same lack of an infinite penetration reflection that endowed the theater in paganism with reality as a kind of divine worship. If we now abstract from this ambiguity, we could retain the designation and by first philosophy understand that totality of science which we might call “ethnical,” whose essence is immanence and is expressed in Greek thought by “recollection,” and by second philosophy understand that totality of science whose essence is transcendence or repetition. Schelling called attention to this Aristotelian term in support of his own distinction between negative and positive philosophy. By negative philosophy he meant “logic”; that was clear enough. On the other hand, it was less clear to me what he really meant by positive philosophy, except insofar as it became evident that it was the philosophy that he himself wished to provide. However, since I have nothing to go by except my own opinion, it is not feasible to pursue this subject further. Constantin Constantius has called attention to this by pointing out that immanence runs aground upon “interest.” With this concept, actuality for the first time comes into view. Søren Kierkegaard, *The Concept of Anxiety* 1844, p. 21 and Note p. 21 Nichol

cause Schelling shifted his focus on actuality, including a discussion on *quid sit* [what is] and *quod sit* [that is], to a more mythological, psychic-type pseudo-philosophy. Kierkegaard's last writing about Schelling's lectures was on 4 February 1842. He wrote the following in 1844,

Some men of Schelling's school have been especially aware of the alteration that has taken place in nature because of sin. Mention has been made also of the anxiety that is supposed to be in inanimate nature. Schelling's main thought is that anxiety, etc., characterize the suffering of the deity in his endeavor to create. In Berlin he expressed the same thought more definitely by comparing God with Goethe and Jon Von Muller,*[25] both of whom felt well only when producing, and also by calling attention to the fact that such a bliss, when it cannot communicate itself, is unhappiness. *The Concept of Anxiety* P. 59-60 Note p. 59

Although Schelling had little influence on Kierkegaard's subsequent writings, Kierkegaard's trip to Berlin provided him ample time to work on his masterpiece, *Either/Or*. In a reflection about Schelling in 1849, Kierkegaard remarked that Schelling was *like the Rhine at its mouth where it became stagnant water - he was degenerating into a Prussian "Excellency"*. (Journals, January 1849)*[6]

8.3.4 Kierkegaard and Schopenhauer

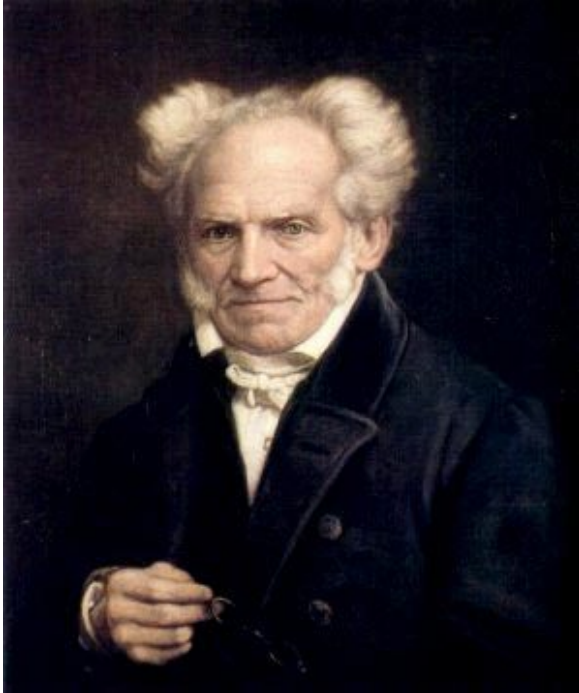
Kierkegaard became acquainted with Arthur Schopenhauer's writings quite late in his life. Kierkegaard felt Schopenhauer was an important writer, but disagreed on almost every point Schopenhauer made. In several journal entries made in 1854, a year before he died, Kierkegaard spoke highly of Schopenhauer:

In the same way that one disinfects the mouth during an epidemic so as not to be infected by breathing in the poisonous air, one might recommend students who will have to live in Denmark in an atmosphere of nonsensical Christian optimism, to take a little dose of Schopenhauer's Ethic in order to protect themselves against infection from that malodorous twaddle.

—Søren Kierkegaard, (Journals, 1854)*[6]

Kierkegaard became disillusioned with Schelling partly be-

However, Kierkegaard also considered him, *a most dangerous sign of things to come*:



Arthur Schopenhauer

Schopenhauer is so far from being a real pessimist that at the most he represents 'the interesting': in a certain sense he makes *asceticism* interesting--the most dangerous thing possible for a pleasure-seeking age which will be harmed more than ever by distilling pleasure even out of asceticism ...is by studying asceticism in a completely impersonal way, by assigning it a place in the system.

—Søren Kierkegaard, (Journals, 1854)* [6]

Kierkegaard believes Schopenhauer's ethical point of view is that the individual succeeds in seeing through the wretchedness of existence and then decides to deaden or mortify the joy of life. As a result of this complete asceticism, one reaches contemplation: the individual does this out of sympathy. He sympathizes with all the misery and the misery of others, which is to exist. Kierkegaard here is probably referring to the pessimistic nature of Schopenhauer's philosophy. One of Kierkegaard's main concerns is a suspicion of his whole philosophy:

After reading through Schopenhauer's Ethic one learns - naturally he is to that extent honest - that he himself is not an ascetic. And consequently he himself has not reached contemplation through asceticism, but only a contemplation which contemplates asceticism.

This is extremely suspicious, and may even conceal the most terrible and corrupting voluptuous *melancholy*: a profound *misanthropy*. In this too it is suspicious, for it is always suspicious to propound an ethic which does not exert so much power over the teacher that he himself expresses. Schopenhauer makes ethics into genius, but that is of course an unethical conception of ethics. He makes ethics into genius and although he prides himself quite enough on being a genius, it has not pleased him, or nature has not allowed him, to become a genius where asceticism and mortification are concerned.

—Søren Kierkegaard, (Journals, 1854)* [6]

Little else is known about Kierkegaard's attitude to Schopenhauer. On Schopenhauer himself, Kierkegaard felt that Schopenhauer would have been patronizing. "Schopenhauer interests me very much, as does his fate in Germany. If I could talk to him I am sure he would shudder or laugh if I were to show him [my philosophy]." (Journals, 1854)* [6]

8.4 Kierkegaard and Eastern philosophy

Because Kierkegaard read Schopenhauer, and because Schopenhauer was heavily influenced by Eastern philosophy, it would seem that Kierkegaard would have shown an awareness of Eastern philosophy. There is, however, little direct reference to Asian thought in Kierkegaard's writings. Anyone who is familiar with such Asian traditions as Buddhist, Taoist, or Shinto philosophy, will quickly see the philosophical similarities that Kierkegaard shares with these traditions. These similarities perhaps explain the Japanese reception of Kierkegaard and the fact that Japanese awareness and translations of Kierkegaard were appearing at least 30 years before any English translations.*[26] There is also extensive Japanese scholarship on Kierkegaard, a scholarship that interprets Kierkegaard's philosophy in terms of Asian thought.*[27] This interpretation is understandable when one sees that Kierkegaard's central concerns of subjectivity, anxiety, freedom, despair, and self-deception, are also of central concern to Buddhism and, consequently, that there is nothing exclusively Christian about such concerns.*[28] Both Kierkegaard and Zen Buddhism, for example, have seen the predicaments of existence in very similar ways.*[29] A specific example of the similarities here can be seen in *Purity of Heart* where Kierkegaard describes the state of awareness that one must enter in order to partake of confession. Kierkegaard's de-

scription of this state is similar to the state of meditation described by Buddhist philosophers.* [30] It is distinct, however, in that the aim of confession, for Kierkegaard, is “to center itself upon this relation to itself as an individual who is responsible to God” (cf. Kierkegaard, “Purity of Heart”).* [31] Kierkegaard aims to claim back the subject from the “crowd” mentality of Christendom (cf. Kierkegaard, “On the Dedication to ‘That Single Individual’”)* [32] and reaffirm the absolute responsibility to God, which is our *telos* (cf. Kierkegaard, “Fear and Trembling”)* [33]

Harald Hoffding (1843-1931) helped introduce Kierkegaard to Western Europe in the early years of the 20th century. He compared Kierkegaard to Eastern philosophy in his 1914 book *The Philosophy Of Religion* in this way:

A characteristic and very frequent type of religious faith is determined by the need of rest. The main cause of fatigue and exhaustion in life is chiefly unrest and distraction of mind. We are influenced on so many sides that it is difficult for us to collect our thoughts; we are drawn in so many directions that we find it difficult to focus our will on any one aim; so many different and changing feelings are aroused that the inner harmony of the mind is exposed to the danger of dissolution. Owing to this feeling of misfit with our ideal we experience an inner need, while our outer needs are borne in upon us in the guise of pain, frailty, and dependence on the elementary wants of life. In the *Upanishads* we find: “The Self (Atma), the sinless one, who redeems from old age, death, suffering, hunger, and thirst, whose wishes are the right ones and whose decree is the right one I am that self which men must inquire after and seek to know. He who has found and known this Self has attained all worlds and all wishes.” And in another place: “Save me, for I feel in this world’s life like a frog in a sealed fountain.” Jesus of Nazareth says: “Come unto me, all ye that labour and are heavy laden, and I will refresh you. Learn of me, and ye shall find rest for your souls.” “Unquiet is our heart,” says Augustine to his God, “until it find rest in Thee.” This need for rest rises to a passion in

natures such as St. Theresa, Pascal, and Soren Kierkegaard. There is no doubt an element of deep pathos in Augustine also, but in his case we have the Platonist and the prince of the church combined with the earnest seeker, and it is the combination of all these elements which renders him such a unique figure in the history of the religious life. St. Theresa felt the need of union with God so powerfully that death alone could satisfy it: “I knew not where else to seek this life but in death. The fish, drawn out of the water, sees at any rate the end of its torment; but what death can compare with the life in which I languish?”

With Kierkegaard, too, his great desire was to be released from the struggle of life. The lines which he desired should be inscribed on his gravestone express this longing: “A little while the search is over. The din of battle sounds no more.” In this life the believer finds himself in an alien element; between the inner and the outer, between life and its conditions there is a want of harmony. In Kierkegaard’s case, too, we get the metaphor of the fish out of water; it is characteristic of this type that the same figure should be employed by the ancient Indians in the *Upanishads*, by the Spanish nun of the sixteenth century, and by the northern thinker of the nineteenth century. This trait sheds a light on the psychology of religion. The aim of man is infinite, but he is condemned to spend his life in the world of finitude, and hence it follows that his existence acquires a sort of spasmodic character. In Kierkegaard, and even in Pascal, this opposition is more sharply brought out than in St. Theresa. In the latter it evokes longing and inner aspiration, but her will is occupied entirely by the highest object, and only her memory and her imagination are free to analyse her experiences. But both Pascal and Kierkegaard have constantly to summon the will to their aid; in their case they have a desperate struggle to keep themselves upright in face of

the harsh discord between the true life and the conditions of actual life; to hold fast to the thought of the object of faith and to resist the onslaughts of doubt. *The Philosophy Of Religion*, Dr. Harald Höffding p. 116-118, Translated from the German Edition, By B. E. Meyer 1914

8.5 See also

- Attributes of God in Christianity

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8.8 External links

- [D. Anthony Storm's Commentary On Kierkegaard](#)
- [Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy - Søren Kierkegaard](#)
- [Kierkegaard, Søren at DMOZ](#)

Chapter 9

Existential nihilism

Existential nihilism is the philosophical theory that life has no intrinsic meaning or value. With respect to the universe, existential nihilism posits that a single human or even the entire human species is insignificant, without purpose and unlikely to change in the totality of existence. According to the theory, each individual is an isolated being born into the universe, barred from knowing “why”, yet compelled to invent meaning.*[1] The inherent meaninglessness of life is largely explored in the philosophical school of **existentialism**, where one can potentially create their own subjective “meaning” or “purpose”. Of all types of **nihilism**, existential nihilism has received the most literary and philosophical attention.*[2]

9.1 Meaning of life

The idea that meaning and values are without foundation is a form of nihilism, and the existential response to that idea is noting that meaning is not “a matter of contemplative theory,” but instead, “a consequence of engagement and commitment.”

Jean-Paul Sartre, the author of *Being and Nothingness*, wrote in his essay *Existentialism and Humanism*, “What do we mean by saying that existence precedes essence? We mean that man first of all exists, encounters himself, surges up in the world – and defines himself afterwards. If man as the existentialist sees him as not definable, it is because to begin with he is nothing. He will not be anything until later, and then he will be what he makes of himself.” Here it is made clear what is meant by Existentialists when they say meaning is “a consequence of engagement and commitment”.

The theory purports to describe the human situation to create a life outlook and create meaning, which has been summarized as, “Strut, fret, and delude ourselves as we may, our lives are of no significance, and it is futile to seek or to affirm meaning where none can be found.”*[3] Existential nihilists claim that, to be honest, one must face the **absurdity** of existence, that he/she will eventually die, and

that both **religion** and **metaphysics** are simply results of the fear of death.*[2]

According to Donald A. Crosby, “There is no justification for life, but also no reason not to live. Those who claim to find meaning in their lives are either dishonest or deluded. In either case, they fail to face up to the harsh reality of the human situations”.*[3]

9.2 History

Existential nihilism has been a part of the Western intellectual tradition since the **Cyrenaics**, such as **Hegesias of Cyrene**. During the Renaissance, **William Shakespeare** eloquently summarized the existential nihilist's perspective through Macbeth's mindset in the end of the play. **Arthur Schopenhauer**, **Søren Kierkegaard** and **Friedrich Nietzsche** further expanded on these ideas, and Nietzsche, particularly, has become a major figure in existential nihilism.

The **atheistic existentialist** movement spread in 1940s France. Jean-Paul Sartre's *Being and Nothingness* and Albert Camus' *The Myth of Sisyphus* discussed the topic. Camus wrote further works, such as *The Stranger*, *Caligula*, *The Plague*, *The Fall* and *The Rebel*.*[1] Other figures include **Martin Heidegger** and **Jacques Derrida**. In addition, **Ernest Becker's** Pulitzer Prize winning life's work *The Denial of Death* is a collection of thoughts on existential nihilism.

The common thread in the literature of the existentialists is coping with the emotional anguish arising from our confrontation with nothingness, and they expended great energy responding to the question of whether surviving it was possible. Their answer was a qualified “Yes,” advocating a formula of passionate commitment and **impassive stoicism**.

—Alan Pratt*[1]

9.3 See also

- Absurdism
- Cosmicism
- Dysteleology
- Existence precedes essence
- Logotherapy
- *Man's Search for Meaning*
- Meaning of life
- Meaning (existential)

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